ForceCaptain is typing...

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/32578363.

Rating:
Explicit

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Catra (She-Ra)

Character:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Background & Cameo Characters, Entrapta (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Online Dating, Online Friendship, Friends to Lovers, Pining, Lesbian Adora (She-Ra), Lesbian Disaster Adora (She-Ra), Lesbian Catra (She-Ra), Lesbian Character, Lesbian Disaster Catra (She-Ra), Crushes, Long-Distance Friendship, Long-Distance Relationship, Self-Indulgent, Slice of Life, I'm using too much Discord, I love my online friends, But I don't want to date them, Alternate Universe - Modern Setting, Alternate Universe, Brazilian Catra, Eventual Smut, Eventual Romance, Phone Calls & Telephones, Phone Sex, Sexting, Silly references and easter-eggs

Language:
English

Collections:
Iorek's Catradora Unputdownables

Stats:
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ForceCaptain is typing...

by ButterfliesInMyBrain

Summary

“what are you doing up so late, shera?”

Adora glances at the clock on the left side of her computer screen. It’s 3:05 in the morning here, which means 9 AM on her end. She cant pinpoint exactly when this habit started, but the time conversion happens spontaneously in her brain now, without her even noticing that she’s doing it anymore.

Hands on the keyboard, she licks her lips like she's just been caught.

OR:

Online friendship turns to online crush which turns to... Who knows?)

OR:

I just want to write some fluff :)

Tags and ratings may change along the way.

Notes

Hello again!

So this very self-indulgent fluffy fic is a love letter to all the fantastic people from all over the world I have met in the SPOP fandom. So many talented, wonderful, kind and intelligent people around here, some of which I think I can consider as friends already, some of which I really hope to meet in person

someday. If we never do, well, this is my gift to you. You make a difference and you're awesome.

It should be a one-shot, but then I got creative and I'll probably have a few more chapters in. I'm currently overloaded with work, so I don't know how often I'll be able to update this, but I'm up for a low-stress silly story with little plot after I wrapped up my last fic :)

In all my stories I headcanon Catra as Brazilian and I will continue to do so, unless stated otherwise. Oh, and I've made a playlist too :)

I hope you have fun reading this. I had a great time writing it and I'd love to read your thoughts :)

Enjoy the chapter :)

See the end of the work for more notes

Buzz

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

2:20AM-3:30AM

Adora yawns and shakes her head, a cup of fresh coffee beside her. With heavy eyelids, she struggles against her physical exhaustion at the end of such a draining day -or a draining *week*, to be more accurate. It may be late, but this isnt the time to relax. Not yet, anyway. Tomorrow is too important for that. Besides, relaxing was never really Adora's thing. She's pretty sure that even if she went to bed now, she wouldnt be able to fall asleep. Her body may be tired, but her brain is too hyperactive and filled with concerns about her professional future to be able to rest.

Restless fingers drum across a page of her notebook, tracing the notes and diagrams scribbled all over it. From a distance, her office desk looks like an obstacle course in the middle of a war zone: books, sticky notes, magic markers, pens and pencils, headphones, flashcards and her laptop barely fit together on the tiny piece of furniture.

She is debating if she should take another look at her notes on eqine anatomy or canine behavior when her computer beeps. The familiar custom notification sound rings like Pavlov's bell to her ears, making her dispositions shift in an instant. Her lips are pulled into an instinctive smile, her heart is racing, and suddenly the idea of studying seems almost irrelevant.

So, full disclosure? Maybe Adora isn't up at this hour *just* to study for tomorrow's exam. Maybe there's something else keeping her awake.

The message pops up before her eyes and she senses her anxiety turning into *eagerness*.

“what are you doing up so late, shera?”

Adora glances at the clock on the left side of her computer screen. It’s 2:05 in the morning here, which means 9 AM on her end. She can’t pinpoint exactly when this habit started, but the time conversion happens spontaneously in her brain now, without her even noticing that she’s doing it anymore.

Hands on the keyboard, she licks her lips like she's just been caught.

“Busted. Can’t sleep.” She admits, fairly sure that she must be blushing and silently thanking the fact that she doesn’t have to show her face in this kind of interaction. “And good morning to you, ForceCaptain 😊”

“*morning. or…night. heh. whatever. time has no meaning.”*

“why can’t you sleep, though?”

“something wrong?”

All three messages flash at the same instant and there's something strangely gratifying about them. Adora is more used to taking care of her friends than the other way around, so having someone worried about her for a change is unusually endearing. ForceCaptain may be nothing more than an avatar on the internet but her concern feels real and comforting.

With a smile, Adora types.

“Thinking of.” She types, then deletes. “Anxious about.” She changes her mind again. “Just wanted to talk to yo.” *Nope*, won’t be saying *that*. “No, nothing wrong. I’m just very awake. 🤪 Thank you for asking! 😊”

For some reason, Adora’s fingertips are tingling when she presses the return key. A part of her feels silly with her cheeks burning up and all, as if she were a clueless teenager who can’t even

understand why she's so on edge to begin with. She takes another sip of her coffee, but of course that only accelerates her blood stream even more, as coffee is not exactly the kind of beverage you should drink when you want to stay *calm*.

Force Captain is typing…

Ah, there are those three insufferable little words again. Adora leans forward and flexes her fingers, her eyes glued to the torturous indicator showing at the bottom of her computer screen.

"are you nervous?" The question pops up after what feels like an eternity. *"about your licensing exam tomorrow , i mean."*

Yes, Adora is. Incredibly nervous, as a matter of fact. This exam has basically been the only thing on her mind all month, even more so these last few days.

"A little 😩" She replies, though *a little* is quite the understatement. She has been working all her adult life for this, and failing is not really an option in Adora's book. "I went over my notes like a million times already, but I still feel underprepared."

"relax, princess." Adora half-smiles at the suggestion, wishing it could be that simple, but feeling her body unclench at the same time. "*i mean, i know it's easier said than done, but try to take a deep breath, okay? it's a big day, so of course you're nervous, right? it's only natural. but i'm sure you've got this."*

Adora gives the advice a fair try. Obediently, she closes her eyes and counts her own breaths: from one to ten, then from ten to one - a coping mechanism she resorts to on occasion, whenever an anxiety attack threatens to creep up. One, two, three… after a few rounds, her heart rate starts to decrease.

"I hope so"…

“you're gonna do fine,” ForceCaptain adds, and Adora tries to believe her. *“this exam is all you've been talking about for the past month. if you study any harder, you're going to be brain damaged, I fucking swear.”*

With a light scoff, Adora grins. She may not have a lot of confidence in herself, but she decides to trust the words of her long-distance online friend. It's weird how easy it is to talk about her insecurities and vulnerabilities to a stranger she met playing online video games. Her best friends, Glimmer and Bow, are extremely supportive listeners, but ForceCaptain makes her feel less pressured, somehow.

“*i know it's normal to feel underprepared and whatever, but from what I know of you, i'm pretty sure you are way more prepared than you think*”

Adora's smile grows wider. Five, four, three, two. A final long exhale and she takes a good look at the pile of books lying around the table, at the insane number of notes and colorful stickers that stick out of almost every page. Her jaw unclenches and the tension accumulated in her upper back starts to ease.

Reassurance runs through her. She is ready.

“but if you dont go the fuckto sleep right now, you will end up passing out in the middle of the exam”. The comment makes Adora snort-laugh quietly. “*would be hilarious, but i thinkit would ruin your whole plan*”.

Leaning on one elbow, Adora rests her chin on her hand as her fingers stroke across her own cheek. “Yeah, yeah, I know… 😅 I know. You're right.”

“always am.”

And that sentence is what it takes for Adora to melt completely in her office chair. She is not willing to put too much thought into it, but she

briefly acknowledges how good she feels. So safe, so comforted, so… *happy*. How can a person she has never met have that effect on her?

"Thank you 😌"

"dont worry about it, dummy. did it help?"

"Yeah. It helped a lot, actually." Adora smiles and glances at the clock again, aware that she really should be sleeping, but at the same time unable to say goodbye. "Still sleepless, though."

Force Captain is typing…

"want to play a quickround of despondos to see if sleep comes to you? i bet i can kickyour princess ass in less than 5turns."

The light from Adora's computer screen illuminates her smile as it turns into a smirk. "Oh, yeah? We'll see about that."



The amazing [motherofchimeras](#) and [ramenfever](#) surprised me with this collab art piece and I have no words to thankthem :)

*

04AM 74AM

Click. Adora is laughing while snapping the photographs, so much so that they mainly come out as useless, shaky blurs. "No! Swifty, *no!* Ah- Bad, Swifty! Leave it alone!" She yells, and although she knows her laughter is definitely undermining her authority, she can't control herself.

Click. Click. Click.

Still chuckling, she reckons the pictures are good enough to send.

"The horror! 😱 I came home to find that Swifty ate all my notes! 😅"

The images show what's left of Adora's notebook after most of its pages were ripped to shreds; the shameless chaotic Beagle appears in the background, torn sheets of paper still in his mouth. Giggling, Adora cleans up her dog's mess and heads to the bathroom to take a shower, not expecting to get a response at this hour. It's seven AM wherever she is, and Adora already knows that ForceCaptain is far from a morning person.

But then…

ForceCaptain is typing…

Oh. *Oh!* Adora's heart bounces inside her chest.

She's awake!

"oh no, bad swifty," ForceCaptain replies. "*see, this is why i prefer cats.*"

Yeah, so, tonight Adora has learned that apparently one's mouth *can* hurt from smiling too wide.

Now realizing that she's standing in the middle of the hallway, Adora goes back to the office. Just before taking her seat, she glances at her newly framed veterinarian license on the wall.

A part of her still cant believe it’ s real.

"Y es, but the good news is.I .dont need any of these notes anymore!"

“that’s right, princess.” Adora smiles tenderly. *“you’re a licensed ert now. you can burn the rest of those notes if you want 🔥🔥”*

"Y aaaaaaaaaay!W ell, of course I won't do that LOL!"And in case you are wondering, while she types that line, Adora *is really* laughing out loud. "But it's nice to know that I CAN!"

“well, congratulations again, shera. you deserve it.” ForceCaptain replies, and Adora is taken over by a strong feeling of self-accomplishment. This, she knows, is not a common feeling, and one that she doesnt plan to take for granted. A proud smile hangs on her lips as she tries to find an animated GIF that can fully convey her joy , but none of the available options seem to account for what she feels.

Adora wishes they could be in the same room right now, savoring this victory together over drinks with Glimmer and Bow, or maybe even alone. This might be strange, but it isnt the first time such a wish has claimed her thoughts. As ForceCaptain progressively becomes a more constant presence in her life, Adora realizes she is beginning to occupy a more privileged place in her heart.

Which place exactly is it, however, is too soon to tell.

Adora moves the conversation to her laptop and checks the time again, furrowing her eyebrows when realizing how unprecedented it is for them to be talking at this specific hour. She didnt by any chance wake her friend up, did she?W ell, probably not-- when ForceCaptain is asleep she usually replies a few hours later. But of course, now that Adora contemplated that possibility, she wont stop thinking about it until she asks.

“Hey. I didnt wake you, did I? I just noticed it's super early in your time zone.”

“no, youre good.” Adora exhales in relief. “*the cat me woke me up a while ago. i was just getting out of bed to make some coffee.”*

“☕”

Adora beams a little smugly at the screen, feeling good about her cunning emoj reaction choice.

“what about u, were you out celebrating?”

Adora’s fingers run through her own hair to undo her ponytail;she tucks some loose blond strands behind her ear to keep them from her face.

“Yeah, sort of!I went out with my friends Glimmer and Bow!Or… That was the plan. But there was not that much to do in the middle of the week, sooooo we just hung out and binge-watched the first season of Following the Peekablues 😳😳”

She also sipped a glass of celebratory sparkling wine, but they dont seem worth mentioning.

“you seriously need better friends.”

“*watching reality trash about superficial rich people is hardly what I would call a decent celebration.”*

Although Adora cant see her counterpart’ s expression, and despite the fact that she doesnt even know what her face looks like to begin with, she imagines that ForceCaptain is rolling her eyes on her side of the conversation, a grumpy smirk showing on her lips.

“but Im glad you had fun.”

It crosses Adora's mind to ask ForceCaptain what she would consider to be a *decent celebration*, and it's not clear why she refrains herself from actually posing the question.

"I did! And well, it is only T uesday, so it's not like we had a lot of options 😅"

"even so, there are better things you could watch that are more worthy of your time and your brain functions. assuming you have any, that is."

Adora snorts, and an offended "seriously?" escapes her lips.

"Oh, yeah!? And what would you suggest for me to watch, oh thou creature of immaculate intellect?" She grins wickedly before sending the next message, as she knows she is about to push one of ForceCaptain's most sensitive buttons. "Mara"?

ForceCaptain is typing…

With a smile, Adora braces herself for the testy reaction she *knows* she is about to get.

"oh, shera. you really dont want to go there. i would hate to be the one who crushes your spirit on a day you should be feeling good about yourself."

"but you know you cant even begin to compare those two things, right? i mean, one of them is an iconic workof art and the other is a piece of pure junk"

Biting her lower lip, Adora realizes how much she relishes this dynamic of theirs – mutual teasing and friendly banter , each of them trying to poke the other one's most competitive side.

"Oh, I wouldnt go so far as to call Mara a piece of pure junk, but now that you mentioned it, I guess I agree!"

“”…

“dont push me, princess.”

Triumphant, Adora beams and wonders how her friend must look now. Frustrated? Challenging? Playful? Sleepy? Why cant she stop trying to picture it?

“I’m just saying, everyone deserves to have a way of turning off their brains without feeling judged about it.”

The next reply takes a little longer than usual to show up.

“yeah. of course.”

“that’s fair.”

“im sorry.”

Adora reads into ForceCaptain’s apologetic tone and realizes that she probably sounded more serious than originally planned. After all, it’s not like her counterpart can see the way she’s smirking at the screen, right? Ugh, online interactions are *hard*. She takes her index finger and thumb to her lips, pinching them lightly before typing again.

“You know I'm just messing with you, right? 😜”

A few more seconds.

“*well. even so, you’re right. no one should feel guilty for appreciating something.”* She replies, and Adora is glad that they can agree on that. “*and since we’re on the subject, you should really watch mara one of these days. it’s seriously a crime you never watched it and i fucking swear that you’re gonna like it. if you dont, at least you can tease me about it with actual knowledge.”*

She smiles as they bounce back into one of ForceCaptain's favorite topics: *Mara, the Dragon Tamer* and how Adora has never seen it.

A warm feeling settles into Adora's chest, the way it always does when they are talking to each other. If it matters that much to her friend, she might as well give the 25-year-old television show a chance. At the very least, she will get to know her a little bit better, and that's always something to look forward to.

"Ok, ok, Ill tell you what." A fair bargain crosses her mind. "I'll watch Mara if you tell me your real name."

Shera and *ForceCaptain* met when they were the two last remaining contenders at *The Battle of Eight Moon*, a competitive tournament of the strategy video game *Escape to Despondos*, about four months ago. After Adora emerged victorious from that glorious match, they began playing together regularly, though always on opposite sides. That arrangement lasted for two months before they decided to move their conversation to instant messaging apps.

Since then, they've been talking to each other almost every day. But other than her pronouns, her time zone, her television, music and literary preferences, Adora doesn't know a lot about her friend's true identity.

And come to think of it, even though she usually overshares about her own life, Adora has never disclosed her own name either.

ForceCaptain is typing…

A quick look at the clock. The excruciating seconds turn into a full minute, then two, then three. This may be the longest time it has ever taken her to respond to one of Adora's messages.

"well played, shera."

Adora smiles. "Sooooo, ForceCaptain… 😏 What's it gonna be?"

“you know ill quiz your knowledge afterwards, so you wont be able to trick me.”

“I promise I'll watch it! I give you my princess word of honor  You can quiz me all you like.”

Forceful Captain is typing…

Adora is so ridiculously nervous all of a sudden, giggling and biting her lips like a child about to receive a much-desired Christmas gift.

She feels Swifty’s wet nose against her fidgeting fingers, then his tongue and teeth trying to bite off the hair tie wrapped around her wrist. “Hey, no! Swifty, cut it out!” Adora’s still prying the dog away when she hears the familiar *beep* that pumps a renewed surge of adrenaline through her veins.

“my name’s catra.”

The newly licensed veterinarian grins widely.

“Catra,” she says out loud, as if to make sure that the name sounds real. Such a unique, interesting name. Adora decides that she loves how it sounds. “Ca-tra,” she repeats, happy to finally put a name to the catgirl profile picture.

“Hi, Catra!” She greets with a dorky smile, and because it's only fair that she repays the favor... “Adora here.”

“hey, adora.”

“Heh.

Okay. Adora senses her hands getting clammy, but they couldn't possibly be sweating, because that wouldn't make any sense, right? She couldn't be sweating over words written on her computer screen by someone she barely knows, someone who might not even be real.

Could she?

No, it's probably just Swifty's slobber. It would be stupid to get this excited over a silly thing like an online friend calling her by her real name.

"Thank you for trusting me."

"well, you've earned it, dummy."

"don't make it weird."

Oh, but it's a little too late for that.

*

5:30 AM

Beep.

A sequence of messages pops up on Adora's phone.

"*hey.*"

"sorry for texting you so early. are you there?"

Adora has always been an early riser. More than that, she is the kind of person who actually *enjoys* mornings. It is the time of day when she is most productive, which is why she tends to organize her schedule in a way that most of her activities happen in the morning.

After three months interacting nearly every day, she's pretty sure that Catra already knows all of that. Even so, she still asks if Adora's available whenever she is the first of the two to start a conversation, and Adora thinks that is extremely sweet.

Her answer is a photo of her overly excited Beagle holding his leash in his mouth.

"I'm about to go jogging with Swifty in the park near my apartment!" She finishes typing the message and chooses her *Songs that make you feel like you're eight-foot-tall* playlist as the soundtrack to her morning workout.

Ponytail up, trainers and earbuds on, and Adora's ready for another day. The phone is still in her hand when it vibrates again.

"*oh ok*"

"i admire your bravery , haha."

"have fun."

"I'll be taking my phone with me if you want to keep talking! 😊" Adora types as she heads to the door. "How has your day been treating you so far?"

"eh, cant complain."

Force Captain is typing…

Adora takes the elevator and greets her neighbors without really taking her eyes off her cell phone.

I have a meeting with an editor in a few hours, they're going to give me feedback on a manuscript I sent them some time ago."

"That is awesome, Catra!" Adora is beaming with pride while she types the message.

The elevator stops on the ground floor, and the door opens. With her eyes still glued to the screen, Adora walks across her building's lobby. "What's the manuscript about? Wait, no. Okay, she is super curious, because up until very recently she didn't even know that Catra is a published novelist, but she quickly realizes that this interaction is not about the content of the manuscript. Catra may not be very forthcoming about her emotions, but Adora senses that this

is about her state of mind. "Hey, I'm sure it will be great. I'm so excited for you!"

After nearly banging her head against a pay phone, Adora figures that looking straight ahead is probably a good idea. She crosses the street and walks another block to reach the entrance to the Whispering Woods Park, humming along to the song playing in her ears while Swifty leads the way.

Her heart flips over when she feels her phone vibrating in her waist pack.

"thanks."

"*it's kind of a big deal to me."*

"i hope i dont screw it up."

"i have a talent for messing up good things, so"…

Adora feels as if her heart has shrunk in size, immediately seized by an overwhelming urge to hold Catra. Her arms clench and she finds herself wondering how it would actually feel. To hold her, I mean. What is Catra's body like? Tall, short, wide, thin? How is it molded? Triangle, round, pear, hourglass? How would it feel against her skin? Would she like being held by Adora or would she resist the touch? Would she surrender to her embrace and feel safe in Adora's arms? Would their bodies make a good fit? Adora wants to think they would.

But this is not what she should be thinking. No, it absolutely isn't. With an exhale, she pushes away those useless thoughts and focuses on what matters.

"You won't screw it up. You will do great and then brag to me about how impressed they were with you."

"*haha, i wouldnt bet on it."*

“but well see.”

They may not have known each other for *that* long, but Catra was there during very stressful moments of Adora’s year – her licensing exam, the discovery of Swifty’s heart condition, her search for a new apartment. Even if only virtually, Catra has been a constant and meaningful presence in her life, one she found she could rely on.

More than a feeling of inherited debt, Adora wants her good friend to feel as comforted and reassured about herself as she deserves to be.

She knows she can’t physically embrace Catra, but she still wants her to *feel* embraced.

So, instead of hugging...

“Do you want to talk about it? Maybe I can help.” She releases Swifty in the dog playground and finds a bench. “I don’t know anything about the publishing industry, but I know a thing or two about strategy, as you know 😉”

“hah!”

“oh, please, just because i let you win in despondos a couple of times, don’t think you’re all sun-tzu or whatever.”

“Don’t be a sore loser, force captain Catra.”

“bite me, princess.”

The next hour is spent with Adora trying to distract Catra with silly jokes and discussing her fear of failure, and it seems to be working well. It’s admittedly hard to tell through a screen, but from what she knows about Catra, she seems more relaxed.

A random stray cat jumps on the bench and curls up in Adora’s lap, and she thinks it’s a good idea to send Catra a picture. “Is this why

you prefer cats?"

When Catra's answer doesn't come, Adora starts to second-guess her impulse.

It's the first time they exchange any visual evidence of their real existence, and she is suddenly *very* self-conscious about how she looks.

Oh, Lord. *Why didn't she think this through?*

She rechecks the image she just sent. Does she look sweaty? Is there something on her face? Is her hair poof in place? Does her smile look natural enough? Is she showing too much cleavage? Will Catra think she looks good?

Wait, wait, time out. Why should Adora care? They are just friends trying to boost each other's confidence and cheer each other up. There's nothing more to it.

Right. Right! Friends. *Ahem*.

Of course.

Beep. Adora's cell phone vibrates and her entire body actually *shivers.*

"holy shit, adora." Is Catra's response, and Adora's eyes widen at the comment. Then, after another few excruciating seconds…

"you definitely gave me something else to think about now."

Adora's breath is caught in a hitch, she takes her hand to her chest. Her tingling fingertips sense just how fast her heart is beating, the cat in her lap stares at her curiously.

She has no idea how she's supposed to reply. In fact, she has no idea how she's supposed to fucking *breathe*. She stands up (the cat is not amused with this decision) and walks from side to side, one

hand holding her phone, the other holding her chin as she tries to figure out what to say.

"LOL! I bet." "No, too goofy." "Oh, so you think I am." "Too smug." "Glad to be of service." "Oh, for fuck's sake, Adora, *snap out of it*. This reaction is *surreal*. Her brain is clearly misinterpreting the signs her body is sending her.

"I hope that's a good thing 😊"

When the cell phone *beeps* again, she almost tosses it on the floor in sheer panic.

"well, i have to say that it is."

"the cat left a really good impression."

Adora is still too nervous, but a smirk starts to show on her lips. "The cat, huh?"

"yeah, obviously."

"you know how i feel about great looking cats."

It's an indirect compliment at best, but Adora accepts it. With her cheeks heating up, her tension turns to a rush of *exhilaration* she vaguely recognizes. This is a highly magnified, superpowered version of how she feels when she's *attracted* to someone.

But that wouldn't make sense, would it? She couldn't be attracted to Catra. How could she? No. No! That would be ludicrous.

"shit, i have to go, meeting's about to start."

Adora smiles warmly. "Good luck! 🤞 You're gonna crush it." She bites her lower lip. "In a good way, of course."

"thanks, princess. ill tell you all about it later."

And as Adora notices just how fast her heart is beating, how dry her mouth is, and how weak her knees are, she realizes that she’s positively, completely screwed.

There's no telling how many laps she'll need to run now.

But she knows it’s time to start running.



The amazing motherofchimeras and ramenfever made this lovely collab fanart piece and I have no words to thankthem :)

Chapter End Notes

@motherofchimeras and @ramenfever surprised me with this fantastic collab fan art piece <3 Check out their work, because they are both amazing.

Reaction

Chapter Notes

Hello, I am back! I hope you are good and staying healthy :)

I also hope you enjoy the fluff I have to give you. And while we're at it, I'd like to thank everyone who is posting comments and giving this story some praise :) You're all amazing!

Oh, of course I made a new playlist for this on Spotify.

Enjoy the chapter and thank you for reading!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

4:28 PM 4:29 PM

There are new messages from Glimmer, Juliet, and aunt Razz. Adora scrolls through the most recent notifications on her phone as she gets home from her first day of work at Pet Zone Hospital. She responds to some of the unread texts, but a specific joke that Glimmer made in the "Best Friends Squad" group chat distracts her from that task. Instead of answering, she snort-laughs and looks up another name in her contact list.

It's almost midnight where she lives, but Adora knows she's a bit of a night owl.

"My friends are saying you're not a real person."

Adora hits *send* just before being taken aback by Swifty's warm, wet and hyperactive welcome. His impatient paws come up to her waist, pushing her body backward and nearly making her lose her balance. With a startled laugh, she drops her cell phone on the buffet beside the door and crouches on the floor to greet him.

"Swifty! How was your day?" She says while the dog excitedly tries to climb up her thighs and lick her chin. The ticklish sensation has Adora chortling and panting in less than a minute. "Did uncle Kyle take you to the park? Did he take good care of you while I was gone? Hm? I hope he did! Otherwise, Ill kick his ass! Yes, I will! Yes, I will!"

They exchange loving smooches and snuggles, barks and silly baby-talk compliments for another moment, until the particular *beep* Adora was expecting makes her jump to her feet. Heart pounding with anticipation, she takes the device in her hands and heads for the kitchen. "Come on, let's get you some food!" She announces to the dog as she leads the way, and Swifty follows.

Catching her breath, Adora turns her attention to the screen.

"haha im not?" ForceCaptain's first message says, and a follow-up text flashes immediately after. *"and what gave them that ludicrous idea?"*

Adora has never been a very competent multitasker, but she somehow manages to juggle typing on the phone and pouring food into Swifty's bowl. Thank goodness for autocorrect. "They say I have no evidence of your real existence lolol."

The Beagle moves towards the food and starts to eat; Adora leans herself against the kitchen wall. "So they think I imagined you or something! 🐶"

"i see."

"they obviously put a lot of faith in that brain of yours huh."

"Of course they do, and with good reason." Adora's lips quiver and her eye twitches at the attempted tease. "But I told them I am not that creative! 😅😅"

"well, i cant really blame them."

"What do you mean? 👀"

"guess i would also have a hard time believing someone as amazing as me exists."

A nervous low chuckle escapes from Adora's throat because a part of her agrees. It *is* a little hard to believe that Catra is real.

No more than a week has passed since Adora's impulsive "photo reveal" in the park, and on that day something clearly shifted. Not between them exactly, but within herself. It's as if a switch has been flipped inside her, giving rise to a series of thoughts and needs that weren't there before.

On her lunch break or during her workouts, she finds herself daydreaming about Catra's whereabouts, her state of being, and her appearance. And it's not because she *cares* about her looks, and not only to give a face to the virtual presence she's growing more and more attached to. No, it's more because she is curious about all those little details that escape through another person's body language and facial expressions during a conversation.

Adora wonders if Catra smiles when they are talking, and what that smile looks like. She wonders about the way she moves, her attitude and her demeanor. From their conversations, Catra sends off this vibe, like she's the kind of person who looks like she owns the room just by walking in. But is that really the case? Does she gesticulate more when she's angry or excited? Is she outgoing and expansive or more quiet and reserved? Does she let her feelings show or does she try to hide her vulnerabilities?

Now that this dam has broken, the flood seems inevitable.

And Adora knows - she just *knows* - that if she keeps indulging in that line of thinking, if she keeps making room for the storm that is *clearly* on its way, it's going to get out of hand at some point.

So it really would be in her best interests to just *forget* all about it. Keep a safe distance and definitely don't get anymore involved.

"You dont say?" She types with a smirk, as forgetting doesn't seem to be an option. "Well, Im beginning to think you're all bark and no bite, force captain."

"u know"...

"it's funny you chose those words, princess."

Adora raises a smug eyebrow at the screen. "Oh, yeah? And why is that?"

Force Captain is typing...

"because..."

"i happen to be very into biting."

";)"

Uh.

Okay.

So, if Adora was a computer operating system, it would be showing a blue screen of death right about now. As she feels her nervous system collapse entirely, she's desperately trying to find the reboot button, but it's nowhere to be found. Whenever her brain resumes, she will curse herself for taking Catra's *obvious* bait like a rookie. But for now, all she can do is stare at her cell phone screen in dumbfounded bewilderment.

Adora's kind of glad she doesn't know what Catra looks like, otherwise, the image of her leaving bite marks along her neck and shoulder would be too strong to repress.

But wait. Hold on, why did *that* specific thought even cross Adora's mind? She's too short-circuited to wonder about this brief erotic indiscretion, but it will surely haunt her dreams later.

When the next message arrives, it sends an electric jolt up and down her spine, covering her skin with goosebumps. And if our girl thought the last interaction would be the greatest heart-attack-inducing moment of the evening, she is about to discover that her prediction may have been hasty.

Because Catra's next message is a picture file.

Adora's breath catches. She touches the screen to reveal the image.

At the first glimpse, her jaw drops. "Wow!" She exhales out loud. Her left-hand closes in a tight fist and presses against the tile wall behind her.

What she sees first are Catra's eyes. Cat-like, expressive, and penetrating, they are poignantly magnetic and of different colors: the right is cerulean blue and the left is golden as vibrant honey. They look a little tired and heavy, probably showing the effect of a long day of work, but that doesn't make them any less beautiful. On the contrary, Adora has never seen eyes like these, and she's so entranced by that powerful stare that it takes her a while to be able to look away. One of her eyebrows is slightly raised as if she is perfectly aware of her own ability to *trap* someone with a single glance.

Yeah. Adora wouldn't mind being trapped by her if she's being brutally honest.

Below Catra's eyes are her high and pronounced cheekbones. They are covered in countless freckles, which is a cute and endearing detail that could go unnoticed, as the spots are so subtle they seem to melt into her tawny skin. A discrete dimple draws a curve next to her upturned nose and right above her lips. Long and thin, those are turned in a defiant half-smile that makes Adora's stomach churn. Her

face is framed by long and unruly hair. Like a lion's mane, it covers her ears, and some wild strands are falling over her forehead.

Her body doesn't show up in the picture, but under her chin, she's holding a pink Post-it that has "Hi Adora" scrawled on it. Adora smiles at the cute gesture like the smitten idiot that she is.

Adora's kitchen floor feels like quicksand all of a sudden.

"Wow." She sighs again, swallowing nervously and shaking her head to snap herself out of that baffled state. "Fuck. Wow."

Catra is, to put it simply, gorgeous. I mean, *really* gorgeous. Hmm. Once again, Adora finds herself swarmed with conflicting emotions and all kinds of sensations. The brewing storm inside her chest is about to get out of hand, and she can already feel its waves coming.

Meanwhile, she realizes that she should probably say something.

How much time has passed, anyway?

Oh, fuck.

Force Captain is typing…

Oh, fuck!

Mouth dry, Adora's heart flips over when her cell phone vibrates again.

"there."

"that real enough for you and your nerd friends?"

Maybe a little too real, Adora reckons.

"or do you need more evidence?"

Well, she definitely wouldn't mind *that*.

"OMG has the temperature -"Okay , no. Adora hesitates, almost certain that anything she says will be a complete disaster. She's particularly bad at being suave, and it's even worse when she's nervous. "Wow, is there something wrong with my eyes?! Because I can't stop starin-"Ugh, no!Come on, Adora, what's your problem?

She decides to try some breathing exercises to regain her sanity.

Slowly, it begins to work.

"Yes, they will be pleased to have confirmation that you exist,"She manages to type, at last. And because she can't contain the truth that's simmering inside her any longer, she decides to add: "You're beautiful, btw."

Her eyes are closed when her thumb presses *send*.

Honesty is always the best strategy in Adora's opinion, but it's also a risky one. The two of them exchange a lot of double entendre jokes in their occasional banter, but Adora doesn't officially *know* if Catra… well... if she walks on the queer side of the street, so to speak. She has her suspicions, of course, but nothing has been explicitly stated one way or another by any of them. The closest she came to confirmation was Catra's reaction to her own photo, as you may remember.

So, after sending the message, Adora is once again in a state of agony, afraid that she might have jumped the gun.

"oh princess."

"you're going to make me blush here." Catra replies in her typical teasing manner, and although Adora is *considerably* less tense than she was a few minutes ago, she feels her skin warming up from the inside out.

";)"

Shit. Are they flirting? Is that something they do now?

If so, should Adora take it seriously? Probably not.

Fortunately, Catra's next message strays from the subject, taking the conversation to more familiar and harmless terrain.

“so how was your first day at work?”

A little more recomposed, Adora smiles. Fear of heart failure aside, she's happy to finally put a face to Catra's messages.

She takes off her white coat and makes her way to the laundry room.

“Ohhhh it was amazing! 😆 So many cute puppies!”

“that’s good :)”

“wanna tell me more about it?”

I dont need to tell you that Adora will say yes.

1:37 PM 1:38 PM

The raspberry smoothie runs out; the disposable cup goes to the trash. Adora reaches into her coat pocket for her office keys, absently whistling a song that has been stuck in her head since Catra showed it to her. The melody blends with the indistinct barks that come from the canine rehab center and the grooming stations as she marches through the hallways. A nod here, a “good afternoon, doc!” there, and she quickens her step, hoping to enjoy what's left of her lunch break in the comfort of her office chair.

The young veterinarian is already behind her desk when her cell phone buzzes inside her pocket. Her heart rate picks up when she realizes *whose* message she just received.

“hey,” ForceCaptain says, and before Adora even has time to react...

“so...guess what.”

It’s not really difficult to make Adora smile, but there are only a few things that are guaranteed to bring a wide, effortless and sincere grin to her lips. Horses. Puppies. A large scoop of strawberry ice cream on a hot summer day. Rainbows. Bow and Glimmer bickering about what movie to watch. That hilarious Totino’s ad parody featuring Kristen Stewart.

But lately?

“Dryl games decided to give you a silver medal for being despondos second best player? 😉”

Lately, the reason for most of Adora's dumb smiles is this sentence:

Force Captain is typing…

Elbows on the table, Adora leans forward and toward the cell phone screen as if to increase contact between them.

“hah!”

“very cute, princess.”

Adora bashfully turns her gaze away from the screen. Since she became aware that her feelings for Catra may be a little more than just a casual online friendship, and especially since she saw how freaking hot Catra is, that kind of comment has been able to turn her into a small puddle of sapphic wishful thinking. The thought of Catra finding her cute, even if only in a comic context, hits her poor lesbian heart like a soft shock.

With a sigh and a quick glance at the clock, Adora recomposes.

Well, barely.

“Why thank you, force captain 😉” “Oh, she is just *hopeless*. “Am I right though?”

“🥈 ?

“oh please.” Catra replies.

“ur just embarrassing yourself.”

Her fingers are quick to type the response. “No! Really?! Ughhh! I was so sure I had nailed it 🤪”

“yeah yeah, arent you so funny.”

“anyway, stop being a dorkfor a minute and checkthis out:”

What comes next is a screenshot showing a partial email exchange between Catra and an editor at the publisher who has expressed interest in her manuscript.

“Re: Manuscript submission - Remember ’

From: Melossa S <boomnets.ed@mindchime.com>

Dear Catra,

As we discussed at our last meeting, here is the agreement. I hope youll find everything is in order.

This Agreement shall constitute the understanding between Catra Queiroz, pen name Cyra KLynx, (“Creator”) and Wind Chime Publishings (“Publisher”), located at 611 Interpertinger Road, Beron, with respect to the above mentioned literary workprovisionally entitled “Remember.” As described in Paragraph 6below, copyright in the referenced literary workwill remain in the name of the Creator. As used herein, “Property” means the aforementioned literary workcreated and/or to be

created by the Creator entitled Remember" and "Work" means the Property in the form of a book, including hardcover and softcover bookforms, and electronic bookforms."

Adora reads the email thoroughly and carefully. When she's done, she reads it again. She wants to take in every detail Catra is giving her, every sentence. And with each word, her chest swells, filled with excitement and second-hand pride at Catra's conquest.

"OMG they offered you a book deal!!! Fuuuckkk Catra, this is huuuuuge! 😸😸"

This is another one of those moments when Adora feels that text messaging isn't enough contact. She wants... more. More substance than just cold bytes and insipid characters on a screen. She wants her physical presence. She wants to smell, see, hear, and maybe most of all, touch.

She wants…

Ugh.

She does her best to swallow it all down.

"Congratulations!"

"thanks :)" ForceCaptain says in response, and Adora beams proudly. *"ill have a lawyer take a better look at the agreement but it seems pretty decent as far as i can tell."*

"That's even more amazing. How are you feeling?" To be frank, Adora herself feels like she is about to combust. "You must be so excited!"

"fuckyeah, are you kidding me?" The reply comes after a brief second. *"i could literally blow something up here."*

Adora snort-laughs, trying to picture the expression that Catra's probably wearing right now. Her eyes are probably sparkling with joy. She must be so thrilled, so happy. As happy as she deserves to be, as happy as Adora wants her to be.

"Lololol I imagine you mean that as a good thing?"

"well, duh. obviously." Catra responds, and Adora rolls her eyes. *"about fucking time someone gave me a real chance to kickass internationally."*

There's something about Catra's confident bravado that Adora finds both charming and inspiring. Just two weeks ago, this girl seemed so fragile, so worried about the outcome of that meeting, afraid that her poor social skills could jeopardize her prospects. She knows her own weaknesses, that goes without saying. But at the same time, Catra knows her strengths and has no doubt about the value of her own work. She understands its worth and stands by it, even if other people fail to recognize it.

It's admirable.

And incredibly attractive.

"Right. Of course." Adora agrees, smiling fondly at the screen. "They are the lucky ones in this deal." The words may seem sarcastic in the context of their friendly competitiveness, but Adora truly means them.

"damn right they are." Catra replies almost immediately.

"seriously though, all jokes aside, it will be my first time publishing in english so that's a major thing."

"it's the big breakive been hoping for."

Adora's thumb instinctively slides across the screen, pressing it gently, almost stroking it.

"You deserve it. Really." Adora says, hoping that Catra will be able to capture the sincerity and tenderness she's putting behind her words. Then, with a hint of mischief, she adds: "I mean, at least I suppose you do. I would know for sure if only you showed me your work 🙄"

"Maybe now that you're writing in english and I can actually read it"…

This has been a recurring request since Catra told Adora what she does for a living. Adora even tried searching for her books online once, to no avail. Aside from the language barrier, she didn't know Catra's last name, let alone that she uses a pseudonym. At some point, she decided that Catra would show her work when she felt she was ready for it.

Of course, it didn't prevent her from asking.

"hahaha, very subtle, princess." She replies after a quick instant. *"and duly noted."*

"Ah, it was worth a shot." Adora groans, mildly disappointed. "Unless you're afraid to have your book appraised by a literary genius like me 🤪"

"haha, you're on fire today."

"but..."

"whatever, if you are being serious about it, i might take you up on that."

A candid grin appears on Adora's lips, another one of those foolish smiles. "Really?! ♡♡ That would be amaz-" Hm, maybe that's a little too much. "Of course I'm being serious about it!"

"good :) im very self conscious about my written english so i guess it could help to have an extra set of eyes."

"Yyaaaaaaaaayyyy!" In her seat, Adora does a celebratory shoulder shake. "I'm happy to help!"

"also..."

"well"...

Adora cant tell whether Catra' s tone is meant to be suspenseful or bashful, but she's definitely dragging out whatever she wants to say.

Force Captain is typing…

The follow-up message doesnt come right away . Adora watches the minutes tick by, her anxiety growing within her. The clock hits 2 pm, sealing the end of her lunch and the start of her afternoon shift. She's about to text Catra goodbye when the phone rings again.

"it would mean a lot to me."

"id love to hear your thoughts about it," Catra says, earning another grin from Adora's lips.

"And I will love to share them with you 😊" Adora replies, choosing to ignore the myriad of symptoms that are trying to warn her about the mess she is deliberately getting herself into.

"of course"...

"im assuming you are able to formulate any kind of coherent thinking."

"but that remains to be determined."

Oh, this little shit, Adora could just smack her . She snarls in offended outrage.

"That' s a very unusual way of asking for someone's opinion, force captain."

“sorry.”

“cant be seen fraternizing with a princess.” Catra says, and Adora chuckles, fiddling with the tip of her ponytail.

“that would not be good for my brand.”

“Don't worry . Ill keep your secret safe and sound.” A knock on the door disturbs her train of thought. “Hey , sorry, I have to go. My shift is about to start. But feel free to send it to my email whenever you're ready: adora.grayskull@gmail.com.”

“okthxi will.”

“good afternoon and whatnot.”

“Thanks! You too.” Adora is already on her feet and heading for the door when she types her last message. “Quick match later to celebrate your big accomplishment?”

“count on it.”

5:47 AM

The television is on and the credits roll over dramatic music. Adora, Glimmer, and Bow are all stunned by what they just saw . Adora is sitting on the floor, her back leans against the couch her friends are on, and Glimmer’s fingers run through her hair on occasion.

Palpable tension hangs in the air as they all stare in silence. The TV screen turns black.

“What!? Did it stop? *Why* did it stop?” Bow asks in a shrill voice, biting his nails nervously. “Someone please, please tell me this isnt the last episode!” he begs, and Glimmer takes the remote to look into the Crystal Castle catalog.

“No, no, no, it cant be! This show has like... seven seasons, I think!” Adora says, also with a slightly altered voice. “Quickly scrolling

through her phone, she adds. "Yes, seven seasons!"

"Shit, they only have seasons one and two on Crystal Castle." Glimmer reveals, causing Adora and Bow to gasp in shock. "Hold on, I'm gonna check if they have it available on Flix Portal. Ugh! I hate that platform!"

"Oh, no, don't even open Portal! I just checked, it's not there either." Bow says, focused on his phone. "But *how* are we going to watch season three!? Guys, this is serious, I have to know what happens!"

"Calm down, Bow, if it's not available on any streaming service we can always just download it." Glimmer replies reassuringly, controlling herself not to laugh at her boyfriend's despair. "Besides, Hope can't really be dead, right?" She says skeptically. "I mean, they never showed her body. Maybe she is just trapped in the Dragon realm."

Sharing her best friend's agony, Adora finds ForceCaptain's name on her contact list. "Ok, we just finished season 2, please please PLEASE tell me Hope is alive!"

After a full weekend watching *Mara, The Dragon Tamer* without a break, Bow and Glimmer are just as hooked as Adora is. Helping themselves to a slice of chocolate cake, they keep speculating about the future of the series, while Adora remains in her place on the floor, waiting for Catra's answer.

"Glimmer, but *how* would she survive this!?" Bow asks, his tone is concerned and incredulous.

"You know it's a fantasy show, right? There are literally dragons in it," Glimmer mocks, and Adora would find their whole conversation entertaining if she wasn't also concerned about the welfare of a fictional character. "If you are okay with dragons, a person coming back from the dead is no big deal."

Adora's phone vibrates, the *beep* makes her pupils go wide.

“what was that?”

“huh. funny.”

“that didn’t sound much like an apology to me...”

The corner of Adora’s lip lifts up, and for a moment she forgets why she was so hysterical a second ago. “I have no idea what you’re talking about.”She teases.

“oh, ok.”

“i guess you don’t want me to answer about hope then.”

“Oh, that was low .”Adora snorts at the blatant attempted blackmail. “Even for you.”

“awww, princess, you should know by now that nothing is too low for me.”

“come on, be a good girl and say you’re sorry.”

“I have nothing to apologize for ."Adora writes stubbornly , the sound of Glimmer and Bow's voices fading into the background like white noise.

“suit yourself.”

“good luck trying to find season three!”

“spoiler alert: it’s not available anywhere and it’s super hard to find.”

Adora groans and rolls her eyes. “Ugh!”

“Ok, ok, fine! I’m sorry . I loved it! It’s amazing and my mind is blown! Happy?”

“...and?”

"And you were right 😊 "She types somewhat reluctantly .

"*now was that so hard?"*

"You know, the only thing worse than a sore loser is a bad winner!" Adora smiles and readjusts her position on the floor to make room for Glimmer and Bow to sit on the couch again. "And you happen to be both."

"whatever , i still won."

"Now can you pleeeease tell me? 😟"Adora pleads. "I don't want to search it online and accidentally spoil myself with other stuff."

"well"…

"askyourself this."

Force Captain is typing…

Adora stares at the screen without moving an inch, nervous with anticipation.

"do you really thinki would tell you?"

"Uuuuugh!Seriously?"She groans out loud, catching Glimmer and Bow's attention. They watch her type the next message. "You're a pain in the ass, did you know that?"

"please."

"now that's just rude."

"ok.. ill give you this: did they show hope' s body?"

Adora laughs at her cell phone screen and turns her head slightly to look at Glimmer, catching her gaze. "Hey , that's what Glimmer just said!"She types.

“well, i wont give you anything else, but your friend may be onto something.”

“Great, thanks for making me even more curious!”

“relax, dummy , i have the whole series on my computer , i can share them with you.”

With a tender smile on her face, Adora replies. “That would be amazing, thanks!”

Glimmer’s inquisitive face appears from behind her shoulder . She’s not close enough to read Catra’s messages, but Adora instinctively covers the phone with her hand to protect the content. Glimmer rolls her eyes and teasingly sticks her tongue out.

“Ugh! Fine, Ill give you and your crush some privacy .” She pulls away and snuggles up with Bow.

“*Pffft what!* Catra’s not my crush!” Adora protests, turning to face Glimmer.

“Right, and Im the queen of Bright Moon.” Glimmer replies with a sly smile, and Bow chuckles along with her.

“Just!” Adora grimaces. “Ugh. I'll be right back. Im gonna get some water.”

“Oh, can you bring me some, please?” Glimmer asks, and Adora nods in agreement.

With her phone in her hand, Adora gets up and heads for the kitchen. It doesn't take long for the device to vibrate against her palm.

“no problem.”

Now standing in Glimmer’s kitchen, Adora looks for an empty glass and fills it with water. She’s halfway through when a new message

pops up.

“hey btw thankyou for sending me your notes.”

“i really appreciate it.”

Again, Adora wonders. If she could look at Catra right now, what sort of reaction she would see? How would her gratitude appear on her face? With a blush? With a smile? Perhaps both.

“Sure! It was my pleasure! ☺️”

She’s the one who’s grateful, actually.

Catra asking her to beta-read the first chapter of her book was an important demonstration of confidence on her part, and Adora plans to value that trust. It also helps that her prose is exquisite. Despite a few slip-ups in grammar, she is a highly-skilled writer with an endearing style. Some of the most impactful quotes stayed in Adora's head for days. With each passing day, she feels luckier to have met Catra. Honored.

Her phone vibrates letting her know another message has arrived.

“ill read it first thing tomorrow .”

“Hope you find my notes useful!”

“im sure i will.”

Adora giggles, feeling like she’s made of liquid, a proud smile hanging on her face.

“but im kind of in the middle of something right now .”

“can we talkmore later?”

“Oh! Sure!” Adora types as she fills Glimmer ’s glass with water. “Are you doing something fun, I hope?”

“yeah, it’s alright. so far so good.”

“And what are you up to, if you want to say? 😊”

Force Captain is typing…

Naturally, when Adora asked this very simple question, she expected to be happy with whatever answer Catra could possibly give her. I mean, she honestly did. If someone you care about is having fun, happiness is what you should feel for them, right?

When you like someone, you should want what’s best for them. Their happiness is your happiness. Regardless of the context, this is what should really matter. Or, at least, Adora would like to consider herself as the kind of selfless and altruistic person who would have that generous approach to life and relationships.

Bep. Adora's eyes widen.

“i have someone over.”

Yeah, but this... this isn't what happiness feels like.

“Oh!”

Nope.

That knot in her stomach when she imagines Catra being with someone else, that twinge of unwarranted possessiveness that makes her bile rise in her throat...

It feels a lot like *jealousy*.

“a friend of mine from out of town is visiting.” The next message says, and Adora gasps when she notices that the water is already overflowing the glass. *“we’re having drinks and watching a movie.”*

Feeling stupid, Adora reads the message once, twice, three times before her muscles begin to unclench. And yes, she could try to

keep denying it, try to repress it, try to pretend she can't see the obvious signs right in front of her, but it would be useless.

Her reaction was crystal clear .

The storm Adora feared isn't just brewing.

Oh, no. That shit is already here to stay.

Chapter End Notes

If you've never seen the SNL Totino's skit with Kristen Stewart , please do.

Also: NO PORTALS!Let's see how many inside jokes I can fit into this fic until it ends.

Thank you for reading!

Ring

Chapter Notes

Hello!:)

I have returned with some fluff.
...And maybe more.

Sorry it took so long, but let's see where these sweet lesbians take their relationship, shall we?

I'm so happy about the feedback you've been giving to this fic, it makes my heart sing :) I really hope you enjoy the chapter!It's been a lot of fun writing it <3

Thank you so much for reading!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

6AM

Steam from a bowl of hot pumpkin soup dances in the air. Swifty's curious snout approaches, his tongue already protruding from his mouth, but Adora manages to snatch her dinner from the coffee table before the stealthy Beagle makes his move. "A-ha!" She exclaims with a self-satisfied smile, proud to have outsmarted her devious dog as she settles on the couch to watch the upcoming volleyball game between the Salinean Mermaids and the Northern Reachers.

It's been a long day, and Adora is glad it's over. She was so on edge about performing her first unsupervised surgical procedure, let alone one with such severe internal bleeding. Once it started, though, she remained cool and methodical as ever, and the anxiety gave way to a feeling of precise certainty about what she needed to do.

The young vet is extremely relieved that everything went well, but still a little shaken at the possibility of not being able to save that cat. Now that the week is about to give her a well-deserved rest, she wishes she had someone by her side other than Swifty.

Glimmer and Bow invited her to go out tonight, but she’s so physically exhausted that she turned them down. Besides, as much as she loves her friends, the company Adora craves is of a different kind. She wants the warmth of someone snuggled against her, the peace of running her fingers through someone's hair, the intimacy of resting her head on someone’s lap.

Unfortunately, what she wants makes no difference if she can't have it. So her dog, soup, sports, and perhaps a bottle of beer will have to do the trick.

As she zaps through the channels, she tries to keep those thoughts in the back of her conscience.

Then that *beep* rings, and she wonders if the universe is playing a joke on her.

Huh.

Speaking of Adora’s wants...

Pursing her lips, Adora glances at her watch before pulling out her cell phone. Once she calculates the time difference, she frowns. Well, Catra *is* a nocturnal creature, so the timing doesn't really strike her as odd, but even so, it's a little unusual that they talk so late.

Nevertheless, she’s excited.

“hyey,” the first message says, and another one pops up in less than a minute. *“so. listen top this.”*

On any other night, Adora would have noticed the typos that Catra hardly ever commits, despite her informal use of the English

language. On any other night, she could have suspected that Catra had been possibly drinking and would have advised her to hydrate. On any other night, she would have likely teased Catra about how she pricked her competitive side by accidentally using the word "top."

But not tonight.

Because what Adora sees next requires the undivided attention of each one of her brain cells.

Force Captain is recording audio…

Adora inhales so fast she almost chokes on her soup - and it's a good thing that she didn't, because *heh* , that *really* wouldn't have been pretty.

This has happened more and more often - every time they exchange photos, jokes, book chapters, social media posts, and complaints about their day. The more Catra lets Adora into her real life, the more she understands what her body is trying to tell her. Elevated heart rate, dilated pupils, and that dryness in her throat whenever Catra mentions she's about to take a shower or go out with a *friend* .

After just over a month of harboring those permanent resident butterflies in her stomach, Adora can't believe she'll get used to this giddiness, this flutter of wings inside her diaphragm. At the prospect of receiving the first sound recording from Catra since they started talking, it seems that these sensations have been elevated to their tenth power.

Catra's 30-second audio file arrives when her ridiculous coughing fit is starting to subside. After taking a deep breath and regaining whatever is left of her dignity, she hits play.

There's music, the muffled conversation of a crowd, laughter, the sound of breaking glass and a guy yelling something in a different language. For a moment, Adora thinks Catra sent that indiscernible

jumble of noises by mistake. And as she was hoping to hear her friend's voice, she must confess that she is somewhat disappointed.

But when she turns up the volume and listens more closely, she identifies the melody playing in the background. With her ears glued to the cell phone speaker, she recognizes the beat, the voice, and, finally, the words:

"...–ey baby, Im just about staring tonight! Im dying for some action, Im sick of sitting around here trying to write this book. I need a love reaction, come on now , baby, gimme just one look. You cant start a fire sitting around, crying over a broken heart. This guns for hire, even if were just dancing in the dark. You cant start a fire worrying about your little world falling apart– ..."

Adora smiles. So it's not ForceCaptain's voice, but it's something just as good - perhaps even better. It's the song Catra showed her a few weeks ago, the one that's been stuck in her head since the moment she first heard it. The one she secretly wishes Catra sent her as a way to express something other than just her musical taste, but she wont go so far as to allow herself to believe it.

Another message arrives while Adora's listening to the audio for the third time.

"can u hear the song playing??"

"I can! Love that song!" She says with a sincere and grateful grin. "Thank you so much for this! It sounds like you're having a great time."

Keeping one eye on the cell phone, and the other on the television screen, Adora checks if the game has already started. It doesnt take long before her cell phone buzzes again.

“yeah, we came to a bar to celraeteb my friend promotion at work”

*“*celebrate lol.”

*F*riend.

Ugh.

There’s that pesky and conveniently vague word that makes Adora’s blood boil. But she’s not about to let that minor sting of envy outshine the importance of this moment, especially because, after a short instant, a new set of messages appears on her mobile device.

“well anyway.” Catra throws out rather casually. “ *the song made me thinkof u, so.”*

“wanted to say hi :)”

Okay, *heh* . Now Adora is too smitten to function. Catra is thinking about her while she’s out with the unspecified *friend* at four in the morning? This makes her feel sort of prestigious. A little smug, even.

"Oh really?" Adora writes, gently patting Swifty’ s face away from her soup again. "So... that means you think of me, huh?"

Yep, smug sounds accurate.

A conceited smirk begins to creep across Adora's face as she waits for Catra's answer. Meanwhile, Swifty jumps onto the couch and rests his head in her lap and she notices that the game is about to start. She’s stroking his ear when her cell phone rings again.

"oh shit.”

“youre gonna be insufferable about that now, arenbt you?"

Adora snorts, feeling herself get more and more flushed.

"Well, what can I say. Looks like I'm insufferably on your mind!" She types, waggling her eyebrows to herself, feeling very accomplished by her witty retort, then adds a subtle "😉" to the end of the message for good measure.

"fuck... i take it back." Catra replies. *"ur too much of a cocky dumbass to be in my mind."*

Adora quickly scrolls through the conversation and takes a screen capture that registers Catra's words before her counterpart can delete them. She attaches the image file to her next message.

"Too late, I have evidence! No taking backsies 😵"

"nooo! betrayal!!" Adora cackles, trying to imagine Catra making a theatrical expression and gesture. *"well looks like u got me now princess :)"*

"also... taking backsies? seriously?"

"thats dumb, even for you."

"And yet you can't stop thinking about me!"

Still laughing, Adora sighs, the edges of her lips quivering. She plays Catra's audio again, and rereads the entire conversation, feeling her heart melt inside her chest as if it was slowly turning into honey. And again, Adora wishes she could see and hear her friend saying those words to her.

And again, she wishes for more.

With a long exhale, she turns her attention to the phone again, and, for once, she decides to admit what her wishes are.

Or at least one of them.

"You know." She starts, somewhat bashful. "When you sent me that audio, for a moment there I thought I'd get to hear your voice."

Force Captain is typing…

"Oh?" Catra says a while later.

"that a request?"

If they were in the same room right now, Adora would like to think that Catra would be smirking, those beautiful mismatched eyes daring her to ask for what she wants.

"Yes," Adora confesses, her own blue eyes sparkling bright with eagerness. "Please? 😇"

And then, silence.

Ten, fifteen, twenty minutes go by, and Catra's answer doesn't come, no matter how many times Adora checks if her internet connection is still working. Well, online conversations are like that, there must be a good reason. While she not-so-patiently waits, Adora finishes her soup, takes that beer out of the fridge, then settles for watching the game that has now become radically less interesting than glancing at her phone every thirty seconds or so.

The Salinean Mermaids are winning the second set when Adora's cell phone finally vibrates again, and Adora grins when she sees she has received another audio file from Catra.

Heart beating rapidly, she hits play and takes a sip of her beer.

She assumes Catra waited to get to a quiet place before she could record the message because there's no background noise. And her voice. Oh, fuck, her voice. Well, I'll give you this. If Adora wasn't ready for Catra's looks when she first sent her a photograph, Catra's voice is something she could *never* have prepared for.

Her voice has a smokey, sensual quality that sends shivers down Adora's spine, and because it's also a little slurred from the alcohol, she's one hundred percent sure that Catra isn't making any effort to sound so *hot*. She speaks slowly, enunciating each syllable and phoneme, perhaps because English is not her native language, perhaps because she is aware of the tantalizing effect her voice has on other people.

Adora has to listen to the audio a few times before actually being able to pay attention to Catra's words.

And here's what they say:

"Hey, dummy. There you go. This is kind of stupid, heh." Catra scoffs softly, and Adora can hear her breathing for a short and marvelous second. *"Uh, I just got home from the bar and I'm about to get ready for bed. Hope you had a nice day or whatever. K, so I showed you mine. How about you show me yours, princess?"*

She takes a long sip of her beer and chuckles to herself, thoughts hazy as she tries to come up with something to say, pretty sure that anything is going to sound off-putting and lame. But nevertheless, Adora presses the record button.

7:04 AM 2/27

Hair still wet from a cold shower, Adora's stomach growls. After an intense workout in the park, she is famished. On her way to the kitchen, her eye catches the business card she absently threw on the table at her arrival. She giggles when remembering the completely random situation that earned her that card. What an absurd way to start the week!

Feeling the need to share that episode with someone, she texts Catra - lately, she's been the first person Adora thinks of on occasions like this.

"So the weirdest thing just happened to me in the park!" Adora types before leaving her phone on the counter to retrieve a frying pan from the cabinet under the kitchen sink.

She is crouched on the floor checking what appears to be a leak when she hears her cell phone beep. Of course, she bangs the back of her head on her way up. "Ow!" She cries, rubbing the back of her head and laughing at her own cluelessness.

"great. give me some weirdness," is Catra's response. *"i could use the distraction."*

"Oh! Is everything ok?" Adora furrows her eyebrows. "Good morning, by the way. Or afternoon 😅"

"haha, good morning to you, too." She replies right away. *"and yeah, everything's fine. im just dying of boredom after a whole morning sitting in this chair making aaaallll the adjustments my dumb editor asked for."*

"I'm so sorry!" Adora types sympathetically. "But I'm sure the changes are gonna make your book even more amazing than it already is!" And as Adora has been reading the material, she can assert this quite aptly and sincerely.

"well, here's hoping." She opens the fridge for some eggs, ham, and cheese.

"but go on, tell me your weird thing."

"Oh! Right!" Adora chuckles to herself, realizing that her train of thought was nearly derailing.

"So I was jogging with my dog like usual and went to get a juice. When I turn around, there's this woman standing right behind me, making friends with Swifty and such. Then I greet her and she says: 'Hi, sorry, I was sitting on that bench and I saw you running and I have to say I am impressed. You look like a photograph, or a

painting, a piece of art, watching you run is like an aesthetic experience (!). So I wanted to say hi' LOL!"

Chortling at the situation all over again, Adora continues.

"So she says: In case you want to talk one of these days, my number's on there' and woosh, she hands me her business card! 🤪"

The hungry veterinarian cracks two eggs in the frying pan but doesn't look away from her cell phone.

Force Captain is typing...

Based on the time Catra takes to write her response, Adora assumes her friend is about to send her a giant essay.

But instead, her reaction is surprisingly laconic.

"hm."

Without giving much attention to her interactor's loss of words, Adora keeps going.

"Then I say: 'oh but I'm not a professional athlete or anything, I'm a vet,' And she laughs, and goes: 'me neither! I'm a latin teacher , lololol.' And I'm like: 'Ok now you completely lost me,' to which she just says: 'oh sorry , my mistake, didn't mean to intrude. But have a great day, keep doing what you're doing' and then she just leaves!"

"👧 "

Having told the whole story , Adora goes back to preparing her meal. After a while, she notices that Catra hasn't answered her yet. With a puzzled frown, she gives her a gentle nudge.

"Anyway , that's it! Weird, huh?"

After another short moment of radio silence, Adora's cell phone rings again.

“i dont thinkit’ s weird.” This time, ForceCaptain follow-up arrives without any additional delay. *“maybe a bit bold, but given the circumstances i cant blame her.”*

“youre just terrible at spotting when people are hitting on you.”

What -- "Y ou think she was flirting with me?" Adora asks, confused, and takes a bite of her scrambled eggs.

“adora”…

“she basically said you are hot and gave you her number .”

“what the fuckmore do you want?”

Uh. Granted, Adora tends to be more than oblivious to that sort of thing, and to be honest her mind has been so overloaded lately that she didn't consider that possibility. But now that Catra mentioned it...

"But what if she wa--" Y eah, no, Catra is right. It's rather obvious, there’s no getting around it. "I guess I didnt think of it that way ."

" *because youre an idiot.”* Catra says after a minute or so, and this time Adora is forced to agree.

Well, giving her business card to a stranger wouldn't be a pickup line she would use, but then again, what does Adora know about flirting? She’s not really known for being smooth. Her most successful tactic to date involved challenging someone to an arm-wrestling match.

Yeah, that night was wild.

“but not all is lost.”

“you can still call her if youre interested.”

That mere suggestion startles Adora, for she now realizes that she may have given her friend a completely wrong impression. "What? No!" She replies reflexively , without thinking much. "I'm not interested!" She reinforces for greater emphasis.

"hm."

Force Captain is typing…

A little anxious, Adora fidgets, plays with her hair, bites her nails, drums her fingers on the kitchen table. And when she sees Catra's next message, she actually laughs.

"not into girls?"

Though her heart is still pounding, Adora feels a little relieved. This is the opening she's been waiting for, the first time the subject has come up explicitly and not wrapped up in cryptic jokes and innuendo. She received a direct question, she can give a straight answer .

Or, well, duh. Not *straight* , obviously.

"Into girls in general, yes. V ery. Pretty much exclusively." Adora writes about her sexuality with confidence that she probably wouldnt be able to show if they were talking face to face. "I'm just not interested in that particular girl."

Nothing against the admittedly cute Latin teacher, but Adora has got her mind set on someone else.

Ill let you guess who it is.

I mean, it's really not that hard to figure out.

"good to know that we have that in common :)"

There. They finally said it. And it's like fireworks going off in the kitchen.

"Yeah. Good to know." The pink hue that appears on Adora's cheeks is proof of how incredibly hooked she already is. Fortunately (or unfortunately), Catra isn't there to see it.

"hey i should go back to those adjustments now." Catra says, and Adora looks around her and remembers she also has to get ready to work. *"don't want to look bad in front of my beta reader."*

"she's quite the nerd, you know."

"Oh yeah, so I've heard 🤓" Adora replies with a knowing smile, finishing her meal. "Well, I can't wait to read it!"

"No pressure, obviously!"

"don't worry, princess." ForceCaptain says in reply. *"ill send it as soon as im done."*

"Yaaaaay! Deal!" She takes the dishes to the sink, making the lazy decision to wash them when she returns home, later.

"maybe we can voice chat tonight. after your shift?"

"we can even watch the game if you explain the first thing about that crap."

"i mean if you want, obviously."

Adora doesn't hold back her excitement. "For real?! I'd absolutely LOVE that!"

"cool."

"i heard the salinean mermaids are kicking ass."

Watching volleyball while talking to Catra? That's literally the stuff Adora's most recent daydreams are made of.

But wait, hold on -- "How do you know it's game night though?"

“uh.”

“i dont know .”

“i guess you told me? it’s the only thing you talkabout these days.”

Fair enough, she's been obsessed with the volleyball kingdoms league for a while, but Adora's *sure* she didn't mention tonight’s game. With a knowing smile, she realizes that Catra isn't the only one who has an influence on her life - introducing her to TV shows, new music, and whatnot. She has also left her mark on Catra's world.

And she wishes she could do even more.

"Riiight! Or maybe you think about me so much you learned the volleyball schedule telepathically, huh, Force Captain? 😏"

“ugh, shut up.” Catra says, and Adora would like to be with her to witness her getting all flustered, imagining that the cute dimple above her lip twitches when she gets angry or frustrated.

Oh, she is definitely way too deep into this.

“whatever princess, in or out?”

And it's too late to get out now.

3:36 AM

The clock beside Adora’s bed shows the time, and she grunts in frustration. Too awake to find her way back to sleep again, she gets up and decides to finish her notes on the fifth chapter of Catra's book.

Once she’s behind the desk, she turns some music on and stretches herself. Her eyes flick over the computer screen, absently skimming

through Catra's words, the words she's now starting to memorize, having read them so carefully over the last few days.

When her gaze finds a specific sentence, the corners of her lips curl into a bittersweet smile without her even noticing it. *"Angeline remembers that smile belongs to the woman who was once her princess."*

Princess.

Adora would like to think Catra didnt choose that word randomly . After she started giving her feedback and pointing out minor grammar tweaks to her work, Catra got into the habit of leaving subtle messages for her throughout the text. Most of them are comments and footnotes designed to make Adora laugh, laden with Catra's sharp wit and her characteristic sarcastic humor. But some of them, like this one, come across as discreet nods of affection manifested in prose.

These signals are more than enough to send Adora's heart into a spiral. After all, it's hard to resist such intense feelings when the other party insists on being so... irresistible.

Then again, this could be nothing. Adora could be imagining the whole thing, finding hidden messages where there are just words, finding a special kind of intimacy where there's just friendship.

She's considering going back to bed and giving sleep another try, but a few minutes after she sends Catra the annotated document file, a message pops up on her computer screen.

Bep.

Adora smiles, giving her thumb a single sharp bite before opening Catra's message.

"hey adora?" She greets her in apparent confusion. *"please dont tell me you were taking notes on my stuff at 4in the morning."*

“i mean, it’s saturday. there are better things you could def be doing.”

“like, you know…”

“sleeping.”

Adora glances at her own horse-themed pajamas and sighs at her latest mishap, a dopey smile on her lips.

“Woke up in the middle of the night for no apparent reason.” She discreetly rolls her eyes. “But then I kind of scared myself awake even further by misinterpreting a shadow as a cockroach crawling on my bed 😅”

A couple of moments later, Catra’s answer arrives.

“what.”

“...you’re kidding right?”

“I wish.” Adora giggles, softly stroking her eyebrow with the tip of her middle finger. “In my defense, it was a big shadow…”

“okay that is hysterical.”

“I’m aware of that, thank you.” She laughs along with her own words and shakes her head, feeling silly. “Anyway, I couldn’t sleep anymore so I decided to do something useful with the extra time.”

Turning off the laptop, Adora switches the conversation to her cell phone and goes to her bedroom. From his spot on the donut dog bed on the floor, Swifty's eyes slowly open and close again as he softly growls back to sleep.

“im sorry,” ForceCaptain says apologetically. *“i mean, im grateful for your notes, of course but”…*

“insomnia sucks.”

“you deserve to get some proper rest.”

Adora grins, as she feels that Catra’s care is genuine, and how good it feels to have someone looking out for her.

"Thank you.”She types, settling into bed and covering herself with the sheets. "But don't worry , I'll fall asleep eventually."

"Will try some meditation or something.”Although she doesn't usually have the patience for these things, it doesn't hurt to try again.

“isn't anyone there to like”…

“pin you to the mattress or something?”

Uh. Okay. So Adora doesn't know where this conversation is going, but she knows the path is potentially dangerous. The air becomes thick, heavy, and difficult to breathe. Swallowing sharply, she takes a look at the empty space around her, the bed looking absurdly big for just one person all of a sudden.

Before she can think of how to respond, another message arrives.

“because i bet that would do the trick”

It really would, Adora reckons.

"Well that’s not really an option 😐”Adora types as she adjusts her head to the pillow, slightly perched up against the headboard. She licks her lips. "I'm alone.”

“that’s such a waste, princess.”

This time, Adora shuts her eyes and inhales deeply, trying so hard to put that tickling sensation to rest. But no entry in the encyclopedia of Mystacor meditation techniques could soothe her mind. The teasing words have found their way to places in Adora's body that are now decidedly awake.

And the more she tries not to, the more she hears it in her mind: Catra's velvety, luscious voice whispering in her ear, warm and soft breath caressing her neck, a soft kiss on her jawline, then those words echoing again, making her crazy.

Force Captain is typing…

Adora holds her breath when her cell phone vibrates in her hand, her fingers pressing it against her palm.

She touches the screen to reveal the message and gasps.

“too bad i cant volunteer .”

“im sure i could thinkof a way to tire you out.”

Ah, fuck, that does it. Sleeping is completely out of the question now.

Catra’s innuendo hits Adora physically this time, a blow so strong that she wouldnt be able to explain what she’ s feeling if someone asked her to. The image of Catra’s body above hers, pressing her against the bed, kissing her lips and touching her bare skin, caressing her, searching for her sensitive spots, driving her slow and steady towards that sweet, sweet release, it stings like an itch she cannot scratch, it fills her and leaves her empty like a thirst that cannot be quenched.

She realizes that it’s been a long while since she’s been this turned on. And come to think of it, she has never felt this way without her being in the other person's physical presence, which makes it all the more exhilarating somehow.

A part of her is dying to take the next step and flirt back, explicitly, directly. A part of her is *itching* to call Catra’s bluff and ask “who said you *cant* volunteer?” just to see how far she would be willing to take this, just to see if maybe, just maybe, she feels the same way .

She might be walking into heartbreak, she might find that she's just deluding herself, projecting, seeing flirtation where there isn't any. And she knows that her answer will probably change their friendship in ways she might not be able to reverse.

But her instincts. Well. Right now, they are telling her to *screw it*.

"Would you want that, though?" Adora hits send before she can change her mind, clenching her fingers around the cell phone, her thighs writhing over each other under the sheets. "To volunteer."

Force Captain is typing...

Those few seconds feel like hours, and the excruciating wait serves to further ignite that yearning burning inside her. The anticipation makes Adora's muscles tense, her mouth waters, and although she knows it's all a bit odd to be feeling this way about someone who's *seven time zones away* from her, she can't bring herself to care. For months she has been brooding over this question and she's about to finally get an answer.

And when it comes, desire turns her skin inside out.

"i wouldn't have suggested it if i didn't mean it"

Adora's fingertips and nails instinctively scratch her sweaty palm. She finds it incredibly difficult to concentrate on giving Catra any kind of answer, as all the blood in her body seems to have converged to one single place.

"And how would you--" she hesitates for a heartbeat or two but eventually decides to complete the sentence. "And how would you tire me out?"

"well..."

"that is something i'd rather say than write."

"voice chat maybe?"

Pupils wide, breath catching, Adora feels the goosebumps coming once again. Her fingers are shaking when she types her answer .

Chapter End Notes

The song Catra recorded to Adora: Lucy Dacus - Dancing in the dark

I put in so many inside jokes and callbacks in this chapter I can't even count, haha.

Also, I have said it before, but I'll say it again: volleyball will probably always be Adora's sport of choice in my fics, because I'm a very self-indulgent writer, so there's that.

Connection

Chapter Summary

Adora processes her reactions to her latest voice chat with Catra.

Chapter Notes

I am back and I have Catradora content :)

A little heads up, this is still a M-rated chapter (though I am walking on a thin line) and I may be bumping up the rating to E in the foreseeable future. I am so happy with the feedback and support I have been getting on this fic, and it's been so much fun to write it. I can't think of a better community than this fandom <3

Anyway, I hope you enjoy the chapter! I'd love to hear your thoughts about it! Kudos and comments are always appreciated :)

CW: a bit of spice

Have fun ;)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

4:12 AM - 1:12 AM

"Is this... Uh... Do you think this is weird?" Adora asks, clearing her throat to keep her voice from breaking. With her eyes closed and her chest heaving, she senses her earlier burst of confidence wavering as she runs her knuckles up and down the mattress. Her breath is short and slightly ragged, the air thick with palpable expectation.

A low chuckle breaks the silence, followed by a click of tongue and a thoughtful hum, and Adora feels all her nerve endings tingle.

They are nothing special, really. Noises. Not even words, just… vibrations traveling through the air and along the wires of Adora's headphones until they reach her ears, or so goes the textbook definition of the phenomenon.

Yet they are so much more than just that, you see. Right now , those seemingly insignificant guttural sounds are the bridge shortening their distance, the embodiment of Catra's presence in Adora's room, in her bed, by her side, kissing her earlobe and stroking the skin beneath her collarbone under the blankets.

And *damn.* Call her crazy, but she can actually feel it.

The sounds touch her, and Adora feels her body responding, seeking contact, trying to reciprocate. Catra hums, and it's as if her flesh and blood are humming along, dancing to her melody. Catra chuckles and her leg muscles squirm and stif fen. Catra clicks her tongue, and Adora's heart rate picks up, the throbbing pressure in the pit of her abdomen increases.

No textbook cataloged in the Great Library of the Whispering Woods could even begin to explain that.

What is this? Desire, sure, even someone as emotionally numb as Adora is able to figure that out. But how can one be so attracted to a *voice* ? She certainly isn't used to being this eager , this needy. Who knows. Maybe it's a side ef fect of her loneliness. Maybe six months without being intimate with anyone did turn her a little desperate, as Glimmer sometimes jokes.

Or maybe it's the sign of something else.

Adora exhales and opens her eyes, the tip of her index finger tracing absent wave patterns on her right thigh. When Catra's voice comes

out of her headphones again, she gives the fabric of her pajama pants a gentle pinch.

“*Weird is not the word I would choose*.” Catra says in a leisurely pace, her voice filling every gap in Adora's senses with tepid but agonizing delight. “*Do you? Think it's weird...?*” She asks, and this hint of insecurity makes Adora smile, as it is reassuring to realize that perhaps Catra is just as anxious as she is about this.

The answer is easy, though, and it comes out of her mouth in a heartbeat.

“No.” In fact, not surprisingly, her interactions with Catra have never been weird. Even when her friend manages to get her all flustered and unsettled, there’s something so natural about their dynamic. “It's just.. different, I think.” And exciting and confusing and *soooo* unbelievably complicated. “New.”

This is a vague and somewhat cowardly way of expressing it, but *new* is also quite accurate, and Adora doesn't mean the voice component of their interaction. They've been voice chatting casually since their first timid audio exchanges, during a match of Escape to Despondos or while watching a volleyball game. But Adora knows this particular conversation is not going to be a casual one. This is uncharted territory for both of them.

And because Catra knows that too, she won't miss the opportunity to tease.

“*Not used to having someone take care of you until you fall asleep, huh?*” Her voice comes out sharp, warm, and delicious, like a bite on Adora's neck.

Adora hisses and licks her lips, trying to swallow the knot on her throat in order to come up with a coherent response. “Uh.” She mutters, her eyes burning underneath her eyelids. “N-not really, no.”

Catra laughs, and again, the sound is like North pulling Adora like a compass needle.

“*I wonder if new and different isn't what you are missing then,* ”she taunts in a sly tone. “*You are always saying how hard it is for you to relax* ”

“Ha-ha-ha,"Adora cuts her of f with sarcastic and nervous cackling. "Don't claim victory too soon, *Force Captain* . Relaxed is the last thing you're making me feel right now.”She confesses shamelessly , and her shaky voice wouldn't let her lie even if she tried. "This whole idea of yours could backfire.”

A devilish scoff, another long and tormentor hum. Adora’s eyes travel across the dark bedroom, turning to the dimly lit bedside table where her cell phone is as if seeking Catra’s gaze.

“*Well, thanks to you and your notes, Sera, I'm not in a rush.* ”The girl replies teasingly, pronouncing the nickname with extra sultriness, and Adora’s teeth braze her bottom lip to bite back a gasp. “*I already finished what I had to do for the day, so I have the whole afternoon ahead of me. I have absolutely no problem with taking my time here.*”

"Oh, okay . Then I guess your big plan is to torture me to sleep?"A sassy smirk starts to show up on Adora’s face, and she makes no effort to fight it down. "Because that can be counterproductive.”

After a short pause, Catra sucks in a ponderous breath. Adora grabs the hem of her shirt in anticipation.

“*I don't know about torture...* ”Catra scof fs softly. “*You see, my plan was to tell you that if I was there with you right now, I think I would probably be touching your skin, stroking it very lightly until you fell asleep. With just... the tips of my fingers, you know . Very slowly, up and down, down and up again.”* Adora swallows, finding that breathing has become considerably difficult. *“My hands on your*

back, your chest, your stomach. Then your arms, your waist. Your hips... Your thighs. Anywhere you needed me to."

True to her promise to take her time, Catra speaks all of these words very slowly, uttering each syllable as if the sound were her fingers on Adora's skin, wandering and discovering her body in soft motions.

"That." Adora sighs, tries in vain to regain her senses, and throws the blanket aside as the rising temperature is becoming unbearable. "That sounds a lot like torture to me." Her voice comes out a lot more shaky and deeper than she intended.

"And if at any point you tried to leave the bed. Well, I guess I would have to think of a way to convince you not to."

This time, Adora lacks the willpower or the strength to suppress her body's most immediate reactions. Goosebumps cover every inch of her skin, and her desire bursts out of her mouth in a discreet, but clear, moan.

The sound of satisfaction she hears coming from the other end of the line is electrifying. Catra's having so much fun with this, Adora could just. She could just. Oh, who are we kidding here? Adora is in no position to do anything.

"Like, uh." She stutters, then swallows. Her uneven breath makes it harder for her to speak. "Like what?"

"Hmmmm"... Catra ponders, long and sadistically, and the wait has Adora tugging at the hem of her pajama top and twisting the fabric in her hand. *"First, I guess we'd have to find out what's troubling you. What's on your mind. Who knows, maybe a long kiss could drown out the noise in that big head of yours. Clear your thoughts."*

Adora's lips throb softly. "Mmhmm." She sobs in pathetic agreement, pulling her shirt to one side and stretching it to the limit. "Y -yes, that sounds like a good plan."

“Do you think a kiss would help?"

Honestly, Adora has been daydreaming about kissing Catra for days, weeks, maybe an entire month. Now that Catra has said that, the image flashes vividly in her brain, awakening her senses. She wonders what it would be like to have that mouth pressed against hers. To have those beautiful, warm lips close enough for Adora to kiss, suck, nibble, until one of them needed to catch their breath.

And maybe it's the power of suggestion, maybe it’s the effect of that *voice* over her, or maybe it's because her imagination is greater than the distance that separates them, but Adora can practically feel it.

"That, uh." She licks her lips. "That would help, yeah."

“Unless your problem is your room temperature... I don't know about the weather there in Bright Moon, but over here the nights are so hot, sometimes it's better to sleep without clothes, you know. I do it all the time.”

Holy fucking shit.

With her eyes closed and her lips pursed, Adora’s fingers close around the hem of her shirt again to pull the fabric up to her chest, uncovering her abdomen. One hand on her belly while the other travels to her neck, gently caressing the sensitive skin near her pulse point, then moving down to her shoulders.

"Catra..."

And as if she could see Catra’s evil smirk, she hears her chuckling and saying: *“...Adora?”*

At her name, Adora opens her eyes and tries for one last moment of lucidity before giving in completely.

"What are we doing?"

After a short pause, Catra snorts with laughter, her voice reaching a higher pitch than its usual sultry tone. "*Fuckif I know*." She responds, and the spontaneity and candidness of her tone are thoroughly appreciated, as they remind Adora that she is not alone in this. "*But I know I don't want this. Whatever this is... To stop.*" She says, and Adora takes that brief moment of silence as an opportunity to inhale properly. "*Do you?*"

With a smile, Adora slowly shakes her head. Her anxiety starts to subside.

"No, yeah, definitely, uh... Stopping would be... Bad." She replies with a silly expression, her brain no longer functioning on the levels required to formulate more complex sentences. "Very bad," she adds, just to be sure, as if her disposition to continue needed any further clarification.

"*Good*." Catra murmurs then hums with approval. "*Then maybe we can just... Keep talking. Stop overthinking. The part of figuring this shit out can be a problem for future Adora and Catra.*"

There's no way to predict how Adora will feel in the aftermath of whatever it is they're doing right now, but she knows for a fact that stopping will leave her cold with regret. And although she is fond of many flavors, the taste of regret is something she absolutely loathes.

She lets her impulses take the wheel.

"Alright," Adora mumbles with a shy smile, stretching her fingers across her belly until her thumb touches the outskirts of her right breast. "Sorry, I, uh-- I guess it's a little hard for me to believe this is happening," she confesses. "Whatever this is."

Her counterpart chuckles heartily, the sound warm and all-encompassing.

"*Don't worry, dummy. You're not the only one.*" She responds, her raspy voice so soft and tender it melts away every last shred of

Adora's insecurity. Then, with a subtle yet noticeable change in tone... "*Now tell me something.* Are you lying down?"

Okay.

So much for soft and tender.

Adora bites her lower lip, her abdomen quivering and contracting with each touch of her fingers. Every hair on her body stands on end as if attempting to travel all the way to Half Moon to be with Catra.

A low moan escapes her throat.

"Adora?" Catra calls, and, once again, Adora looks at her phone as if searching for her expression.

"I am," she responds weakly, and Catra lets out a satisfied groan that makes her salivate.

"You didn't get out of bed. I'd say that's progress."

Adora smiles, not noticing that her right hand begins to move down from her breast to her navel, outlining the waistband of her pajama pants while her left hand continues to caress her collarbone.

"Well, yeah, sure, but, *heh*. I *am* still awake." She jokes, her pupils alert with excitement in contrast to her heavy, tired eyelids. "And, uh... Not yet. Relaxed." She chuckles. "Not at all."

"Aw, that's too bad." Catra sing-songs and Adora rolls her eyes playfully, her middle finger wandering across the side of her lower abdomen to trace her hip bone. *"Oh, well. Guess my plan isn't working, then."*

It is working too well, Adora reckons.

"Oh, no, it *totally* is," she blurts out excitedly. "But only, uh... To a certain extent." She clears her throat a little nervously.

Catra scoffs with a low, predatory growl that tickles the skin around Adora's ears. *"I see. Well, unfortunately, princess I can only do so much from where I am."* She laments. *"But believe me, if I were there, I would love to do the honors."*

"Oh, yeah?" Adora attempts to tease, but the effort to do so is so tremendous that her voice sounds pathetically shaky. "And what would you do?"

At the question, Catra pauses and makes another of those excruciating pondering noises. *"I think I would take my time with you. Make you ask for what you want."*

Wriggling in the sheets, Adora manages to let out a laugh. "You like to tease, huh? Not exactly a surprise."

"Well, Adora, from what I know of you, you don't like to come across as needy. I would love to be the one who breaks you. Who makes you beg."

"*Fuck*." Adora growls rather breathlessly, her toes curling. "Catra"…

"That would be very satisfying, I must admit." Catra teases smugly.

"I would *love* to see you try," she defies with a smirk, her hand moving down from her collarbone to fondle her breasts, the other one stroking her inner thigh.

Catra swallows, inhales then exhales, and the next time she speaks, her velvety voice is breaking. *"I guess we have to make that happen, then."*

"You know, sometimes I think about what would happen if we met in person," Adora says, tentative fingers skirting her most sensitive areas, but not daring to touch them.

"You do?" She asks, and Adora is not sure if she means to sound teasing or if she is genuinely surprised.

"I think about it *so* hard I can't concentrate," she confesses with her eyes closed, already dizzy from the heat building inside her. "What it would be like to be with you."

"Well, I'm, uh... I'm flattered." Catra says timidly. Adora imagines her blushing, and the thought makes her chest expand, her lips curling into a smile. *"Are you thinking about it right now?"*

The images take her at once, powerful and overwhelming, filling all the empty spaces within with hunger. Catra crawling on top of her, their bodies pressed together, their clothes coming off. Adora pushing Catra against a wall, kissing her neck, whispering obscenities in her ear. Catra touching her, nails digging into her skin, into her scalp, her teeth nipping at Adora's lip. Their fingers and tongues searching for flesh, their flesh craving for contact.

It's confusing. Catra is there, but she isn't. Her voice fills the hot, thick tension hovering over her, keeping her company, but it's also shapeless. Bodiless. Adora's breathing gets heavier and faster, beads of sweat forming on her sternum. "Y -yes."

"Good." Catra hums under her breath, almost proudly, and Adora feels herself buzzing to the sound again. *"And how is that tension now?"*

She huffs out a low giggle, the muscles in her abdomen aching with the lingering strain. "It's still here," she chuckles.

"What are you going to do about it, princess?" That husky, delicious voice tickles Adora's insides, scratching the surface of her yearning. *"You do know what's missing there, right?"*

Adora shuts her eyes. The blunt suggestion makes her throat tighten. On the one hand, she wants to continue, to yield to Catra's voice until she reaches climax. At the same time, she isn't sure. They have a friendship, a relationship of sorts. This is not a stranger Adora will never talk to again, this is someone special for her. Their newfound intimacy is still delicate, still fragile, and for Adora to totally

lose her inhibitions, it would take a level of trust she's not sure they've achieved.

"Y..Y. eah." She mumbles bashfully , her face getting warmer with each breath, her right hand so close to where she desperately needs to be touched. "But... Catra"…

It may sound silly, but even if the idea itself is *incredibly* arousing, and something that Adora would absolutely like to try somewhere in the future, the ridiculous truth is... This is not how she wants her first time with Catra to be.

Assuming they will ever have a first time, that is.

"Would you prefer to have some privacy?" She asks, and Adora whimpers a little "mhmm" in agreement, so grateful that she doesn't have to say it out loud.

"Is that okay?" She asks, a little embarrassed.

"Of course, dummy ," Catra chuckles suggestively. "*Ill leave you to it."*

When the call ends, Adora tries to process the emotions and sensations that simmer inside, and they all seem to converge on one simple instinct. Adora wants. More specifically, Adora wants Catra. To be with her, to take her, to touch her.

And she wants to be touched by Catra just as badly .

It's so rare for her to want something. I mean, *really* want something. Maybe that's the weird part about this whole thing, after all.

Her cell phone beeps unexpectedly , startling her and robbing her of any thought. She picks up the device, the bright screen nearly blinding her for a few seconds.

"before you go"… Catra's message says, and when Adora's eyes adjust to the brightness enough for her to read, her heart pounds in anticipation for the follow-up.

Forced Captain is typing…

As she waits, Adora stares at the screen, cradling the cell phone with her hands as if it held the most precious and important thing in her world - because, right now, it kind of does.

When the message appears, all of her muscles clench, the pressure between her legs burning stronger.

“i want u to know that i think about you too. and i wish i could be there with you right now. to see you. to watch you. i wish i could be there to find out where you like to be touched... how you like to be touched... whether you like it gentle, whether you like it rough. and because im a very good soldier , if i were there i would give my best to figure out all your weaknesses and your sensitive spots, what makes you squirm, what makes u scream, what makes your blood runs faster and your eyes roll up. then i would work you... and take care of you... until all the tension in that gorgeous body of yours was gone.”

Oh, fuck, Catra.

If only they could put those words into action.

Adora exhales sharply, eyes and mouth watering with hunger as her hand finally reaches the place she needs it to be.

“sweet dreams, princess.”

12:42 AM

Cold water drips onto the wood of the bottom of the kitchen cabinet, and Adora puts on a towel to keep it from soaking. She’s crouched on the floor, there's a toolbox at her feet and Swifty is sniffing out the supplies she bought at the hardware store. Her eyes are on the drainpipe, but her head is light years away from the leak under the kitchen sink. Right after waking up from one of the most intense nights of her life, domestic problems feel irrelevant.

The pleasure Adora felt no more than a few hours ago is still present, still vivid, still buzzing inside. *“Are you lying down?”* Catra’s voice claims her thoughts and Adora shivers at each flash of memory, not entirely sure whether she should feel happy or afraid, but certain that her life has gotten a lot more complicated since last night.

“I would love to be the one who breaks you.”

She checks her texts. Bow inviting her for brunch with him and Glimmer, a dumb meme from her twin brother Adam in the family group, a few work-related messages.

No new word from Catra.

Rationally, Adora understands why she didn't text. Given when and how they said their goodbyes, it would be more logical for Adora to make the first contact of the day. Emotionally speaking, however, the silence only adds more fuel to her anxiety. After all, what is one supposed to say to their online crush who lives halfway around the world after being reduced to a warm puddle of bliss under her command? What is the post-hot-phone-foreplay protocol?

Adora doesn’t know how she should approach this. So instead she just stares dumbfoundedly at the screen, each glimpse at Catra’s latest messages making her insides clench and turn all over again. *“What makes you squirm, what makes you scream.”*

Fuck. Functioning will be *very* hard today.

“What makes your blood runs faster and your eyes roll up.”

At least the hydraulic problem in front of her is something she can objectively fix. Or so she hopes.

She picks up the pliers and the adhesive from the toolbox, hits play on a RuneTube video on “how to repair a leak under the sink” and dives inside the cabinet. Watch out, leak! Your days are numbered.

A cheesy pop song plays softly in the background. Bow drops his fork onto the plate in surprise. "Whoa, Adora, really?"

Adora fills her mouth with cinnamon buns and chews. She looks sideways, a blush growing in her cheeks.

"Good for you. And about fucking time, if you ask me." Glimmer says smiling and taking a bite of a bagel. "You owe me a drink, by the way," she raises a triumphant eyebrow at her boyfriend.

"Fine, fine. Fair is fair." Bow grunts in a defeated tone and Glimmer squeals cheerfully as she waves the waiter over to order a French 75. Meanwhile, Adora can't bring herself to care about the fact that her best friends were presumably betting on her romantic life. To be honest, if the situation were reversed, she would do the same.
"Adora, don't get me wrong, I'm really happy for you. It's been a while since you've been excited about anyone. I just worry that you--"

"I know, I know, the long-distance thing is insane," Adora says with her mouth full while noticing that these cinnamon buns are simply delicious. With a delighted *"hmm"*, she flips through the menu of "Bake a Pie" to take a picture of their delivery phone number.
"Anyway, I'm screwed, right?"

Glimmer and Bow trade a glance. "Well... I guess it depends on how far you are willing to go." Bow says. "I've never been in a long-distance relationship *myself*, but I imagine it requires extra communication, patience, and trust, otherwise small things can turn into big problems." He adds in a gentle tone as he picks up the pitcher of pineapple and mint juice from the table to fill up his glass.

"But Bow, aren't you getting ahead of yourself? Adora didn't say anything about a relationship." Glimmer interjects, sipping at her newly arrived cocktail drink. "From all we know, this can be just a harmless crush. A way to blow off steam, flirt casually, have some

fun.” She faces Adora. “Where did you leave things after you admitted having the hots for each other? How did the conversation develop?”

“Well.” Avoiding all eye contact, Adora turns her attention to her cell phone, drumming her fingers on her chin in frustration when noticing that Catra still hasn't texted her. “It kind of didn't.”

“I don't get it, you hung up in the middle of the conversation?” Bow asks with a puzzled expression.

Yeah, so. Adora may have intentionally left out one or two things about last night. It's not in her plans to overshare that in addition to confessing their mutual attraction, she also participated in a guided self-pleasure session with Catra.

“It's just that it was *super* late at night.” She justifies defensively, her voice cracking. “We left that other part of the talk to be continued.”

Glimmer places her glass on the table. “What, you fell asleep after the big reveal?” She snorts. “*You*?”

Holding her breath, Adora purses her lips.

Then I would work you…

And take care of you...

Until all the tension in that gorgeous body of yours was gone.

“*Ahem*, yeah, uh... something... like... that.” Adora suppresses a little smirk, her mouth getting dry and her thoughts getting lost in wonder.

The two of them fix her with a knowing look. Adora's complete lack of subtlety must have made her late-night indiscretions pretty obvious. They cross their arms and grin at her in synchrony.

Blushing, Adora checks her cell phone again out of the corner of her eye. "Now I don't know how to pick up that conversation again."

"Well, what do you want?" Bow asks and chews his omelet as if the question he is asking was simple. "Do you want to pursue this?"

"I think so. I don't know. It's all so new," Adora says frankly, overwhelmed by all the thoughts running through her head. "There's a lot to figure out."

"You don't have to figure everything out *in advance*, you know. Sometimes there doesn't have to be a plan." Glimmer says, cleaning her mouth with a napkin. "A big part of the fun of meeting someone new is letting it roll and just rolling with it. You know, discovering how you feel about things in the process."

"I *don't* have to figure out everything in advance?" Adora stares at her friend skeptically. "Do you not know me?"

Bow and Glimmer cackle and Adora laughs along with them.

"It's just... What if this turns out to be just something fun for her like Glimmer said? Just... friends casually flirting online because nothing serious is gonna happen anyway."

I want you to know that I think about you too.

Did Catra really mean that, or was it a heat of the moment thing?

"Well, but..." Bow starts, but Adora interrupts him and continues her ramble.

"And what if we give this a try and one of us gets hurt? I mean, what kind of prospect could we even have at all, being so far away from each other? And she hasn't texted. I know I also didn't text her and I probably should, but... Do you guys think it's weird that she hasn't texted?" Adora is barely processing her thoughts as she spills them out, the words leaving her mouth as if they had a mind of their own.

Realization finally hits her like an anvil.

"Oh, God. I think I really like her ."She admits, weak from her own surprise. "What am I going to do?"

Glimmer and Bow trade another look, then turn to her.

"Adora.Y. ou know whatever you do, we will support you. We have your back, alright?"Glimmer says reassuringly . "But you are asking these questions to the wrong people."

"I know ..."She huf fs out with a frustrated pout on her face, laying her head on the table. Of course she had to fall for a girl who lives on the other side of the world. "This is a disaster ."

"W ell, you cant really know that. So... before freaking out, why dont you just talk to her?"Bow adds with a kind smile. "I know you can do it."

Adora sighs, hoping her friends are right.

3 M

"So I had an excellent night' s sleep for some reaso--"Ugh. "I cant stop thinking about last ni--"Seriously , Adora. "Hey , good lookin--"

This is stupid. Since she got home from brunch, Adora has been stuck in a cycle of typing and deleting a message for Catra for longer than she would ever admit. The inquisitive screen stares at her as she sits uselessly and taps her index finger on the laptop.

She feels frustrated, almost angry at herself. Adora may be a lot of things, but she is definitely not a coward. No, she is the kind of person who is straightforward about her problems and does what needs to be done to solve them. There's a leak in her kitchen? She fixes it. Granted, after nearly breaking the cabinet, sticking her fingers together with adhesive and poking her dog in the eye with a screwdriver, but the point is, she gets the job done. In Adora' s book,

if she receives a mission, she wont stop until the mission is accomplished.

So pull yourself together, Adora. This is a conversation like any other. Just take a deep br--

ForceCaptain is typing…

...Merciful mother of all the First Ones and angelic beings above.

Adora grips the edges of her seat, digging her nails into the leather chair.

The message appears after a few seconds.

“so im having a blast watching you type and delete for the past 20 minutes, but im seriously starting to get worried you're gonna burn your two brain cells trying to write that essay over there.”

“thought id breakthe ice.”

"hey adora."

Adora laughs nervously, grimacing. “You saw that, huh? 😬 ,”she chooses an emoj that conveys her exact expression. “Sorry!”

“there is nothing to apologize for .” ForceCaptain says. Adora scratches the nape of her neck, trying to organize her thoughts.

“Actually I think there is.”She replies, taking a deep breath. “I wanted to text you earlier, but I guess I was struggling with my words a little because of what happened last night.”

A short pause.

“oh?”

For a minute there, Adora assumes there will be a follow-up message, a sassy retort, or a tease, but it doesnt come. Suspicious,

she interprets Catra's lack of words as distrust. She has been silent for too long and it could have given Catra the wrong idea about how she feels.

Channeling her inner Bow, Adora convinces herself that *she can do it*. And again, she decides her best strategy is to go with the truth.

"I cant stop thinking about last night. Actually , the truth is... I cant stop thinking about you. I know we dont know each other in person and things could be totally different if we ever did, but I think that I --" Adora pauses, hesitates, inhales, and exhales again. "Last night made me realize how much I like you. I mean, I really like you. I like you to the point that I'd be willing to find a way to meet you, not right away, of course, but I'd be willing to see what this feeling is about. And maybe this is crazy, but yesterday you told me that you think of me too... and I was here wondering if that would be something you would like to do."

She hits the return key before she has the time to change her mind.

At the edge of her seat, she waits.

Force Captain is typing...

"always such an idiot :)"

Adora's muscles unclench and she exhales in relief. When the following messages from Catra arrive and their conversation unfolds, relief turns into a kind of ecstatic joy . As she allows herself to feel it, she thinks she understands what Glimmer meant by what she said earlier, and she finds she agrees. Part of the fun of meeting someone new is letting it roll. And rolling with it.

Chapter End Notes

Go, lovebirds <3

hope you enjoyed this chapter just as much as I enjoyed writing it :)

I'd like to thank every scholarrrr who gave me a hand while I was writing this - you know who you are.

Thank you for reading!

Stand-by

Chapter Summary

Four months later, Adora and Catra adjust to their new kind of relationship.

Chapter Notes

Hey! I am sorry I took a little long to post this. I know this is getting repetitive, but my life has been pretty hectic lately, so I can't write as frequently as I would like. Nevertheless, I am back with fluffy long-distance yearning, so please don't hate me :)

I'd propose a drinking game in which you take a sip at every shameless reference/easter-egg to the show (or to the fandom) that you find, but I suppose it's best to read this sober :)

Anyway, thank you for your patience and your support, and I hope you enjoy this chapter. This one was kind of tricky, but also very fun to write, and I would love to hear your thoughts on it :)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

“i thinkthere’ s something here, yeah.”

Adora shuts her eyes, presses her eyelids firmly, then opens them again, as if to make sure she's really read what she thinks she's just read. A long breath, her whole body seized by a wave of goosebumps, and she has to keep her hands from trembling when she takes them back to the keyboard.

“You do?? 🙂 For real?”

It doesn't take long for Catra's next response to appear on Adora's screen. *“of course dummy.”* The surge of adrenaline from a few moments earlier begins to wane. *“i dont thinkI was being subtle after some point.”*

“W ell Im not great with subtlety as you must know 😜”She sends, rolling her eyes. “I kind of need these things to be spelled out sometimes!”

“well then rest assured, princess. i feel it too,” Catra says, and Adora feels these words like fingertips caressing her cheeks.

She blinks, grins, giggles, slightly moving her head to the side as if leaning into the imaginary touch.

Then, like a child, she bursts out laughing.

Catra feels it too!

Euphoria. That’s the only word she knows for this stupid, ridiculous high that completely overwhelms her senses and blurs her thoughts.

And she knows it may not last, it may never become anything more than just this, a long-distance crush with no real future. But nevertheless, it’s so fucking rewarding to simply *want* someone and be *wanted* in return. It's a bit of a miracle for Adora to have confirmation that she shares this special secret, this somewhat forbidden and increasingly growing affection with the person who matters most to share it with.

Catra feels it too. Of course it doesn't change the fact that they're thousands of miles away - or kilometers, now that Adora is getting used to this metric system conversion thing. But that small sense of certainty is enough to embrace her for now, to make her feel like she is no longer alone in the room.

Adora considers sending an animated gif with a happy dance or maybe a fireworks emoj to convey her sense of ecstasy , but instead,

she decides to ask the difficult question that begs to be asked.

"And what do you think we should do about it?" She presses the return key after staring at her own message for a while.

Force Captain is typing...

Anxiety creeps in again. This is the real deal now. It's one thing to have feelings for each other. Feelings are easy, really, but they can only take you so far. Deciding whether and how they should pursue them is a very different situation. In this matter, Adora knows where she stands.

But where does Catra?

"well"...

"there's a lot to consider," she adds shortly after the first message appears, and Adora catches her breath as she waits for the next one.

"10 thousand km is not a joke."

"I know ... 😔" Adora sighs, pausing for a moment to look around the empty and quiet room around her . Only the sound of low trip-hop music disrupts the silence as she reconsiders the costs of taking this forward. "I would never ask you to put yourself in a position where you think you could get hurt, so please, just feel free to say whatever is on your mind right now."

"oh, there's no doubt in my mind that we're both signing ourselves up to get hurt," the message says, and Adora feels her heart shrinking in her chest. *"we would be pretty much walking into an emotional clusterfuck"*

Catra's choice of words makes Adora scoff, albeit a little bitterly.

She wishes she could reason with that irritating dose of reality Catra has delivered. She wishes she could be the optimistic one and say there's nothing that can't be fixed. But deep down, she knows that Catra has a point. Relationships are hard enough without having to deal with this kind of predicament.

All the questions race through Adora's brain at once. What if someone else comes along? What if they never get a chance to actually meet? What if they meet and find that their emotional chemistry doesn't translate physically? What if Catra doesn't like the way she kisses or her performance in bed? Or, perhaps even worse, what if they find they are super compatible and right for each other, but then have to go back to living apart with no actual prospective of being together?

The odds seem to be all against them when she starts to think about it. Adora doesn't believe she could handle a long-distance relationship without a deadline, or at least a reasonable plan. That amount of yearning and waiting and not knowing could be the recipe for a very painful kind of torture.

It wouldn't be reasonable to even give this a try.

...But *fuck*. What if she never feels this way about anyone ever again?

No, she's not about to back away from that.

For someone who has always tried to strategize her life down to the smallest detail and ensure that nothing got out of her control, Adora is starting to realize that reason can sometimes be overrated.

"You're right," she admits, softly scratching her thumb with her index fingernail as she figures out what to type next. "It's risky and dangerous and probably not smart. And things could get VERY messy for the both of us, I am aware of all of that. But Catra. Look, of course, I can't speak for you. And again, I'm not asking you to

submit yourself to anything that could be bad for you. But right now, what I'm feeling seems to be more important than those risks."

Underneath the desk, Swifty comes close to her, sniffing her thigh, asking to be petted. Adora finds it interesting how the dog always seems to know when she is distressed, as if he was attuned to her emotions.

She exhales and rereads what she's just written, quickly assessing her tone. Then, she adds: "So yeah, it may be an emotional clusterfuck, but I'm willing to take that chance."

When Catra's next message comes, Adora has her eyes closed, and she holds her breath before opening them.

"okay . then i'm in." Adora takes a deep breath that washes the tension away as she allows that surge of illogical joy to take her over once again. *"what's life without a little risk, right?"*

"let's see where this clusterfucktakes us :)"

Adora is grinning from ear to ear when she replies. "Gladly ☺"

*

3:11 PM 1:11 PM

A dozen different anonymous tabs are open in the web browser on Adora's office computer. In each of them, the estimated price of air tickets and hotels, in addition to a list of places to go in Dovale, a.k.a Catra's hometown in the country of Bhutan. For the past four months, since the nature of her relationship with Catra changed, planning an imaginary vacation trip has been one of Adora's favorite pastimes, and one of the few things that can soothe her nerves when she starts overthinking the more complicated elements of their blooming relationship.

That and, of course, checking her cell phone for the traditional *“how’s your day going?”*, the occasional *“can’t wait to kick your ass when you get home,”* and the increasingly frequent *“i wonder how long your neck will be bruised after i sink my teeth into it.”* The latter is pretty much always accompanied by a suggestive photo of Catra smirking, winking or simply existing and being her drop-dead-gorgeous self in front of the camera, which is enough to leave Adora inappropriately parched and flushed before greeting her next patient.

They haven't made any concrete plans to meet, nor can Adora pay for a trip of this magnitude on her current salary, so her research is mere fantasy, an indulgence in the realm of possibilities. At the same time, she has been actively working to materialize that dream, saving money here and there, taking house calls to earn some extra cash, and discussing with her co-workers at the Pet Zone when would be the best moment to schedule her vacation.

“adora, you do know you don’t have to search for hotels, right?”

“i have a bed.”

“it’s small, but i’m pretty sure we can both squeeze into it.”

For Adora, one of the best parts of this is that she has someone who is interested in seeing her extremely detailed spreadsheets, diagrams, and schematics.

Even if it's just to make fun of her.

“you are a geek,” Catra told her some time ago when Adora presented her air-tight six-month strategy to make her trip to Dovale viable without wiping out all her savings at once.

“I know,” she typed rather proudly at the occasion. “But then again, that’s how you like me 😉😉😉”

“touché”

“i cant argue with that)”

This is another fantastic part of this whole planning and “waiting to see what happens” thing they are doing. As they imagine what their future could be like and share their ideas for when they finally meet, Catra allows her affection for Adora to show more naturally in her words.

“Hey I saw a picture of one of the beaches over there and I gotta say WOW! Cant wait to see them in person,” Adora said sometime last week while she was in between patients.

“yeah the beaches here are nice,” Catra replied with her usual nonchalance. *“gotta lookout for sharks though.”*

Adora cackled, then suspiciously looked around her own empty office as if afraid someone would hear her. “LOL 🤭 But if I am not mistaken, you are the shark magnet, Force Captain!” She responded, assuming that Catra was referring to one of their most memorable video game face-offs, one that ended with her opponent’s entire armada being thrown into the water.

“just one of the rare occasions i let you win to keep you motivated, shera)”

“Riiiiight,” she typed with a self-satisfied smirk. “Keep telling yourself that!”

“anyway i wasnt joking about the sharks,” Catra added, attaching a list of links reporting recent shark attacks in her area, consequences of accelerated industrial development without due environmental impact study.

“Oh no that sounds scary!” Adora said after skimming over one of the articles. “I guess farewell to all my beach plans... 👏🏖🌊”

“dont worry, dummy, ill point you to the few places that are safe for swimming if you care about it so much.”

Adora frowned with playful suspicion, holding her chin in her fingertips. "Mmmm. You're not telling me this just to throw me to the sharks, are you? 👀"

"oh trust me, i want you alive :)"

A happy sigh escaped from Adora's throat, her chest bubbling with warmth. "If you say so!"…

"besides"…

"i promise that if you ever show your face here, the sea will be the last thing on your mind."

And with a shiver down her spine, that warmth in her chest turned to a heat of a very different kind.

Four months later, and she still hasn't got used to it, to the intensity of it all, to this roller coaster of emotions every time she feels Catra's presence with her, even though it is a physical impossibility.

The first time they chatted on video, Adora was so mesmerized by the whole experience that she barely managed to utter any coherent sentences. Luckily, on that occasion, they were in the middle of watching an episode of *Mara, the Dragon Tamer*, so Adora's dumbfounded expressions could safely pass as reactions to events portrayed on the show. She disguised her nervousness towards Catra's virtual image by saying things like "Uuuuh nope, don't do this! Mara still cares about you!" and "Pffffwhoa, I can't wait to see them reconcile," when in fact her heart was pounding for reasons related to her own sapphic drama, not the one implied on screen.

And to this day, it only takes a single glance at Catra's face for Adora to feel like she's been struck by lightning and suddenly she's 13 years old again, when her hormones were starting to kick in and she couldn't understand why she felt so compelled to watch anything starring Carrie-Anne Moss or Milla Jovovich, no matter how bad it was.

To this day, she still closely watches the way Catra's lips move to pronounce her name, savoring how the corners of her mouth curl into a smile as she finishes saying her infallible *"Hey, Adora."*

To this day, Adora temporarily forgets how greetings are supposed to go when Catra's moving image appears, and she feels the urge to say something like "Fuck, I can't get over the fact that you're freaking gorgeous," only to stumble over her words, feeling too silly to finish what she was going to say and instead mumbling something random about Tung and Lashor, the two lizards she treated at work that day.

To this day, she tries to recompose and catch her breath by looking away from the screen, but it doesn't take long before her face is drawn back to Catra's magnetic different-colored eyes, her wild hair, and her sassy grin, and to this day it doesn't take long for Adora to get lost wondering how it is possible that someone so beautiful has been even allowed into this lifetime and how miraculous it is that they are *together*, even though they are thousands of miles and seven time zones away from each other.

With that notion and her mouth slightly parted, to this day, Adora freezes.

"*What's the matter, princess?*" Catra usually asks with a sexy knowing smirk. *"Did the cat get your tongue?"*

"I wish!" Adora scoffs with a mischievous grin and a roll of her eyes. She shakes her head, looking at her own flushed cheeks and dilated pupils on the computer screen, then at Catra's image again, and the truth comes out. "Well, uh-- It's just that... I still can't believe how gorgeous you are."

Catra snickers modestly before saying something like *"oh, and I can't believe how cheesy you are."* Then she looks down, her mouth breaks into a shy smile, and a faint blush appears on her face. Her eyes dart up and to the right, focusing on a fixed spot on her computer screen. Her expression changes to something more

serene, and Adora knows she's not looking at anything but *her* when she says "*but yeah, I, uh...I know what you mean* ."

They are avoiding more definitive words like *girlfriend*, as part of their agreement to "see where this takes them"as slowly and carefully as possible. They wouldn't want to jump the gun by creating unrealistic expectations in terms of what this could or could not become.

They talk to each other several times a day, every day, and if for some reason they don't, Adora misses it. They are so entangled in each other's routines that the label seems more like a formality at this point.

In their day to day, there is intimacy and trust, saucy photos, and provocative conversations that have Adora climbing up the walls.

"Oh, I had a dream about you the other day ," Catra whispered to her one of these nights, slow and sultry, sending out that jolt of electricity that never fails to remind Adora of how alive she is.

"Really? And how did that go?" Adora dared to ask, though she could sense from Catra's inflection where this was going.

"We were at a nightclub at first. Dancing. T aking a few drinks. It was someone's birthday, I think. Y our friends were there, and so were mine. We all knew each other somehow ."

"A w, that sounds like fun. I'm not a very dancer , though,"Adora admitted with an embarrassed chuckle. "I'm sort of clumsy ."

"Well, you were doing a very good job in the dream."

"Oh, yay!" She cheered, celebrating the fact that some version of her can look good on the dance floor. "Go, dream me."

Catra chuckled, then continued to tell her story. *"Anyway , of course, the dancing part didn't last long"...*

With a smile, Adora sensed the bait swinging in front of her eyes. "No? Why was that?" She said, clearing her throat to keep a steady voice.

"Well, we kind of had something else in mind," Catra snickered suggestively, her tone becoming more seductive at each sentence. *"So we went back to your place. Or at least I think it was your place. And then I took off the red dress you were wearing and had you pressed against the apartment door. Then my mouth and my hands were all over you, kissing you, touching you... exploring you. It all felt so good, so real. And I wanted you so bad – I mean, we wanted each other so bad that we did it right there in the living room. Against the wall, then on the floor , then on the couch, again and again."*

Adora merely whimpered back, closing her eyes to give space to her imagination, yielding to the flashes of her own fantasies about Catra. She pressed herself against the sweaty sheets, wishing Catra's dream could instead be a premonition, a harbinger of their near future. "You have no idea how much I want this to be true someday."

"Oh, believe me, princess. I do."

But their newly-established relationship has a lot more than flirting and shameless foreplay over the phone.

There is support and metaphorical hand-holding when life takes a disappointing turn. When Catra was fired from her part-time job as an English teacher and her mother gave her shit for never holding a steady job, Adora had very strong opinions. "With all due respect to the person that brought you into this world, but what a bitch 😠"And when Adora lost her first dog patient, when she couldn't stop crying and felt like a complete failure, like her life lacked meaning or purpose, Catra comforted her. *"i wish i could do more than just say this, princess, but im so sorry you are going through this. and I know it's frustrating because i am sure you did everything you could... but sometimes... it's out of our hands."*

When there's reason to celebrate, they are there. Adora followed the entire editing process of Catra's book and even gave an opinion about the cover art. Catra rejoiced when Adora got word that her brother was getting married and asked her to be his best man.

There are big, life-changing moments, yes, but there are also those little, simple moments that seem so trivial they could go unnoticed. Like the day Catra told Adora why she decided to become a writer, or what it was like to grow up in a conservative upper-class environment and a strict mother. Or the time Catra listened to Adora talk about her childhood, and how she would always have to work harder than her brother to get her parents to recognize her accomplishments.

Binge-watching *Mira* together, having passionate discussions about music or volleyball, talking for hours before bed, asking each other to text to let them know they've come home after a night out with friends.

All of these moments, the sum of them, make it all feel more solid than any previous relationship Adora has had.

Now it's four, almost five months later, and Adora can't imagine her life without Catra anymore. Time went by so fast, it feels like an eternity, she can't even remember how it was before. In contrast, time doesn't seem to pass quickly enough: she is still two months away from her financial goal to finally be able to afford those precious tickets.

"You know, Adora... of course this distance thing is a bitch, but sometimes... I gotta say, I am sort of glad we don't live close to each other." Catra told her a couple of nights ago when they were both in bed - Adora getting ready for sleep, Catra still waking up.

"Oh, yeah, sure, I understand," Adora teased with a cocky grin on her face, swallowing a yawn. "You would crush on me so hard that it would keep you from being a functional human being."

Catra snorted, the sound of her laugh boosting Adora's serotonin level to the max. *"Seriously, why do I even like you?"* She grunted. "*Ugh, it's just that... uh. I'm generally not good with people, and I'm pretty terrible at this opening up and sharing your feelings sort of crap. I usually keep my personal things to myself and just... try to put everything I'm feeling or thinking into my work, my stories. It may sound weird, but I think that if we lived close to each other, we wouldn't have gotten to where we are. I wouldn't have shared some of the things I told you, or, like... shown you what I wrote before publishing. My best friends have no idea that I, uh…*" She then paused for a moment, taking a ponderous breath, and Adora closed her eyes trying to imagine Catra lying by her side instead of thousands of miles away. *"Shit, I don't know. That I pretended to hate artistic gymnastics when I was a kid and failed at it on purpose because my fucking mom cared about it too much, but that I secretly liked it. I never told them anything like that."*

Adora smiled with her eyes still closed, feeling silly, lucky and special at the same time, to be the person Catra trusts with that part of herself. "Wouldn't be good for your brand, right?" She said with a mischievous grin, opening her eyes as if expecting to see Catra, but facing the darkness of her own room instead.

"It wouldn't, no." Adora chuckled at Catra's playful tone, squeezing the mattress just to feel something solid in her hands, something to make up for that lack of contact, to make up for the cold and the emptiness.

"I don't think it's weird." She turned her face to look at the bright cell phone screen on her pillow. "In a way, it's the same for me. Around my friends... Well, not so much around my friends, perhaps especially around my family and at work, there is always this constant pressure, that I can't fail, I have to be perfect, or the costs will be too high. Like I'm the one keeping everything and everyone together, and if I crash, everything will fall apart with me. Everyone expects me to be the one who gets it right, and gets it done, the one who fixes things. And sometimes I feel like I can't just -- Ugh, have

a bad day or something. I have to be this zhuzhed-up, perfect version of myself, at all times. And here...I mean, with you, I can be whoever I want. Just. You know. Me."

Silence hung in the air for a second or two.

"And by you, you mean a big dorkwho says things like huh," Catra mocked, tearing through the delicacy of the moment with her trademark acid humor.

Adora clicked her tongue and hummed. "You really know how to kill the mood, huh, smartass," she added with a heartfelt scoff.

"I'm sorry. Bad timing for a bad joke." Catra chuckled apologetically. *"Force of habit, see? Terrible with people."* She paused again, and Adora could feel in her momentary silence that she was getting a little hesitant on the other end of the line, even unsure perhaps. *"Seriously, though...I hope you can still feel that way when we get together. I hope I don't, uh...push you away or end up scaring you and ruining everything or whatever, like I always seem to do."*

And then there are moments like this one. The moments when the inevitability of what's to come hits Adora harder, like a renewed epiphany that lets her know exactly what awaits her on the road ahead. For these are the moments when Adora knows with absolute certainty that this thing between her and Catra is growing into love, and there's not a damn thing she can do about it.

"Catra," She said with a reassuring tone and a smile that translated all her care. "I really can't imagine that happening."

"Well, I guess we'll see."

Adora is also smiling now, as she turns off her computer and prepares to leave the office, looking forward to that moment two months from now when she will put an end to this standby mode and hopefully give the relationship a more defined consistency. She walks through the Pet Zone hallways to give her inpatients a final

check before heading home to work on the commissioned article she's been writing for a horse magazine.

Taking a careful look at her patients' charts, Adora is pleased to find that Percival's blood glucose is dropping, Loo-Ke is breathing normally and Orko has started eating spontaneously again. She snaps some photos and records a few videos, but before sending the good news to each of their caretakers, she looks for Catra's name on her contact list.

"A good day in the feline wing! All my patients seem to be getting better! 😸" She clicks send with a proud smile, then looks around the room, seeking company.

In addition to the animals, there are two vet assistants there, people she could invite to grab a bite, and who would probably say yes. A few blocks away, Glimmer and Bow would surely join her for dinner or a drink if she decided to call them.

But the company she seeks, she cannot reach. "I wish you could be here so we could celebrate together."

Adora smiles to herself and pauses to consider this bittersweet feeling building within. She realizes that, after four months, this is the first moment in which she has consciously felt the urge to type the words "I love you." They feel big and heavy and incredibly scary, but they also feel true. Yet she refrains from saying them, knowing that her yearning could be deceiving, and remembering their agreement to wait until they meet in person before assessing their feelings. "Thinking of you."

When she hits *send*, she notices that Catra hasn't texted since yesterday evening, nor does she appear to be online now. Huh. Probably ran out of battery or is in the middle of something, of course, nothing to be worried about. She did say she would have a busy week. But it still sits strangely in Adora's stomach when they don't talk, it fills her with this feeling like something is wrong, displaced, or simply missing.

It's funny, though. Missing someone you've never met. Feeling like you could know someone, like you could *love* someone, without ever being in their physical presence. Ah well. The mysteries of relationships, online or otherwise.

For the sake of her sanity, Adora makes the wise decision not to indulge in these thoughts, nor to wonder why Catra didn't text. Fighting the surge of panic, she only hopes that the next two months can pass quickly.

*

8/1 1PM-8/1 1AM

Two thousand words about the advantages of maintaining a stable daily horse care routine, and Adora has decided her article is as good as it's gonna get and accepted Glimmer's invitation to go to this hip restaurant called *The Legend*. It will be more productive than obsessing over why Catra hasn't responded to her messages yet, or wondering where she is, if she's okay, and if by chance she needs something. See, this is how Adora knows long-distance relationships are not for her. Many reasons to be anxious piling on an already anxious person.

But that's not what Adora should be thinking about right now. Nope. Uh-uh. No, what she should be thinking about is what she's going to order. *Just gotta take one last look at her cell phone first...*

A hand quickly snatches the device before she can reach it. "Adora, relax!" Glimmer says with a grin, but then, looking at Adora's murderous expression, her face gets more serious and her tone turns comforting. "Look, I'm sorry, I know you're worried. But it's not like she's going to text you now, it's three in the fucking morning where she lives. She's probably just asleep."

"You're right. You're right!" She repeats, adding a bit of pep to her tone in order to sound less concerned, incorporating that *hushed-*

up, perfect version of herself . "I'm sorry . Everything is fine, let's go back to our girl's night."

"She'll text you as soon as she can, I'm sure."Glimmer gives Adora her cell phone back, then a glint of anger flashes in her eyes. "I mean, she'd better . Otherwise, I'll find a way to fucking *teleport* my ass to Brightmoon so I can punch her in the fucking face, no matter how attractive she is."

Adora laughs, putting her phone in her pocket and trying to follow her best friend's advice. "You sounded like Frosta now."

"Ugh, yeah, I know . I mean, who would have thought, right? The brat drives me crazy and pisses me off to the last nerve, but I kind of miss her now that she's gone off to college,"Glimmer smiles nostalgically, nodding at the nearest waiter to order their drinks.

"That's a great definition of fraternal love right there,"Adora chuckles, thinking back to her own relationship with Adam. Although Frosta isn't Glimmer's blood sister, it's almost like she is - Glimmer's mom and dad, Angella and Micah, are Frosta's godparents, and when Frosta was only a kid and her mother became ill, they took her under their care. "Speaking of which, I went to the tailor to try on the suit for Adam's wedding."

"Nice! Meanwhile, I still need to figure out what I'm going to wear ... I was thinking of that lilac dress I wore to Lance and George's anniversary last month, but I'm not sure."

"That one is gorgeous, you should go for it."Adora says, taking a long sip of her newly arrived beer. "Time's going by so fast, I can't believe the wedding is just around the corner ."

"Yeah, tell me about it. But anyway, I bet *you* look *smoking hot* in that suit."Glimmer states playfully , giving Adora a gentle nudge and a flirtatious wink, to which Adora smiles modestly. "Are there pictures?"

“Oh! Yes, hang on, Ill show you,” Adora takes her cell phone from her pocket, casually noticing she hasnt received any new message before opening her image gallery. She feels a little uneasy and frustrated again, but manages to swallow it all. If she and Catra are really going to do this, she needs to get used to not hearing from her sometimes.

As Glimmer gushes over her photos and they talk about life, work and relationships while having drinks and some delicious frito pie, Adora succeeds in letting her worries go for the rest of the night.

6:00 AM - 6:28 AM

There is something ringing, but Adora isnt sure if it’s real or if it’s a part of her dream. The sound gets louder, then she feels something hot and wet and a little stinky on her face, recognizing Swifty’s weight on the bed as she regains consciousness. She wakes up and begins to pet the beagle with a loving smile, though she’s experiencing a minor headache - the result of her alcoholic forays with Glimmer last night.

Accustomed to waking up early, Adora doesn't let the slight hangover shake her and quickly gets up from the bed, searching for the insistent ringing sound. She finds her phone in the back pocket of her pants, which is lying on the bedroom floor. Device in hand, she’s just missed a voice call from Catra’s contact, and her heart jumps in her chest. She’s about to call it back when the phone rings again.

She answers immediately. “Catra?! Hey!”

“Hey, Adora.”

Hearing Catra's voice, Adora feels a surge of adrenaline that immediately makes her forget about the headache or any worry she's felt for the past 48 hours. “I was wondering how you were doing.”

“Yeah, sorry about that, I was out of service for a while, then I had nowhere to charge my cell phone, then I was out of service again… Anyway , it was a whole thing.”

"It’ s okay,”Adora says reassuringly , a grin on her face as she throws herself in the armchair in the living room. "Everything is fine, then?"

“Everything is okay , yeah. Just uh”… Catra pauses, and Adora notices in her hesitation that she sounds a little tired. *“So, yeah, remember how I told you that my editor invited me to do a reading at that event with queer authors, to promote the book?”*

"Y eah, sure, you told me that a while ago,”Adora replies a bit casually. And then, with renewed enthusiasm, she adds: "Oh my God, is that happening already?"

Catra chuckles. *“Yeah, it’s happening tomorrow.”*

"That’ s exciting!"Adora applauds, one of her legs going over the arm of the chair as she adjusts into a more relaxed position. "I'm proud of you."

“So, uh. It’ s gonna be hosted by this place called, uh – hold on… The... Cephalopods Literary Corner .”

Adora creases her eyebrows, noticing a strange coincidence while biting an awkward smile. "That’ s funny, there’s a bookstore with that name like 10 minutes from where I live, in Elberon. I didn't know they were international!"

“Well. That’ s the thing. They are not,” Catra replies, and Adora senses something different about her tone, but she can't tell exactly what it is.

She takes another guess, reaching for the TV remote to check the morning news. "Oh, uh, so they're holding the event at your local bookstore or something?"

“Getting colder , princess,” Catra scoffs teasingly, and Adora then begins to recognize the background sounds that are leaking through the call.

Crowd noise, a ding, a kind of artificial voice giving information, someone offering taxi service in English. Nearly 48 hours of radio silence, no phone service, then no place to charge her phone...

“Oh!” Adora exclaims, jumping up from her seat. “Oh!” She repeats.

“Yeah.” Catra laughs, though a bit bashfully. *“That took you a while, huh?”*

Adora paces the room, Swifty follows her confusedly, and she can't hide her excitement in her words. “You're not serious! No, you can't! -- this. No! This can't be serious! Are you serious!?”

“I am.”

Almost pinching herself to make sure she isn't dreaming, Adora tries to remember how to fucking *breathe*.

AM AM

Chapter End Notes

> Yeah, it wouldn't be me if I didn't leave you hanging with the cliffhanger, so... sorry?
> Or, not sorry.
> Bright side: I should be posting the next chapter sooner rather than later (hopefully!)
>
> I learned so many new words while writing this chapter and I have to credit @amenfever for giving me the word “zuzh” and @itomart for teaching me about “prospective.” You are amazing!
>
> I should also add that I named Catra's city as “Dovale” because, in Brazil, when we want to imply if someone is queer , we say

they are "From the valley", so he-he-he-he. V ery cheesy, I know.

Thank you so much for reading! I really hope you enjoy it.

Do Not Disturb

Chapter Summary

In which Catra and Adora meet in person for the first time.

(CW: they may get a bit carried away)

Chapter Notes

Hello :) I have missed you. I am sorry to be taking so long between updates, because this is a story I have a lot of fun writing, and I hope at some point I'll be able to increase my pace but I really can't promise it. For now, I'm just glad to be here again with another update :)

To compensate for the wait (which seems to be an ongoing topic in the chapter itself), I bring you many more words than my usual, so I hope you enjoy my verbiage burst :)

As usual, I'd like to thank you for reading, and I really hope you enjoy this chapter - if you do, I hope you share your thoughts on the comment section :)

Fair warning: I raised the rating to E. I think by now we all know what it means. Also: a quick hint of homophobia.

Hope you enjoy the chapter!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

08:03 AM

"Good morning! My name is Emily and I am sending this message on behalf of the Eight Zone to inform you that unfortunately your appointment with dr. Adora this afternoon needed to be canceled. We can either reschedule for the same time next week or if you wish

to keep the appointment, dr . uliet would be happy to take a lookat lizzie! he is one of our most experienced and well-regarded veterinarians 😊"

Untara snarls and rolls her eyes. This is not the news she wanted to receive. She is very particular about who examines her pet Chinese water dragon, and Adora may be an annoying overachiever who just got out of her diapers, but she is competent and kind to Lizzie and has earned Untara's trust.

The woman scratches her forehead and brushes the strand of white hair that falls over it, then glances at Lizzie in his aquarium, all lethargic and sad and refusing to eat. Her heart feels small with concern for her pet. She may not like it, but...

"I don't like changing plans at the last minute." She types, gritting her teeth. "But fine. I'll keep the appointment."

"Perfect! 😊 I will let dr. uliet know! Thankyou so much for understanding!"

Ugh. Untara then remembers why she hates this Emily character so much. The way she talks, even the way she texts, it always sounds so fake, so artificial.

"Not like I can do anything about it, can I?" She replies with an audible click of her tongue, still dissatisfied with the solution, hoping that at least there is a reasonable explanation for Adora to cancel the appointment. She stares at the screen for a moment, snaps her fingers, grunts.

Then curiosity defeats her. "Why did doc blondie have to cancel anyway?"

"D . Adora had an urgent personal matter to attend to 😊"

8:45 AM

The girl has been wandering through the store's aisles for a while, hesitantly picking up and returning different types of bottles of wine and champagne. From his place in the line to checkout, Rogelio watches as the shop's sommelier tries to help the undecided and nervous customer make up her mind.

"What's the occasion, darling?" they ask, and as his wait is a bit tedious, Rogelio entertains himself by reading their lips out of the corner of his eye. "What is this friend of yours like? I mean, how would you define her character?" continues the sommelier. "Does she prefer red, white or rosé?" they question. "If it's a special occasion, can I interest you in this sparkling wine from the Northern Reach? Ambrosian stuff. I promise you won't regret it."

They pass by Rogelio to continue their search. "Excuse me," the girl says to him with a friendly smile, and as he gestures back to her, he realizes he's seen that blue-eyed blonde somewhere before, and he thinks he knows where. To confirm his suspicions, he takes out his cell phone and snaps a covert photo of her.

"Isn't this one of your clients? The one with the beagle?"

Ankle is typing...

It doesn't take long for the response to arrive.

"Yep! It's adora! She's very nice! In fact I'm on my way to take Swifty for a walk right now!"

"I'm getting some wine for tonight." The cashier waves to Rogelio to let him know it's his turn to check out, and he has to shift his attention away from Adora's conversation to put his purchases on the conveyor belt.

"Oo fancy!" Rogelio grins discreetly at the message, then to the cashier as they start checking out his items. *"And adora is there too??"*

"Yes, same. It looks like she's about to meet a very special person because she's being very thorough in her search for the perfect wine. It's sweet." Rogelio types, scanning the store and noting that Adora has finally found a bottle of Alwynean wine that she seems satisfied with. "By the way , what time should I pick you up tonight?"

Rogelio turns his attention to the cashier, handing his credit card, then typing his pin code. He is organizing his purchases into paper bags when he catches a glimpse of Adora taking her place at the end of the line, bottle in hand, and an eager look in her eyes.

As he's about to leave the store, he frowns when noticing that he has still not received an answer. "U there?"

"Sorry ! Almost crashed my bike because I was texting"
Rogelio's eyes go wide with concern, but he is relieved to read the follow-up message: *"But Im ok! XO"*

Rogelio smiles lovingly. This sweet dork is his guy, his person, and for better or worse, he's glad they found each other. Before leaving, he shoots one last glance at Adora, still waiting in line, and while he may not know her, he wishes with all his heart that she, too, had found her person.

09:00 AM

Roses are cheesy and too obvious. Daisies are... apparently a source of childhood trauma, for some strange reason the customer has preferred not to share. Lilies are, in her words, "for serious commitments and I really don't know if we're there yet and wouldnt want to scare her off on our first meeting."

Seneschal cannot even begin to understand the relationship between this adorably anxious customer and the Elfmoonian girl she wants to give flowers to, but nevertheless, he feels compelled to help.

And when it comes to flowers, he knows it's best to ask the expert.

"Hey boss," he types while walking into the small garden they keep behind the store. "So there's this blonde girl here and she really digs this other girl from Halfmoon, right? Like they have been flirting for months and the girl's here now and they are about to meet for the first time and now she cant decide on what flower to get. She wants to show the girl is special and that she values their relationship and all that but not like in a way that would put too much pressure, you know?"

He hits send, then adds: "Sounds intense but she's like super sweet and I totally ship them!"

The response comes a few moments later.

"Ooo, fun! I love being part of flourishing relationships and, most importantly, I love the challenge of finding the perfect flower (lol) 💍💐 *Did you show her our orchid collection? We have a blue one at the back of the garden, and nothing says a girl is special like a blue orchid!"*

Seneschal mumbles a low "*oh yeah, that could work*," and goes in search of said orchid.

He is reaching for the vase when his phone beeps again.

"You can also show her the hazel bouquets because they mean inspiration! Also, ranunculus are the perfect 'I have a crush on you' flowers (lol) and of course, forsythias stand for spring sun and anticipation after a long winter, which by itself offers beautiful and very positive symbolism!"

"All dope suggestions boss!" Seneschal replies, his mind blown by the unexpected excess of information, his eyes roaming the area to locate the flowers. "Tks!"

"Glad to be of help! 💐💐"

He walks through the garden, putting the suggested arrangements on a small cart. When he sees a rare mandacaru flower, a discreet "whoa" escapes from his mouth. "Hey boss, what about this rad cactus? 🌵🌵 Does it mean like something special?"

Perfuma is typing…

The young salesman sticks his finger in the thorn of the plant as he waits for an answer.

*"Seneschal, I need you to read this very carefully. I appreciate you as an employee, and I value your enthusiasm, and I don't mean to sound negative or bring you down in any way, but I'm **NOT**, and I repeat I am **NOT** discussing cacti with you again."*

With wide eyes and a grimace, the hippie florist hisses. "Whoa ok chill bro, that was my bad! I'll stick to your suggestions boss!"

"Best of luck to the sweet couple 💝"

11:12 AM

Is this really happening?

For four months, Adora has been waiting. Exciting and thrilling at its best, torturous and painful at its worst, she thinks this bittersweet exercise of patience may have changed the meaning of the verb in her mind. Or perhaps "wait" is not the best word to express what she has been doing, exactly. She has been waiting, yes, but it didn't keep her or Catra from turning their relationship into something solid and consistent, it didn't keep her feelings from growing and their intimacy from cementing.

She has been waiting, but she has been also busy making plans, ticking boxes, filling her mind with small but tangible tasks that would bring her a few steps closer to her goal.

All this time, she kept herself moving, so the waiting wouldn't make her crazy.

Then the tables turned without any previous notice and what should have been another two months of waiting was compressed into one morning.

One morning for Catra to settle into her hotel and get some rest, by her own reqest. One morning Adora spent giving her patients a final checkup before clearing her schedule for the rest of the day, then browsing through multiple stores to keep her mind occupied and ultimately waiting in the hotel lobby until the clock ticked 11:30 am, the time they had agreed to meet for lunch.

Or, well. 11:27. That’s close enough, right?

Adora has waited four months, yes, and yet it's this morning that nearly breaks her. More specifically, it's the two-minute elevator ride to Catra's hotel room floor.

See, with nothing left to do but wait, at the mercy of the fucking slowest piece of metal in the universe, with no task or immediate goal to focus on, Adora feels it all at once: the adrenaline-fueled anticipation of seeing Catra for the first time, plus the panic stemming from the unpleasant qestions she's been trying to push aside.

Needless to say, she is on the verge of a panic attack.

What if it doesnt go as well as she hopes? What if she’ s not good enough? What if Catra thinks all of this, the wine and the flowers and Adora, is dumb and stupid or just.too much?

Adora closes her eyes and reminds herself to breathe, filling her lungs with reassurance. And although the paranoia is trying to get the best of her, she smiles when she considers it's been a long, long time, that she's not as afraid of losing something as she's afraid of losing Catra.

Scary as it may be, this is a feeling she wants to hold on to.

The elevator stops. Adora opens her eyes and tells herself that it will be okay, that this is what she wanted and she's finally about to have it. The door opens and all her thoughts, paranoid or otherwise, are abruptly swept away. Adora stops bracing herself for whatever she has been bracing herself for because what she sees in front of her is both the cause and the remedy for those mixed emotions.

Catra. Not a catgirl avatar in a video game, not a text message on her cellphone, not a picture, not a video, not a voice memo. Fully fleshed and three-dimensional, standing in the hallway with her arms crossed and a relaxed stance against the wall, wearing dark jeans, a long white t-shirt, and a black leather jacket.

Right in front of her, looking at her.

And holy fucking shit, she's *beautiful*.

Actually, no, forget about beautiful: she is here.

Catra's *here*. She has traveled halfway around the world, spent almost two days changing planes and hanging around motels and airports, and she did it so she could get *here*. She did it to be with Adora.

It may sound stupid, and it probably is, but only now does Adora realize that all this time she's been waiting for Catra, Catra has been waiting for her too.

And that surge of panic turns into something else entirely.

"Hey, Adora," Catra chuckles lightly because of course that is the greeting she would use.



The magnetic look in her eyes, the deep consistency of her voice, the slight blush that breaks through her bronze complexion, the way she takes both her hands to her pockets, are all so genuine that Adora is suddenly too overwhelmed to move.

Is this really happening?, she asks herself again, completely frozen.

Without having the decency of waiting for Adora's brain to restart, the elevator doors almost close on her again. Thankfully, Catra's foot rushes in, preventing her early departure.

Okay, Adora, this is really fucking happening, and you better get yourself moving.

"Hey ," she smiles from ear to ear , finally making her way to Catra.

She places the bag with the wine on the floor and takes a good look at Catra standing before her, shaking her head because a part of her

still cant believe it, a little afraid of touching Catra and finding she's just a figment of her imagination. But then she smells Catra' s perfume, and she sees the expectant gleam in her eyes, and she cant keep herself from plunging forward.

Adora embraces Catra with a hug that is both awkward and comforting - a hug for everything that is already part of their history and for everything that is still unknown, for everything that's ahead of them, for whatever story they are about to start writing.

With her eyes closed and her face buried in Catra's hair, Adora takes in her scent for the very first time, and she knows in her heart that from now on that smell will always bring her back here. And although the grip of her arms around the girl's waist is tight, her mind is calm and her body is relaxed for the first time in months, maybe in years. Because as she lets the pressure of Catra's body and the warmth of her skin introduce them to a brave new world of smell and touch and flavor, Adora feels like she can finally - *finally!* - stop waiting.

"I cant believe youre here," she admits, her left hand clutching the leather jacket, her right holding the flowers behind Catra' s back.

"You'd better believe it, princess," Catra replies with a light scoff, her hands now resting on Adora's hips, their heads nestled against each other's shoulders. "Otherwise, Ill turn into a pumpkin."

"Please dont," Adora laughs, her arms still wrapped around Catra' s waist. She doesnt want to let go, but a spark of consciousness reminds her that she has to. "Oh, hey , here, I, uh... This is for you," she says timidly, breaking the embrace just enough to hand Catra the floral arrangement.

"You corny sap," Catra turns her attention to the flowers with a discreet smile, then she looks up at Adora again. "You know you didnt have to do this."

"I know ," Adora says with a knowing grin, stepping back to give Catra space to get a better look at the flowers. "But it' s not like I would

show up here empty-handed."

"Of course. You're too much of a princess for that, aren't you?" Catra taunts, fixing her with a look and a smirk that remind Adora *exactly* why they are here. "I wonder if I can get you to break a rule or two while I'm here."

Ah, so there it is. That shortness of breath, that weakness in Adora's knees. If there were any doubts that Adora's online attraction to Catra would hold up in her physical presence, they vanish with that quick exchange of words and glances.

"How long will you be staying, again?" She coughs and clears her throat, trying to brush off her most immediate urges, figuring it's probably too soon to be thinking about whatever she's thinking right now. "I-I don't remember if you told me, and if you did, *heh*, I'm sorry, I guess I was too busy recovering from the shock of your sneaky arrival."

"Oh, yeah." Catra's smirk grows wider. "And how did you like the surprise?"

"You once told me you wanted me alive, so I don't know what your endgame was," Adora says humorously. "Because that was a risky move, Force Captain."

Catra laughs. "Sorry. It was a long shot, and at first, I didn't know if it was going to happen at all. Even when the publisher finally sorted it all out I guess a part of me was waiting for it to go wrong. I only believed it was for real when I got on the plane."

"I know what you mean," Adora admits, and Catra smiles at her fondly.

"But anyway, I'm staying for a week -- or, well, sort of. There's the event tomorrow, then I'll have this boring meeting with Netossa on Monday, so only five days, really."

"That's too bad," Adora blurts out impulsively. "N-not that I'm complaining, trust me, it's wonderful that you're here. It's just kind of unfortunate because it's such a short trip, there's so much we -- so much you can do around here."

"Yeah. One more reason I shouldn't waste any time." She pauses, looks into Adora's eyes. "Don't you think?"

And there's *that* look. That flirty, malicious look, full of intention. Adora's seen it hundreds of times before, in video calls and pictures, and you would think all of that would have prepared her to actually face it, but of course, nothing could have prepared her for Catra.

Not really.

"Uh... And what do you, uh... What do you want to do? Like, where do you want to go? Anything in particular on your mind?" She asks, running her fingers through the strand of hair that escapes her ponytail and then tucking them behind her ear.

"Yeah, there are a few things I've been meaning to do during my stay." Catra grins suggestively, shooting a look at Adora's fingers on her hair. "But of course, that's not only up to me."

Different colored eyes inspect Adora as if they were posing a question to which they already know the answer. Adora's gaze is drawn to Catra's lips, and there they stay. The thought of kissing Catra crosses Adora's mind and settles into it, like an itch she has to scratch if she plans on staying sane. She swallows, inhales and exhales, tries to think of something else, tries to remind herself that they have only met five seconds ago, but that urge, that need to eliminate the distance between them, doesn't go away.

The silence lingers, thick with the tension that emerges between them.

Thankfully, Catra changes the subject.

“W ell, uh, what are these, anyway?” She asks, turning to the flowers again, her freckles covered in an almost imperceptible blush. “I don’t think I’ve ever seen them before.”

“Uh -- Oh! Oh, glad you asked, these are, *heh* -- these are *Serenias*,” Adora imposes her voice to give it a somewhat professorial tone, so proud to have taken all those notes from the stoner guy at the flower shop. “They are these wildflowers that grow in the Etherian desert, around the Crimson Waste region, which is like... W ell, basically it’s a dead-zone, nothing grows there other than a few species of poisonous cacti,” she reaches out to touch the colored petals, so smooth and beautiful. “Y et these little guys... they bloom. And they are beautiful. Despite the climate and the soil and all the adversities that they face, they find a way to survive. I think it’s... I think it’s extraordinary.”

Catra glances at Adora again, a knowing smirk on her lips, but she’s not being flirty now. No, her look is somewhat tender, as if to show she has received the not-so-subtle message behind the gift. She takes her nose to the orange and blue flower arrangement and sniffs them, seemingly pleased with their scent. “Thanks. That was very thoughtful of you. And geeky, obviously.”

“W ell, geeky and thoughtful is kind of my brand, so,” Adora says with a goofy smile and a modest eye-roll. “That was what I was going for.”

“Y ou nailed it, then,” Catra snickers, a sound even more beautiful now that Adora can witness it firsthand. “Though I wouldn’t expect any less from a dork like you,” she adds, touching the middle of Adora’s forehead with her index finger, and Adora involuntarily leans into the touch.

“W ait until you hear about the wine I got us,” she grins. “It’s gonna crack your expectations right open.”

“I’ll hopefully be drunk or asleep when we get to that part of your lecture,” she sasses, and Adora lightly punches her on the shoulder, pretending to be offended while chuckling along with her. “No, I’m

messing with you, obviously. This is great, Adora. I... I really appreciate it."

Their laughter dies down, and Adora notices how close they are to one another, how they gravitated towards each other's bodies again, foreheads and noses almost touching, mouths so dangerously close that Adora has to make a conscious effort not to kiss her right then.

"Uh. Shouldn't we get going? I mean, to get lunch and all?"

"Yeah, I guess." Catra's breath caresses Adora's lips. "But first, if you don't mind, there's something I wanted to try. Something I wanted to give you in return."

Adora's eyes widen, and she bites her bottom lip when she feels a hand on her waist again, the smile on Catra's face and the light in her eyes filling her mind with dirty thoughts of where their first encounter would end.

"W-well, there's, uh - no expectation of reciprocity, of course."

"Yeah, yeah, how very generous of you." Catra's smirk grows, and she's stroking Adora's side with just the tip of her finger, and the thought of *not* kissing her is beginning to sound atrocious. "I still want to, though," she says, taking a step forward. "If you let me."

They are so, so close. Adora looks at Catra's mouth and feels that kind of pull you feel when you're about to jump off a high place and decide to look down, a mix of wonder and attraction with a hint of danger, like a fall you know it's coming but you don't really want to avoid.

"And what is it?" She asks, too eager to be able to try for a more clever retort, her gaze still locked on Catra's lips, her face vaguely leaning forward and towards that irresistible mouth.

Catra smiles, bites her bottom lip, and gives Adora's waist a gentle squeeze before her hand moves around her shoulder blade to press

them even closer. Adora notices when Catra swallows, when her eyes shut and her mouth opens slightly, and the sound of her heartbeat takes over the hallway in anticipation of what is about to happen.

Even though she sees it coming, the kiss still takes her by surprise. It's timid and sweet and a little messy in the best of ways, as first kisses sometimes are, but it's also powerful like a jolt of electricity, better than any dream or fantasy. And I could give you one hundred corny analogies to describe how she feels right now, like floating mid-air, bells ringing, sirens singing or fireworks blowing in her chest, and while that romantic crap would work, it would also fall short in comparison to how she *actually* feels.

Words, it seems, are only useful up to a point; and this moment, this encounter, this kiss, is far beyond that threshold. Adora is happy to realize that, for the first time in her relationship with Catra, verbal language isn't the only means she has to express how she feels.

"This." Adora mumbles moronically when their mouths part, her eyes still shut, her mouth still moist from Catra's lips. "Wow, Im, uh… I didnt know you liked flowers so much. If I knew, *heh*, let's just say I-I would have brought a lot more."

"Yes, princess, you've got me, I have a secret crush on flowers," Catra says with a low and ironic scoff, lightly touching Adora's lip with the tip of her thumb. "No, idiot, I just... Weren't you wondering? I figured we were probably wondering what this was going to be like. At least I know that I was, so I thought we deserved to get this... impending issue or whatever out of our system."

"Uh-huh, uh-huh, yep, very good thinking," Adora nods repeatedly, her arms slung around Catra's neck, the urge to kiss her one more time sparking. "Did it work for you? I mean, is it... out of your system?"

"Hmm." Catra purses her lips, looks to the ceiling, pretends to be thinking. "Not exactly, no," she grins sarcastically. "How about you?"

Adora shakes her head with a dopey smile. "Maybe it would work if we gave it another try?" She says, closing her eyes as she dives forward again.

Alas, it's the *ding* of the elevator door opening behind them that reminds Adora of where they are: a very public, with many surveillance cameras, hotel corridor.

With a self-conscious gasp, Adora jumps back. "Oh! Sorry!" She makes room for the two clearly shocked guests to exit the elevator. "Sorry!" At the repetition, Catra glances at her and squints suspiciously, then looks back at the couple.

"*Excuse* us," the man says in a bellicose tone, the expression on his face clearly showing that the ongoing sapphic PDA he interrupted was not to his liking.

"What, you didn't like the welcome committee? Too bad. I guess we have to keep working to improve it then," Catra winks and waves to the newcomers, smirking, putting her arm around Adora's shoulder to pull her closer. "But wait until you see our private shows, I'm pretty sure they'll blow your mind."

The man grunts, the woman blushes, then the two guests awkwardly walk past them to make their way down the hall, carrying their luggage. "Hope you enjoy your stay!" Catra says with noticeable sarcasm, and Adora watches her watching them go, so confident and bold and sexy with her messy long hair falling over her face, and the vision highlights the lingering taste of her lips on Adora's mouth.

She's still staring like an idiot when Catra turns to her again.

"Not that I'm sorry about those losers," she says with a mischievous smile, "but maybe that's our cue to get a room?"

"Uh. Do you mean, like." The idea of entering with Catra in an enclosed space takes Adora's mind to very indecent places. Her breath catches and her throat goes dry when she wonders how

Catra's skin would react to the light touch of her fingertips or the firm grip of her nails. "Well, if you're *sure*. I think we could, uh, if you want --"

"Someone's got a dirty mind," Catra sasses. Again, Adora briefly worries about wanting too much, about *being* too much, too fast. "Relax, dummy, I meant literally. I should take these to my room," she casts a glance at the flowers in her hand and the wine on the floor.

"Oh, pfffft yeah! Sure, totally, of course, that's what you meant, *heh*."

"Though I wouldn't mind a little make-out session while we're at it," she winks humorously, and Adora can't see her own face right now but she *knows* it must be red. Of course, she wants to be with Catra, I mean, that's basically the only thing in her mind right now, but she's also afraid that skipping steps and jumping into bed could somehow spoil the prospects of their relationships.

And Catra must have picked up on it, because, as they walk side by side and down the hallway, she nervously adds: "But hey, I don't want to impose or assume anything or whatever if -- if you think it's too soon, or you don't feel like it at all. I came here to see you, and that's basically that, regardless of what happens. I'm sorry if I rushed anything or if I made it weird, uh." She clears her throat. "Too late to say that now, I guess, but what I mean is I'm cool with whatever you are cool with."

Adora grins warmly; her overall anxiety starts to ease. As much as she loves Catra's assertiveness, what really gets her heart melting are those subtle moments when she lets her vulnerabilities show. And right now, her chest is so filled with affection that she no longer cares if they are in a public space when she leans in to kiss her again.

"It's okay," she says, tenderly pressing her lips to Catra's in a gentle peck, wrapping her arms around her. "Believe me, nothing is weird,

this is everything I --"She sighs. "I'm just. A little all over the place, is all."

"Yeah, I know," Catra replies with her eyes still closed, taking Adora's hand on hers. "The clusterfuck, right?" Adora nods in agreement, grinning as she feels like they are on the same page. "Will you tell me if it's too much or too fast or whatever?"

Adora smiles at Catra's choice of words, thinking that perhaps the traditional concepts of *too much* or *too fast* dont have to apply to them, as they've lived so much together and been through so much already, perhaps not in the way other couples do, but in their own way. This means they are the ones who get to make their own rules, as long as they are clear to both of them.

"I promise," she vows.

She's waited so long for this - they both have - and it doesn't seem fair to wait another second. So, Adora yields to her wants.

They allow the kiss to become bolder, steamier, more passionate. Catra's tongue asks to enter Adora's mouth, the hand on the back of her neck closes tightly around her skin, grabbing a chunk of hair, and the unexpected tug on her scalp triggers a surge of arousal that manifests in goosebumps and makes her knees go weak. A hint of teeth, a hint of nails, fingers in search of skin, and Adora smiles against Catra's lips when invaded by the notion that this *is* really happening.

"I'm so, so happy you're here," she whispers, placing a chaste kiss on Catra's chin, her hands finding their way under the black leather jacket to hold her even closer, and she clings to Catra's smell, to her warmth, and to her comfort, and she *wants* and she wishes her want could be strong enough to keep Catra here not just for a week, but for as long as she felt like staying.

*

Catra's mouth is hot, her lips are smooth, savory, and moist, and her breath has a vague scent of mint combined with her own unique flavor, which is already becoming Adora's favorite flavor in the world. Her hands are agile and sneaky, curious wanderers traveling through Adora's body without asking for permission, but also watching for any signs of resistance that might indicate if she's crossing a line.

Maybe they've been switching between talking and making out for only a few minutes. Maybe they've been doing it for hours on end - on the bed, on the desk, against the wall, on the armchair. Time is so relative here that neither they know, nor they care. What Adora knows is that her lips are swollen, her face is flushed, her breathing is labored, and her sternum is sweating;her lower stomach is aching with desire, and she can't wait to have it sated, but at the same time she figures she'd be perfectly content to keep doing just this: kissing, talking, touching, discovering all each other's secrets that cannot be told in words.

They fit nicely together. Adora is slightly taller and broader than Catra, and the size difference makes kissing a little clumsy at times, but it doesn't seem to bother either of them. In fact, Adora is so amused by it that she spends a considerable time noticing the differences between their bodies, how Catra's hands are smaller than hers, how her dark hair is thicker and fuller than Adora's, how she has a pronounced hipbone that escapes from the waistband of her jeans and that she can feel when their bodies are pressed together. Every single bit of Catra is exquisite, and Adora wants to know it all in detail, no matter how long it takes.

Their pre-established intimacy, their somewhat competitive dynamic translates very naturally into physical chemistry. They met as competitors in a game, and that has always been a part of their relationship, so it's only natural that they would bring this to the bedroom, have fun by creating an atmosphere of playful dispute.

A kind of contest where everyone wins, really.

Still, each of them uses their weapon of choice.

It’s not a surprise that Catra likes to tease. She kisses with hunger, but also with something that Adora can only describe as arrogance, or stubbornness - as if time wasnt an issue, as if she could af ford to take it slow, as if the world would stop turning to wait for them. *“I thinkI would take my time with you,”* Adora can almost hear Catra’s voice in her head as that glorious tongue outlines her lips or goes searching for the sensitive spots on her neckline. *“Make you askfor what you want.”*

It’s deliciously infuriating when she nibbles Adora’bottom lip and then holds back, making Adora chase her mouth for another kiss. And she seems particularly pleased when Adora tightens her grip, squeezes her thigh, or becomes a little more impatient in her advances. “*I would love to be the one who breaks you.”* Adora can read it in her eyes, in that lustful look of hers, how she gets off on driving her wild. *“Who makes you beg.”*

But Catra isn't the only contender here, and Adora, being the quick learner that she is, is taking every opportunity she can to find out what works and what doesn't.

Catra tries to contain herself from showing her own pleasure, maybe so she doesn't feel too exposed and vulnerable in Adora’s hands. She closes her eyes, holds her breath, and bites her lips so she wont make a sound, but Adora can read in her expression that she must be doing something very right. Adora sees it when she presses her fingers into her waist a little tighter, when she grabs and squeezes her ass, when she kisses her neck or when her teeth trace her jugular . And when Adora's fingertips brushed the sensitive skin under Catra’s chin for the first time, and when she couldnt help a small whimper from escaping her mouth, the sound was far more rewarding than Adora could ever have imagined.

She is learning a few things about herself, too. For instance, she hadn't expected to get so riled up and turned on at being teased. But when Catra pushes back, or when her fingers ghost across her belly over her shirt, when they trace the contours of her breasts but purposefully avoid the most obviously sensitive places, a part of

Adora that is a little aggressive and takes what she wants without asking, a part she didn't even know existed, awakens.

That part of her, surprisingly, *also* likes to tease. Usually, she is so focused on pleasuring her partner that postponing it or denying it is not an option she even considers, but with Catra, it's almost irresistible. She wants to see that cool, suave façade dismantled; she wants to be the one who brings Catra to her knees.

Quite literally, in fact.

Of course, she does it in her own way, and sometimes it even happens by accident. Like when Adora interrupts their kisses by throwing the most random questions that run through her head - "How was your flight?" "Did you get enough rest?" "How excited are you about tomorrow's event?" Sure, it starts off innocently enough, but Adora quickly realizes she gets a kick out of watching Catra struggle to keep her voice steady while Adora has her hands firm on her hips, her mouth on her neck and one knee subtly between her legs.

"They wanted me to, uh -- to take part in the event via video conference," a hiss, a pinch on Adora's arm, nails running through her back then digging in her scalp, pulling her hair, hard. "But then I got word that the event was taking place here..." a small whimper, Catra's body jerking forward, almost grinding against Adora's leg.

"Yes?" Adora stops biting Catra's earlobe, presses her harder against the wall, a cocky smile turns on her lips. "Go on, I'm listening," she giggles with a hint of newfound sadism.

Catra looks at her with frustration. "Seriously? *Fine*, you big goof… Long story short, they realized it was important to increase the presence of authors from diverse countries, since -- uh," a moan, Adora's teeth on her neck, Catra's back slamming against the wall. "*Fuck* -- since, you know, it's an event about the value of diversity in queer storytelling," her voice finally breaks when Adora starts sucking the skin above her collarbone.

Adora forgets about lunch, about work, about anything that exists outside the confines of that hotel room. She’s too lost in her own pleasure, too lost in the daze of finding out what makes Catra happy, of finding out what makes them both happy. And now, she’s sitting on the bed with her feet on the floor, and Catra has each of her knees around her hips - straddling her, trapping her, pinning her down with the weight of her body - and Adora has her hands tight on Catra’s ass, and their breasts are pressed against each other, and it’s ridiculous how hot it is, it’s ridiculous that, except for their shoes and for Catra’s jacket, they are both still fully clothed.

But at the same time, it couldn't have happened any other way. They've craved each other's touch for so long, and they've wanted to be together so badly that now that they are here, they try to make the most of it, make their own time, set their own pace, so they can savor every step of this new road they're taking.

And they both know that this road will not be here forever and that, in less than a week, it will be time to say goodbye, and that’s another reason for them to make every minute count.

Catra's thumb goes to Adora's lip, her other hand is pressed to her back under her shirt, and she's leaning close to Adora's ear as if she's going to tell her a secret, but no words come out of her mouth. Instead, she hushes against Adora's earlobe, like a long, sharp exhalation, just this gust of warm air tickling Adora's skin and spreading all over her insides, and as much as she loves foreplay, it’s this small gesture that finally drives her to her limit. She takes Catra's thumb into her mouth, sucks it, bites it, and when she hears Catra whimpering against her and feels her body trembling inside her arms, she senses her last shred of self-control fading away.

She searches for Catra’s gaze, holds it for a moment. Then she takes Catra's hands to the hem of her own shirt, raising her arms so Catra can undress her and unhook her bra. Adora's still looking into Catra's eyes when she sees her bare breasts for the very first time, and she watches as they go wide in surprise and wonder, and she notices the split second when Catra stops to catch her breath, and

that silent form of praise hits her harder than any compliment ever could.

Something about her has made this cool, suave, and sexy badass so meek and tame, and that realization fills Adora with a kind of confidence she's hitherto unknown.

Everything that has been boiling inside her for all these months, every feeling she’s pushed aside, every emotion she’s second-guessed out of fear that it could be only a projection or a side-effect of her loneliness, erupts alive.

It floods through her, all the love she has been saving all this time, all the care, all the affection;it pours out in her kisses and caresses and her sharp lovebites;it pours out in the reverent look she gives when she takes off Catra's shirt and sees her small, firm, perfect breasts for the first time;it pours out in her words of praise, when she says how beautiful and gorgeous Catra is;it pours out as she takes every single bit of Catra in her mouth - fingers, lips, tongue, nipples, and they all taste so, so good.

As she trails down, as she covers Catra's body with her undivided attention, whatever has been building up inside starts making its way out, trying to find its way inside Catra, trying to obliterate any distance between them, and she relishes the way Catra’s stomach flinches at her touch, how she grips her back tighter, how her hand comes behind her neck to guide Adora’s mouth where she needs it to go. Adora loves it about her - how she knows what she wants and how she just takes it.

Their playful dispute ceases.

Adora’s back collapses on the bed at some point in the middle of taking the rest of their clothes off, and she doesnt resist when Catra crawls on top of her, nor when she kneels between her legs, nor when her hands come to spread them wider. And Catra is not teasing anymore when she offers Adora a thigh to grind against,

when she leans in to suck her nipple, and when her hand finally finds the spot that has been calling her the most.

With her mouth still on one of Adora's breasts, Catra opens her eyes to look up at her, and Adora sees it in her gaze, the satisfaction of realizing how wet and ready she is, so much slick that her finger is sliding almost frictionless against her, and *fuck*, it feels so good and Adora's already so close that she doesn't care if she's whimpering or moaning or plain asking for more. Catra sits up on her knees again, so now it's Adora's turn to go after her, leaning on her forearms to kiss her belly, pushing her hips towards Catra's hand and thigh to increase the contact.

Then Catra's hand starts to move faster, and the sensation is so electric and mind-numbing that Adora falls back on the bed again. From her position, she reaches up for Catra's breasts to caress them, and she has both her nipples trapped between her thumbs and fingers when she feels her peak coming, and she becomes increasingly more aware of Catra's finger rubbing her, harder and faster at each turn, and her muscles clench all at once and she knows it's time to let go.

Catra seems to notice it too, because she then leans over her one last time to ask, "come for me, princess," her voice so ragged and shaky that Adora must obey, and the accumulated tension of four months of waiting finally finds its way out of her. The release is quick, and being their first time it's admittedly a little clumsy, but it's so fucking intense Adora's suddenly sorry that it can't last any longer. Soon it's over, and she is left smiling and laughing in exhaustion. Her eyes are watered with pleasure, but there's also a hint of sadness in them, as her orgasm reminds Adora of how fleeting and ephemeral this kind of happiness is, and that is precisely what makes this moment so precious.

When she opens her eyes, she sees Catra smirking at her, in a mixture of awe and self-satisfaction that triggers Adora's competitive side once again.

Adora sits up to kiss her, hard and deep, and Catra moans inside her mouth when her hands start working on Catra's tension. They start to move together again;Catra whimpers as she rides her fingers, clinging to Adora's back with her chin resting on her shoulders to keep from falling, gradually increasing the rhythm of her hips until she also climaxes, and Adora wishes for a brief and selfish moment that they could stay here forever, that this feeling could last forever, but she knows she needs to let it go. Catra's orgasm comes, and Adora feels another rush of pleasure taking her again.

They hold on to each other and breathe together for a moment, Adora sitting on the bed and Catra settled on her lap. Little by little, Adora feels her limbs again, thoughts and senses returning to her slowly, and she feels Catra pressing herself to her even closer, the sting of her nails digging deep into her back.

In silence, they kiss, hug, adjust to a more comfortable position on the bed, their hands clasped, their bodies sweaty, tired, and hot.

"So, I guess you weren't kidding before about your private shows being mind-blowing," Adora jokes while stroking Catra's hair. "I thought you were just trying to piss that guy off."

"That fucking asshole," Catra grumbles, then she kisses Adora's collarbone. "But I'm glad my audience of one seems to be pleased."

"Oh, very pleased, Force Captain" Adora admits with a goofy grin. Catra pokes around on her cell phone and turns on some music, and they quietly enjoy that blissful post-orgasm high. After a short while, her stomach rumbles, and hunger reminds her that this originally was supposed to be a lunch date. "Hey. What time should it be? The last time I checked it was like 11:30, then I totally lost track, *heh*."

Catra scoffs, nuzzling her head into Adora's chest. "Fuck if I know."

??

Chapter End Notes

Hmmm, I just love them, and I had fun expanding their world a little bit and inserting some other characters' POV to keep the "concept" of the fic alive even though they are meeting in person.

Some explained callouts: "Lizzie, the dragon" is the product of my own silly imagination when the lovely @oursfemmely wondered what had happened to the lizard that Adora transformed into a Swift Wind-like creature in the show. My take is that it turns into a dragon, goes back in time when the portal thing happens, then becomes Mara's noble steed. This is my nod to my own headcanon and I hope someone writes that fic one day.

Yes, the homophobic guy in the elevator is Hordak.

Also: I would have gone for the Mandacaru flower, but Perfuma wouldn't let it happen, and it also would make more sense for Adora to hand Catra a species that belonged to Etheria - whereas Mandacarus would grow in "Half-moon" (*coughs* *Brazil* *coughs* *coughs*).

After I finished writing the whole fic, I was honored with this beautiful fan art by the great rejsante, who allowed me to embed in the actual story! Thank you so much!

Anyway, I'll be back when I can with their next installment :)

Alarm

Chapter Summary

A few glimpses of Catra's visit to Bright Moon.

Chapter Notes

Hey , all! Here I am again.

I am always saying how much I struggle with each chapter, but this one was really a struggle. I had the insane idea of fitting all of Catra's days in Bright Moon into one single chapter, and I had to follow through. So I took twice as long to write it, which also means it came out twice as long (and that part I hope you enjoy). W e should go back to our regular word length from now on.

Anyway, I hope you enjoy the chapter . As always, thank you for your patience! Y our support has been amazing and I'd love to hear your thoughts.

Enjoy the chapter! Oh, and happy Halloween!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chairs, check. Projection screen and sound, check. Sponsors backdrop, check. Banner, check. Food and beverages, check. Bartender, check. DJ, check. Driver , check. Authors' contact information. Lonnie has to hold that thought. Her cell phone rings and she momentarily puts aside the checklist of tomorrow's panels to pick it up.

Huh. A text from the owner of the Cephalopods Literary Corner , the place that will be hosting the event and the after-party. As Lonnie has known her for a long time, because they've worked together on

other occasions, she can't help but read the message with her characteristic blasé tone.

“heads up, planner lady. netossa just told me one of the authors had to checkout of the chimera hotel.”

Uh-oh. What now? Sensing trouble, Lonnie rolls her chair back to her laptop and opens the spreadsheet again. "Please don't tell me we have another writer-diva situation in our hands, cuz frankly I'm getting too old for that shit," she sends, her mind taking her back to the gala she organized for the Peekablues last year. So much rich family shit and silly intrigue happening in the background of that party, Lonnie feels nauseous just thinking about it.

“wow. rude much??” Lonnie snorts and rolls her eyes. *“im literally just trying to give you a message here.”*

"Sorry," she types with a sigh, less tense, reminding herself that the owner of the bookstore has nothing to do with her past celebrity traumas. "My stress levels are high and the last thing I need is another crisis to manage. What happened?"

Serpentine Sea is typing…

Lonnie cracks her knuckles. All right, here it comes. After all she's been through in this unmerciful field of work, she's prepared for anything life can throw at her.

“uh - it’s not a crisis at all. the author only checked out of the hotel because she has like a sweetheart in town or whatever . sorry to disappoint, but there’s no actual drama drama there, just... lesbian long-distance romance drama.”

Phew, okay. That doesn't sound bad. For one thing, it saves money from the budget. Plus, it's good to know at least someone is getting laid this weekend, because, for Lonnie, things have been slow in that department lately. Maybe she should text that Rogelio guy and the cute blonde she met a while ago. See what happens there. Yeah,

when all this craziness is over, maybe it's time to put some effort into something other than work.

But anyway ...

"Guess I should thank past Lonnie for making refundable reservations! 😅 Ok. Do you have the new pickup address so I can send it to the driver or should I get it from Netty?"

"yeah, so, that's the other part of the message: she has like her own ride now, so she wont be taking the van with the other authors - which is totally for the best, because that van driver is soooo annoying, i dont know how people put up with all that singing. the last time he drove me somewhere i swear i almost set the van on fire."

Oh! Alright. So... Putting aside her counterpart's unresolved past with the eccentric van driver, this is good news. One less thing for Lonnie to worry about, which is rare in the event planning business.

Still. "You could've opened your message with that, you know. Not that you hate our van driver, but that the author won't need him anymore. Would have saved me the headache."

"*yeah whatever*." Lonnie scoffs, somewhat annoyed by her contractor's nonchalance. "*oh, also: i need you to bring my secret of the lab alone tomorrow because im gonna ask marina siren fisher to autograph all my mer-mystery books at the panel and that's obviously like the only reason for me to be hosting this event AT ALL so you better not forget it or ill kill you and most importantly ill never hire you ever again*."

Lonnie grins. "And you're calling ME dramatic? Don't worry, your precious book will be there," she casts a glance at the borrowed book on the top shelf, then she turns to the computer screen again. "Hey, which one was it? The author I mean. I'm gonna need to update her info on the spreadsheet." She adds, scrolling through the tiny list of authors from abroad who will be part of the panel.

When her response comes, Lonnie finds the corresponding row in the spreadsheet and adds the observation: "Cyra Kl ynx / Catra Qeiroz - Found alternative accommodation and transport (may the gays get laid, your honor)."

*

8:37 PM

"You know, if someone had told me that the great Force Captain would be afraid of a harmless puppy, I dont know if I would have believed it," Adora teases while Catra hides behind her to shield herself from Swifty's affectionate and overly excited advances towards her.

"What?" Catra protests, her voice a note higher than usual. "I'm not afraid, I just. Don't love the idea of getting licked and potentially bitten, that's all," and realizing what she's just said, Catra points a finger at Adora's face. "That doesnt apply to humans," she adds with a smirk.

Adora smiles smugly, Catra's taste still strong on her lips, the memory of Catra moaning and writing under her tongue still deliciously fresh. "Yeah, you seemed to be enjoying yourself this afternoon," she chuckles, closing the front door of her apartment. The place is a mess because when the day began, she had no idea that she would receive a guest. She quickly picks up Swifty's toys from the floor, as well as the cup of coffee she left abandoned when she ran out in the morning.

"Thank you again for agreeing to this," she says. "I hope it doesnt get you in trouble with your publisher or anything like that. Glimmer wasnt available and it was too short notice to find someone else to look after Swifty overnight and give his heart medicine, and uh"… She leaves the rest of that sentence hanging and takes Catra's suitcase to the bedroom, but you and I know it would probably have something to do with *not having any time to waste*.

"Dont worry about it, dummy , Ill just.Add that to my list of a million reasons not to get a dog or whatever," she scof fs as Swifty sniffs her with interest. "Seriously , though, I talked to my editor and it's going to be fine. I only opted for the hotel room in the first place because… Well, I didnt know what would happen once I got here and it sounded like the safest plan," she explains, clearing her throat to hide the adorable blush that covered her freckled cheeks. "Besides, It would be irresponsible of me to leave you alone tonight," she smirks. "Y ou would miss me too much."

"Oh, *I* would, huh?" Adora looks at her with a cocky grin, as she realizes she isn't the only one who's worried about *time*. "Why , thank you. That is very selfless of you."

Catra tries to maintain her confident stance. "I'm a very selfles-- *whoa,*" she fails miserably when Swifty jumps on her and nearly knocks her to the ground.

"Oh! Sorry!" Adora goes to her rescue, of fering her hand so Catra doesnt lose her balance. "I swear he doesn't bite or anything, he is just not used to having company ."

It's been a long time since Adora brought anyone home, to the point where she got used to spending her nights alone. Not that there weren't suitors before Catra came into her life - many women tried to earn that invitation, but Adora was never interested enough to ask any of them.

Acknowledging the importance of this moment, Adora squeezes Catra's hand tighter and leans in to kiss her.

"T o be able to do that is such a wonderful thing," she whispers, pretty sure she's just quoted a line from a romantic comedy movie from the 90s.

"Dork," Catra says, kissing her again.

“Hey , if it makes you more comfortable, I can get the walk-through gate and keep Swifty in the office while you are here.”

“No, no, don't be stupid,” Catra chuckles, stroking the inside of Adora's hand, while the dog jumps around the two of them, trying to get their attention. “It’ s fine. I'm just going to need some time to adjust to all this enthusiasm, I've always had cats and it's a very drastic change of behavior, *heh*. I'm honestly not used to having someone so excited for my company.”

“Better get used to it. ‘Cause he is not the only one,” Adora says, and Catra looks at her with a knowing smile.

[illegible]

There are Chinese takeout boxes on the coffee table, wine and water glasses on the floor. Since they arrived at Adora’s place, Catra and Adora have been debating over what song to listen to, eating, drinking, discussing Adam's wedding plans, making fun of trashy reality shows and mocking each other’s sleepwear. Through it all, they continued to kiss and touch and drive each other to the edge, eager to explore everything the dimension of touch has to offer them.

The last few hours were fairy tale material, but it comes with a deadline. They only have seven days ahead of them, and Adora is fully committed to making the most of it.

And she has a feeling Catra is doing the same.

“Hey , I’m sorry for being such a terrible host. I assumed you’d be too tired from the trip, so it didn’t even occur to me to ask, but - do you want to go somewhere? I mean, my neighborhood is not very exciting, but there are a few nice restaurants around the park if you want to go out for a drink or something.”

“Oh, there are a lot of places I plan on going tonight,” she says salaciously. “Only none of them involve leaving this apartment.”

It’s strange how organic this is - or, perhaps, it’s precisely the opposite of strange. Since they became friends, and even more so when they realized there was something else between them, Adora already felt Catra as a constant presence in her life. A symbolic presence, of course, but nevertheless a real one.

Finally experiencing her physical presence in its materiality feels like an extension, an additional layer to what they already had. It does not contradict what Adora previously knew about her, but rather reaffirms it, endorses it, while also filling in some gaps and revealing new details of Catra’s personality.

She’s a very work-driven person. Granted, Adora already knew that, but there’s this glint in Catra’s eye when she talks about her novel, and specifically about the passage she chose to read on tomorrow’s panel. This isnt the kind of thing that appears on text messages or video calls, and Adora thinks it's so special to witness that kind of eagerness, that kind of passion revealed in someone’s gaze.

And because Catra values her work that much, she’s also worried. About the panel, I mean. Adora can tell by the way her voice wavers or by the way she scratches the back of her neck whenever they bring up the subject.

Adora thinks she knows why. In addition to being her first reading in front of an international audience, Catra mentioned that a hip and famous novelist will also be releasing her new book at the event, and her presence has attracted many wealthy sponsors. This is what allowed the publisher to cover travel and accommodation expenses of foreign authors under contract, so it’s essentially the reason why Catra is even here, but it also means the place will be packed with hysterical Mer-Mystery fans and bigwigs from the publishing industry.

"The excerpt you chose is such a powerful one. It sets the tone of the plot and the characters without being too spoiler-y,”Adora says in a reassuring tone, while Catra has her head on her lap. She softly caresses Catra's cheek, lips, and chin, feeling the gentle pulse of her

heartbeat against her knuckles. "At the end of your reading, no one's gonna even care about Mer. Mer-what-now?"

Catra snorts. "I can't believe you've never heard of fucking Mer-Mysteries," her fingers go dancing on Adora's thigh over her pajama bottoms; the touch is light but present enough to awaken Adora's desire yet again. "That shit is so popular it will be turned into a TV series on Flix Portal. Only a clueless dork like you wouldn't know about it," she sasses, clenching her jaw to discreetly stifle a yawn.

Oh, yes, a yawn. Because naturally, Catra is also *exhausted*. No need for a murder detective to uncover *that* mystery. It's five-thirty in the morning in Bellmoon right now, and it has been a long day, filled with all sorts of - *ahem* - straining activities. Catra's eyelids are heavy, and her speech is getting slurred, but she's clearly struggling to stay awake for as long as possible.

"Hey, you have a big day tomorrow, what do you say we continue this conversation in the bedroom?"

And like everything about her, her stubbornness is charming and hard to resist.

"*Aww*, no, don't tell me you are already tired, princess," she sits up and grabs Adora's neck for a steamy kiss, her breath smells of wine, her tongue is hot and hungry. "I think I wore you out a lot faster than I thought."

"That is ridiculous, *uh* –" It's hard to sound serious when Catra is straddling her like that, her hand inside Adora's pajama pants stroking her over the fabric of her underwear. "Y-you're probably exhausted from the trip, and from -" Adora stutters, moaning and unwittingly leaning into Catra's touch, almost rocking down her hand. "Maybe you s-should try to get some sleep. You want to be well-rested for tomorrow."

Catra smirks, her tired eyes filled with malice. "Is this your excuse to get me to bed, then?" She says, her fingers gripping the waistband

of Adora’s boyshorts, fingernails brazing her lower abdomen and sending shivers down her spine. "Because if that’ s the case, *She-Ra* , all you have to do is ask."

The wetness between Adora's legs testifies to how much she wants to do just that: take Catra to the bedroom so they can spend the rest of the night devouring each other, tasting and savoring every part, finding new and different ways to fit their bodies together. Neither of them wants to give in to sleep when they both know how precious their time is.

But she takes one look into Catra's weary eyelids, and all she can do is smile. "I promise Ill do that when you are not about to fall unconscious, *Force Captain* ."

When she returns from one of her trips to the kitchen to put away the leftovers or to get a glass of water, she finds Catra dozing on the couch, so adorable in the oversized *This World is Bullshit* Fiona Apple T-shirt she wears to sleep. Swifty’s on the floor, curled up on her feet, his tail wagging slowly.

And Adora's heart feels so full, so incredibly content, she wouldn't dare ask for anything else.

Anything other than *time*.

She decides to make the sofa bed instead of calling Catra into the bedroom. Careful not to wake her, Adora brings them clean sheets and arranges the pillows. She then lays down beside her, kisses her forehead, and whatever restlessness left in her chest settles down when she envelopes Catra’s body with her own. It doesn't take long for sleep to claim her—and when it does, it remains undisturbed for the rest of the night.

[MUSIC PLAYS: "THE SUN, THE MOON, AND THE STARS"]

Bow's personalized ringtone wakes Adora up, and she mentally curses the fact that her best friend is as much a morning person as

she is, because for once in her life she feels like sleeping in.

She doesn't recognize the bed right away, and fantasy and memory seem to blend into one big blur. She feels an arm on her stomach, the heat and weight of another body beside hers, a woody scent mixed with alcohol, and at first, she suspects she is still dreaming. Only when she opens her eyes and confirms that Catra is sleeping next to her is Adora convinced that yesterday *really* happened.

Her lips part in a small smile. As it turns out, waking up with Catra is better than going to sleep with her. Nothing in Adora's life that preceded this moment gave her a clearer sense of *belonging*.

"Hey , Bow,"she whispers when she retrieves her cell phone from the rug, turning sideways to sit on the couch with her feet on the floor. "What' s up? Everything ok?"

"Good morning!" he says in his usual upbeat tone. *"Wait, why are we whispering? Oohhh, is Catra there with you? Oohhh, did it happen already?!"*

"Wha --"Adora almost raises her voice, but she senses Catra turning on the sofa bed and goes back to keeping her voice down. "Hey , you know, I expected a little more discretion from you."

"So that is a yes, huh? Tell me everything!Well, not everything, of course, only like... the redacted, very very safe for work version."

Adora smiles. "You are starting to sound like Glimmer. Everything is going great. Well, more than great, honestly. It exceeded my highest expectations,"she sighs as the flashes of the day before begin to flicker in her mind: their first exchanged glances, their first kiss, their first orgasm. How many of those will they still have? This just isn't the best time to discuss it, she's, uh. Still sleeping."

"Alright, alright, I won't hold you up. I just wanted to askwhat time we should get to the bookstore later . I would have texted, but I

imagine you have more important things to do than look at your cell phone."

"Very perceptive of you," Adora says before she explains the day's schedule.

When she hangs up the phone, she glances at the clock, assessing they still have some time before they need to go to the bookstore.

She is thinking about what to make for breakfast when Catra's arms come around her waist, and her breathing instinctively changes. She takes her hand over Catra's, not only as a gesture of affection but also to confirm once again that she is truly there. Catra's face emerges from behind her shoulder, she rests her chin on it, and her hair feels ticklish against Adora's neck.

"Did I just hear you say that I exceeded your highest expectations?" She asks, her voice even huskier than usual from having just woken up.

"*What*, no, you thought that was about you?" Adora says unconvincingly. "I was just telling Bow about a movie I saw while you were sleeping."

"Really?" Catra smirks against Adora's jawline, then nibbles on it softly. "What movie?"

"Uuuuuhhhhhhh." Adora's brain freezes with the impossible task of remembering the name of a movie that exists in real life. "Breakfast.For.Dogs.Is.Bullshit"?

"Wow, that was awkward," Catra snorts. "Did anyone ever tell you you are a really shitty actress?"

"Mmmph, just about everyone I know," Adora confesses with a funny grin and an eye roll. "I hope this is not like a relevant criterion for you or anything"

"Nah, you're good. As far as I'm concerned, it's actually a virtue."

Adora smiles. "You know the risk of exceeding expectations right at first, right? You are gonna have to keep up for the rest of the trip."

"That a challenge?" Catra asks, her hands going inside Adora's shirt, her mouth on Adora's neck. "Because you should know by now that I happen to love a challenge," her hands move to Adora's breasts, she presses her chest against Adora's back.

There's no part of Adora's body that she isn't aware of right now. "I was kind of counting on it," she says with a cocky grin, putting her hand to the back of Catra's neck, then pulling it lightly so she can kiss her. The kiss is long, slow, deep, and has a distant hint of morning breath that doesn't seem to bother them.

They allow gravity to pull them back onto the sofa bed.

And now that she is decidedly awake, Adora only hopes this morning can be the first of many.

[illegible]

Adora can't describe what it was like to see Catra take the stage at the bookstore, applauded by the crowd and so many renowned writers. To some extent, the international authors' panel was as big a hit as the release of *[illegible]*, the new Mer-Mystery novel everyone was so excited about - well, everyone who isn't Adora.

Catra's editor, Netossa, seemed very pleased with the general turnout. "We are thrilled to have so many people here to praise these amazing writers," she said before handing the floor over to the moderator of the international author's panel. "On behalf of Wind Chime Publishings, I thank you for coming and taking some time to listen to what these powerful and unique voices have to say."

Oh, Catra looked so handsome and self-assured in that gorgeous pastel red button-up shirt, the open-front black vest, and the loose tie that conveniently covers the love bites Adora left behind.

She speaks so confidently, no one would suspect that she was ever nervous about doing this. The few slips in the English language during her introductory speech would have gone unnoticed if she hadn't drawn attention to them herself, quickly making up for it with a charming chuckle. When she began to read the passage from her upcoming novel, Adora felt chills as she heard those familiar words rolling out of Catra's mouth.

The upright, elegant posture, remnants of her gymnast days;the intonation and cadence of her voice;the look in her eyes, the way she pursed her lips each time she paused to catch her breath;every syllable, every sentence, every emotion expressed so assertively. "Angeline remembers that smile. It belongs to the woman who was once her princess," Catra recited, her gaze fixed on Adora throughout the reading, hungry eyes undressing her, peeling off every piece of her clothing as if they were the only ones left in that room. "And now that they're face to face, Angeline wants more than just remembering."

It felt so *powerful* to be the one Catra was staring at, to be the one who held her gaze, the one who had her full attention. It made the feelings inside Adora scream for recognition. Pride, admiration, and... Well, love. Or if it wasn't fully grown love yet, it was a clear glimpse of it, like an omen of something already in motion and coming her way.

And she was not the only one seeing it. "Oh, Adora. You are so gay for this woman," Glimmer whispered with a smirk during Catra's reading. "Like… so fucking gay."

"Well... *Yeah*," Adora replied with a self-conscious smile. "But what else is new?"

That moment, Catra glanced at the pair, sending Adora a discreet smile as the next author began their reading.

"You know, I get it though. The appeal." Glimmer put an arm around Adora's shoulder, caressing her hair as they both watched Catra on the stage. "The I'm too cool for school' type, the power lesbian outfit, the snarky attitude, the sexy voice I gotta say, it *works*."

"Yeah, sure. But there's also so much more to her than that, you know?" Adora replied, remembering that she found real support and companionship in Catra when she was nothing but a shapeless figure on her computer. She saw talent and sense of humor and determination long before discovering any details about her real identity.

So much has changed between them, but that bond has been there from the beginning, and it only seems to get stronger. Now that Adora can give Catra a hug to celebrate her triumph, what was once ethereal becomes matter, solid and consistent, and the sensation is immensely gratifying.

"You were amazing up there," she says fondly as Catra's body relaxes into her arms, and she hopes her tight embrace can express at least a fraction of everything she is feeling but isn't quite ready to name. "I'm so proud of you, Catra. I hope you know that."

"Thanks. You know, for everything. I wouldn't be here if it weren't for my very nerdy beta reader, I guess." Catra chuckles, looking at her with a mixture of gratitude and relief, and Adora responds with a smug lift of her eyebrow. "I am kind of glad it's over, though. It was weird to be up there."

"Well, something tells me you're gonna have to get used to it," Adora says into her ear, taking a step back as she notices a small crowd that begins to gather around Catra. "It looks like you have fans."

They say things like "I can't believe I've never read any of your works," "where can I find some of your other novels?" and "when will

the book be released?" and Adora's chest is bursting with a second-hand sense of achievement.

Catra deserves this, and so much more. Adora wishes for more opportunities to witness her success.

0AM(T -MS 2 3, 2HS, 3MS)

When they asked how long Catra would be staying here in Bright Moon, Adora was thrilled to see Catra getting so much interest from the first international fans of her work. When they complimented her on her English and her "magnetic" reading voice, Adora convinced herself it was only natural that Catra's multiple talents were being recognized. When they were curious about whether there was a "*princess*" in Catra' s life, *heh*, okay, Adora figured that kind of personal question was to be expected in that kind of context.

But then at the wrap party came things like "here is my number , in case you want someone to show you around town," and "you should get all the attention you deserve," and Adora felt her hands close to fists; her pride bothered by the pesky itch of *jealousy* and her confidence stirred with a seed of *doubt*.

Is this what a typical Saturday night looks like for Catra in Bright Moon? A line of admirers throwing themselves at her? How many girls must she have hooked up with after an event like this? How many of them has she kissed and invited to her bed?

And when their time runs out and Catra returns to her hometown... Will she be taking any of them home?

Then Catra says something like "thanks, but I already have plans," taking Adora's hand, and they kiss, and that flame of insecurity turns to ash. Adora remembers that none of that matters: Catra is with her now, she's the one kissing her, she's the one taking her home.

And just in case anyone hasn't noticed, they're more than happy to put it on display. Their kisses are coming out hungrier and hotter

than one would expect in a public situation, bordering X-rated. Every escape to the bathroom becomes an excuse for a long and meticulous make-out session, and on the dance floor, they are putting on a show.

"Look at you, princess, so loose and relaxed on the dance floor . I like it."

"Well. Good thing we're not really *dancing*."

But Adora would be lying if she said those thoughts weren't bothering her.

What happens when the fairytale is over and their bubble bursts? What happens when the alarm rings and Catra goes back to her life in Halfmoon?

She tries not to think about it as she waits at the bar for another drink, distracted by the lovesick disaster that is setting fire to the dance floor with a ridiculous cover performance of a romantic Bon Jovi ballad. This is apparently his last resort to win the bookstore owner's heart. "Ugh, *why* did anyone let this goober in?" While the crowd seems to be enjoying his performance, his target audience remains indifferent and unimpressed.

"Now what's wrong with this picture," a velvety timbre steals Adora's thoughts, the delightful and now familiar sound of Catra's voice warm in her ears. "A hot girl like you all alone in a place like this? *Such* a shame," she singsongs.

Adora grins without turning to her. "The girl I had my eye on has like a line of people drooling all over her, so I don't think I stand a chance."

The bartender delivers Adora's Moscow Mule. She takes a good sip of it as Catra steps out from behind her to lean on the bar.

"Then I guess her loss is my gain, isn't it?" She smirks, signaling the bartender to refill her whiskey shot. "Though I don't think you should worry about any of that. From where I'm standing... No one here's got nothing on you, princess," she gives Adora a reassuring look. "Well, except for *me*, obviously," she scoffs, rolling her eyes with false modesty and bringing the whiskey glass to her mouth.

"Obviously," Adora smiles, pulling Catra by the tie for a lingering kiss, only stopping when she remembers: "Oh, by the way, Glimmer and Bow just left. They meant to say goodbye but you and your editor looked like you were having an important conversation, so we didn't want to disturb you. They wanted me to thank you and to invite you for brunch tomorrow."

"Oh, shit, okay," Catra scratches the back of her neck, somewhat regretful. "Brunch sounds nice. Sorry I missed them, I guess." She finishes her drink in one big gulp before bringing her hands to Adora's hips. "Hey, do you maybe want to go too? It's getting pretty late."

"Are you sure? I'm fine with staying a bit longer," she responds, pressing her body against Catra's for another kiss, her fingers closing around the loose tie again.

"Trust me, if there's one thing I've learned from parties like this, it's that when a drunk simp starts performing on the dance floor, it's time to bail."

Adora's lips turn into a dopey smile and she takes another look at their chaotic entertainer, who is putting his heart and soul into his performance.

She is about to recount a similar incident at Adam's engagement dinner, but her breath catches when she feels Catra's fingertips slipping unobtrusively over her linen pants and up her inner thigh. "Besides, I bet we can think of another way to enjoy ourselves."

Adora smiles, sighs, and kisses her in agreement. For the rest of the night, she won't care if there were people flirting with Catra at the party. She wont wonder about what will become of them at the end of this trip, she wont worry about the future. She will be lost in the euphoria of being inside Catra and in the spectacle of watching her come, over and over again.

11:2AM(T -MS 5A 3, 1HS, AS MS)

The sound of Swifty barking somewhere, the distant smell of coffee. A slightly hungover Adora opens her eyes to find herself alone - and naked - in her bed. She stretches under the sheets, yawns, and a smile shows on her face when she remembers the state she was in when she went to sleep a few hours ago.

Her cell phone vibrates on the bedside table. She picks it up: there are texts from Glimmer, others from Bow, they are both asking about brunch and giving their first impressions of Catra. Adora chuckles at the messages and stifles another yawn. She is about to type something in response when Catra leans against the bedroom door frame, a cup of coffee in each hand. There's nothing on her body but the shirt she wears to sleep, and from her *adorably* tired expression, she must have just woken up as well.

As she looks Catra up and down - her legs, her thighs, the contours of her waist and breasts visible through the white loose T-shirt - Adora has a déjà vu from their early video calls. It feels as if she's seeing Catra for the first time, as if she's somehow forgotten that she's so incredibly beautiful.

"Morning," Catra smiles and blows out the steam from the cof fee, so, *so* freaking sexy - perhaps especially because she's not trying to be. "Hope you dont mind, but I went ahead and helped myself."

"Dont mind at all." Adora says, lazily stretching her arms, and she notices Catra's gaze lingering on her bare chest. "Uh... W e are being summoned for brunch."

"Right."Catra sips at her cof fee. "Bow and *sparkles* ,"she teases, making her way to the bed and handing Adora's cup. "I remember ."

"If you're not feeling up for it, we can say no."Adora takes a sip of coffee and leaves the cup on the nightstand;Catra does the same, standing just inches from Adora. "W e can meet up later, or not at all, even. Whatever you want."

"No, I am up for it. Food is important, or so they say ."She smirks with mischief, lightly stroking Adora's arm with the tip of her middle finger. "It just takes a lot of brainpower to get out of this room when you're here, looking like this."

Maybe she wants to sound provocative, but the expression in her eyes is fragile, soft, and vulnerable. It makes Adora feel a sudden wave of mixed emotions - the uncertainty of their future balanced with the certainty of love.

Her hands go under Catra's shirt, and she puts her arms around her waist to pull her close. She bites her lip and looks into Catra's eyes for a moment, as if searching for something. Reciprocity, perhaps.

"What?"Catra asks with an awkward grimace. "What are you looking at?"

Adora doesn't immediately answer . Instead, she tenderly caresses Catra's back before her hands move down to her butt-cheeks, then her thighs. With the pads of her fingers, she feels a wave of goosebumps rising on Catra's skin beneath her touch.

"I think we can af ford to be late."

(WHAT HAPPENS NEXT IS UP TO YOU, READER)

The kitten sniffs Adora's fingers. She smiles, a little timidly, shoving her hands in her coat pockets. "This little guy looks fine. It must have been something he ate,"she says to his nervous caregiver .

"Phew! That is so good to hear!" The woman sighs in relief, helping the cat get back into the pet carrier. "Did you hear that, Sir Dinadin?" She says to the cat, who stares at her with a blasé expression before proceeding to groom himself. "You are fine!"

"I'd like to run some more tests just to play on the safe side, though. I didn't feel anything when I examined him and the blood test came out normal, but I prefer to be thorough when it comes to these things, just to discard some possibilities." Adora says, going to the computer to fill out the patient's form. She senses her cell phone vibrate inside her coat. "Uh - can you bring Sir Dinadin in for an ultrasound tomorrow? He will need to be fasted for at least eight hours."

"Sure, sure, whatever you think it's best," the woman says. "But you don't suppose it's anything serious, do you?"

"Well, watch out for any change in behavior and if it happens again, bring him to the emergency room." Her cell phone vibrates again, she reaches into her pocket to feel the device in her hand. "But for now, I wouldn't worry," she grins reassuringly .

Adora explains how to administer the medicine she prescribed before saying goodbye to her patient. As soon as they leave her office, she glances at the clock. Ugh. Still half an hour to go. Time really likes to play all kinds of tricks on us, huh?

When Adora checks her cell phone, two messages from Catra await her.

"honey i'm home," The first message says. *"meeting was boring but promising. and since ill be staying in B for a few more days, they invited me for lunch tomorrow ."*

The veterinarian smiles proudly. "Yyyyy , that's awesome! Congrats! 👏👏👏 So I'm guessing that means they were happy with the panel?

“apparently, yeah,” Catra says modestly. *“anyway, they suggested that ramen place you keep talking about. the one down the street from the publisher’s office.”*

Adora’s mouth salivates at the thought of a good bowl of ramen. “Yum! 😋🍜 Great choice!”

“wanna come? if ur not busy with your own work, obviously . it’s not a business lunch or anything.”

Glad to be invited, Adora purses her lips as she calculates the time to head to Unterpertinger Road and be back in the Pet Zone for her afternoon shift. It's going to be tight - but for Catra, it is worth it. “Of course! You know I would never say no to ramen 🤪”

“it’s a date then :)” Like a fool, Adora giggles at the word *date*, a rush of happiness bubbling in her stomach. *“btw what time do you come home?”*

She glances at her computer to check the next patient's schedule. “Oh, I only have like one more patient and I’ll be done for the day , so I’ll be there soon!”

Force Captain is typing…

While she waits for the next message, Adora double-checks some information in the patients’ charts, so she can leave the Pet Zone right after her last appointment. But when her cell phone vibrates again and she sees the message content, her brain crashes on the spot.

A selfie of Catra, but of course that isn’t everything. She’s naked on Adora’s bed, her hair is spread across the pillow, her gorgeous breasts are on display, her signature smirk is on her lips. She is looking straight into the camera and one of her hands is absently resting on her breastbone.

Adora remembers what those fingers are capable of, she remembers the taste of those nipples on her mouth, the way they react to her touch. Her heart skips a beat, her throat goes dry , and her thighs clench.

Desire builds on her lower abdomen.

“ill be waiting for u, princess)”

Slack-jawed and flushed, Adora wishes she could go home sooner .

[illegible]

“Again, Im really pleased to meet you, Adora,” Netossa says. “Sorry we didnt give you much attention at the party , everything was so crazy that day. Lots of ass-kissing to do - if you know what I mean. But I hope you had a good time.”

Adora is sitting at the table with Netossa and her wife Spinerella, who is also the co-owner of Wind Chime Publishings. It’s been a pleasant afternoon so far and, as Catra promised, it feels more like a double date than a business lunch. The three women finish their meals and make casual conversation while Catra is in the bathroom.

“Oh, everything was excellent. Thank you for making it happen!” Adora responds after swallowing. “Not just the party , but the panels, I mean. So many powerful and insightful stories. We could use more of those.”

“Much of that was due to Catra's ef fort, you know,” Netossa says with a sassy grin. “When she first heard we were hosting the event here in Bright Moon, she showed so much initiative and hard work to be a part of it. She was the one who pitched the idea of having an international authors panel, she helped us with the budget, connected us with potential sponsors.” She turns to Adora. “Now I see why.”

Oh.

Eh.

Ehehehe.

I guess Catra had neglected to tell Adora that she had been such an active participant in that part of the process. The new information is undoubtedly flattering, but Adora doesn't know how to answer, so she's grateful to have her mouth full.

"Darling," Spinerella interjects with a kind smile, politely cleaning her mouth with a napkin.

"*What I mean is* that after meeting with her, it's clear that she is very passionate about queer narratives and diversity," Netossa continues with a pointed grin and a sharp look at her wife.

"Yes, and I would also add that she has a knack for business as well as writing," Spinnerella says. "She's very cunning and resourceful."

"It's a shame she won't be here for the weekend. We'd love to have you guys over for game night. We would absolutely destroy you, of course," she smirks.

"Darling, your competitiveness is showing," Spinny chuckles lightly. "Don't let Netossa scare you off, Adora. We would love to have you over. There will be plenty of other opportunities, I'm sure."

"Thank you, I love a good game night," Adora smiles, finding the contrast in their personalities very amusing. Spinny is serene and patient, Netossa is quick, agitated, and assertive. It's sweet how they seem to balance each other out.

Still, there's something about the way they're talking about Catra that prickles Adora's curiosity. She clears her throat, trying to sound casual.

"So. Do you think. I mean, do you think she would have more opportunities to come back here soon?" Netossa and Spinny

exchange a small smile. Okay, so that was probably not subtle, but Adora doesnt really care.

It’s Spinny who answers. “When *Remember* comes out, the promotion will involve more readings, probably some book signings, and we are very interested in bringing her here again for that. But other than that, it depends on many variables, Im afraid. It’ s hard to predict.”

Spinerella's words once again remind Adora that her future with Catra is completely at the mercy of chance. “I see.” Uncertainty brings a noticeable disappointment to her tone.

“But youll never know ,” Netossa adds, perhaps trying to cheer Adora up. “She was a big hit on the panel, attracted a lot of attention, a lot of people asking about her. I don't doubt her potential to create new opportunities to be here if she wants to.”

“Oh, yeah, *pfff*, absolutely,” Adora agrees with a hint of pretense indifference, her mind bouncing back to the queue of people interested in Catra's writing. Among other things.

Okay. Maybe it's time to stop putting off that impending conversation.

“Hey ,” Catra says, placing a hand on Adora's shoulder before sitting back down. “What did I miss?”

“Oh, we were just regretting the fact that you'll miss our legendary game night next weekend.” Netossa winks at Adora discreetly .

“Lucky for you. W e would destroy you two,” Catra grins wickedly , putting an arm around Adora’s shoulder.

[CUT TO: EXT. WHISPERING WOODS - DAY 3, 4 HOURS AFTER THE GAMES)

“Hey , Catra? May I ask you a question?” Adora asks nervously , holding Swifty's leash in one hand and a cone of strawberry ice cream in the other. They are walking around Whispering Woods

Park, Adora has just shown Catra to the local artists' fair near the area.

"Yeah, sure, dummy, you may go ahead," Catra says, scoffing at Adora's excess of diplomacy.

"Uh. I was just wondering"…

For the first time in a week, Adora laments the fact that they aren't behind screens. She must admit that it's somehow easier to say what she wants when she doesn't feel Catra's gaze on her.

"W-what do you think about playing Despondos when we get home?"

Onward.

Catra looks at her suspiciously. But even though she's not convinced, she doesn't push.

"Fine by me, it's your fucking funeral," she snorts, then points a finger at Adora's face. "Just promise me you won't put me out on the street after I kick your ass, alright? It's gonna be a cold night."

Adora smiles. "Don't worry, there's no risk of that happening."

9:24 AM (T-MINUS 2 HOURS, 0 MINUTES)

The steam from the shower still hangs in the air even though they turned off the water several minutes ago. The contrast of temperatures - bodies, water, breeze, and steam – makes the situation even more arousing.

Adora's back is pressed against the cold tile wall, her fingernails digging into Catra's shoulder blades as her pleasure builds. It's going to happen at any second now. Adora senses it coming with each of Catra's vigorous thrusts inside of her - two fingers, knuckle-deep, pumping her as she rocks her hips towards it. She moans softly against Catra's ear, sensing her climax approaching. "Catra, dont

st-” she gasps as Catra curls her fingers inside her, a louder moan escaping her throat.

Catra seems to have understood her partial request. “I won't stop. Not unless you ask me to.” She whispers, nuzzling her head in Adora's damp hair and increasing her pace. It’s coming, and one part of Adora wants so badly to reach relief while the other doesn't want this sweet, sweet agony to ever end. Trying to contain herself, her body jerks forward, and Catra keeps her from falling. “Shh, I’ve got you. I won't let go.”

Those simple words of comfort suddenly sound sexier than any dirty talk, and they make it impossible for Adora to hold herself back.

“Fuck, please. Don't stop,” she begs right on the threshold of orgasm, in a rare moment of asking for what she wants, clinging to Catra's back and biting her shoulder.

When she doesn't contain her scream, she rediscovers something she already knew: expressing desire aloud can be ridiculously liberating.

And if their first together exceeded Adora’s highest expectations, this kind of domestic bliss is all she could ever want out of life. For the past few days, it seems they've entered a fantasy dimension, a honeymoon trip in the midst of Adora's ordinary routine.

She knows it’s not real. It won't last, can't last, is not supposed to last. But the words *“don't stop”* are still ringing in her ears when she closes her eyes and kisses the water droplets from Catra's neck.

[illegible]

Catra makes up space in her suitcase for the things she bought in Bright Moon. It’s nothing much - some clothes, a book, a few refrigerator magnets with inspirational quotes or ridiculous puns. “A friend of mine loves those dumb cheesy things,” she explains with a nostalgic grin. “She’s gonna go crazy over these.”

Adora noticed that Catra didnt buy anything for her mother . In fact, she didnt mention her a lot - despite the two having communicated once or twice during the trip. As far as Adora can tell, they don't have a relationship that goes far beyond mutual tolerance.

Their childhoods seemed to have been radically different. Catra's sounded more lonely - so much to show, so much potential, no one to give a damn about it. Adora's was the opposite: lots of people, lots of pressure and the crushing weight of high expectations. Catra doesn't seem to dwell on her past that much, but Adora has unwillingly dragged that weight around throughout her entire life.

Watching Catra pack her bags, Adora realizes that she has never felt as *light* as she has in the past few days, and her heart aches knowing that farewell is coming.

But this is not what Adora should be thinking about now. "Gotta introduce her to Bow, then. He loves making pun-based jokes, thinks they are hilarious. Glimmer and I are always messing with him for it."

She doesn't know exactly what she said, but something in the air immediately changes. Catra casts a furtive glance at her, then pauses with a thoughtful expression.

"Yeah, so." She turns back to her suitcase. "She has a crush on you, doesnt she?"

"Mmm?" Adora doesn't even understand who Catra is referring to. "What are you talking about?"

"Glimmer ," she scratches the back of her neck nervously . "Have you ever... Forget it, it's just that s-she seems kind of into you. I mean, it's none of my fucking business, of course, I just happened to notice a lot of touching. Like, all the time."

Adora senses the discomfort in Catra's tone, but it's hard for her not to laugh. It's not the first time she's heard that question, even

Glimmer's mother thought there was something going on between them at some point. Still, it never gets any less funny.

"Oh, No, pf ff. She's just like that. It was the same with Bow before they." "Nope, uh-uh, that's not gonna help your case, Adora. "It's just her way of showing affection, regardless of the type of relationship. It's not necessarily romantic or sexual, it's just who she is. Also, she's crazy about Bow. You know, exclusively."

"I dont doubt that. That much is clear. But. You know," she stutters, clears her throat, tries to convey the insecurity from her tone. "Whatever, maybe it's because I'm not someone who touches my friends like that. Must remember that my own experiences are not universal, right?" She awkwardly turns her back on Adora to close her suitcase.

There's something in Catra's eyes that Adora recognizes. Adora remembers the panel, Glimmer with her arm around her shoulder, the two of them giggling together, Catra glancing at them from the stage. Then at brunch, even if they were having a good time, Catra was a little withdrawn. Is it possible that the whole time Adora was torturing herself about Catra's fan club, Catra may have been doing the same?

"Catra, are you jealous? Of Glimmer?"

Catra scoffs defensively. "*No.*" She turns to Adora again, partially outraged, partially disconcerted. When their eyes meet, her expression softens. "Ugh. Fine. What the hell. Okay, so maybe I am a little jealous, alright?" She tries a small smile, then lets out a long sigh. "But not exactly in that sense. I dont know, probably it's not even *about* Sparkles, it's just... weird. Sorry. I dont really understand where this shit is coming from," she looks at Adora apologetically. "*Fuck*, look at me, Im not making any fucking sense. You know, maybe this isnt the right time for us to be having this conversation, let's just go back to what we were doing."

Oh, but Adora understands *exactly* where Catra is coming from because what she's describing is very similar to her own feelings. The doubt, the little seeds of jealousy, the harbingers of conflict... She feels it all too.

She makes her way to Catra, speaking softly. "Look, I know this is hard, and I've been avoiding this conversation just as much as you because I didn't want to kill the mood, but... Catra, this is the only time we'll get. Your plane leaves in a few hours and I don't think this is something we should discuss over the computer or the phone and I don't want you to leave without. Well, I don't want you to leave, period, but if you must, at least let's try to sort this out. And if it helps, I can sympathize with everything you're saying, because, hey, I'm feeling all of it too."

Seemingly less tense, Catra sits on the bed and exhales. "Well, since apparently we're doing this..." She nods to the empty space beside her with an inviting smile. "Let's do this."

With a long, deep breath, Adora sits down beside her. She counts her next exhalations from one to ten, and then, even though her fingers are tingling, she manages to continue.

Expressing desire aloud can be ridiculously liberating.

"Catra, these last few days have been... Great," she chuckles because she knows this is an understatement. "For one thing, they confirmed what I already suspected, in terms of how I feel about you, how much I - how much I like you," she looks sideways, feeling her cheeks heat up as she realizes she's almost gone for another verb. "But... having you here is also making me like so fucking anxious because. Well, because I want more of this. I want to keep seeing you. And wondering what's going to happen to us after you're gone is driving me crazy, so I'll just say it. We had agreed that we were going to meet and then see where our feelings would take us. I just want to restate my interest in, well, *continuing* to see where they take us. For real. Like, officially. If you want. Uh, okay, maybe it's time to ask... Do you want to?

Catra’s lips crack in a small grin, she gives out a light scoff. “You sound like you're offering me a job opportunity or something.”

Bewildered, Adora elbows her. “Well, and you sound like you're trying to avoid the subject, dumbass.”

Catra agrees with a low chuckle. “You noticed that, huh?” When her laughter dies down, she pauses for a moment, her expression turns thoughtful. She holds her own arm, as if subtly hugging herself. After a few more moments, she continues. “You know, the thing is, Adora. I don't know if wanting is enough.” Catra says bittersweetly, while also taking Adora’s hand on hers. “This, right here, this is the easy part, you know. We meet, we fuck, we wake up together, we get to know silly things about each other like the way you like your coffee, we hang out for a few days. And it’s all so close to perfect that it's easy to be lured by the trap of thinking that it’s always going to be like this.”

“Yeah.” Adora says with a dreamy smile. “That’s exactly how I feel.”

“Great, me too, but then what?” Catra interrupts her. “When I think about what it actually means. How challenging it is going to be to get past the distance, and the fucking time difference, and the jealousy, and the longing, plus the regular relationship drama? Fuck, Adora. I should be running for the goddamn hills and away from this. And so should you.”

“Oh,” Adora’s heart breaks a little as she considers the truth of Catra's words, and she feels her face heat up, tears wanting to come out. “Yeah. No, you're totally right. I get what you're saying,” she lowers her head, so afraid to cry. “Sounds like the smarter thing to do.”

Catra then squeezes Adora's fingers, her other hand goes under her chin to gently lift Adora’s head. “Then tell me. Why am I not running?”

Adora smiles when she sees a flash of hope flicker in Catra's different-colored eyes. "Well. You told me you liked challenges."

"I do, yeah," Catra snickers, pulling Adora's chin a little closer to kiss her. "But weirdly as it may sound, the thing is. Maybe I like you even more."

And with those words, Adora is sure that somehow they will find a way. This won't be their last night, this won't be their last time.

This is only the first.

90(T -MS 4HS)

All the way to the airport, Catra is quiet, focused on choosing the music or looking through the window. Adora, on the other hand, can't stop talking. Probably the combination of caffeine after a sleepless night, added to the nervousness of the impending goodbye and the Herculean effort she's making not to burst into tears.

"Oh, next time, we should definitely head to the Eternian Castle ruins, which is like a historic site from our colonial days. Sounds a little touristy, I know, but there's a great restaurant and also an old library there, and the view is *amazing*."

Catra gives some laconic answers and smiles but remains introspective. Adora knows she shouldn't push - the day was particularly emotional. The pleasure of their remaining moments together was shrouded in sadness, the aftertaste of each kiss came out a little sour.

They will be fine. They've made a fair amount of plans since last night: Adora will vacation in Half-moon as previously arranged, Catra is expected to return to Bright Moon for the promotion of *Remember*. The two opened up to each other about what they each expected. Both admitted to being too jealous for an open relationship, but they promised to revisit their arrangements periodically, knowing that their individual circumstances might change. They know it will be difficult,

and that for the time being there is no prospect of shortening the distance between them.

But the two made clear their desire to make it work, and that fills Adora's chest with renewed breath. For now, that's gotta be enough.

They arrive at the airport.

After such a physically intense week, it's weird for Adora to keep a safe distance from Catra when all she wants to do is kiss her - but they are in a public place, and she doesn't want to get into unnecessary trouble with some homophobic jerk tonight. Still, they remain close, finding small opportunities to touch or whisper something in each other's ear, and they exchange hurried kisses when they're alone in the bathroom.

As the hour passes, saying goodbye to all that seems impossible.

They are waiting in line for international departures when Catra walks up to her with a package in hand. From the shape and weight, it appears to be a book.

"Hey, so, uh... So I wanted to give you this. I've been sitting on it since Monday. Guess I was waiting for the right time to, uh. Well, here. But Adora, p-please," she stammers, tucking her free hand into her pants pocket and looking down. "C-Can you please open it only after I board?"

Adora takes the gift; her fingers squeeze the small lump left by the hasty wrapping. "Of course," she smiles, and then looks at Catra kindly. "Thank you."

"Yeah, don't make a big deal out of it or whatever," Catra says blushing.

When it's time for her to board, they stand facing each other for a while, a sad, thick tension hovering between them. They are only a few inches apart, but at the same time they seem to be so far away

already. It is Adora who bridges the gap between them, with a hug and a kiss on her lips. She doesnt want to cry;she doesnt want to stain such a perfect week with a sad memory.

They trade their final words, like "have a nice flight"or "let me know when you land,"but neither of them says goodbye. Because, as Adora tells herself, this isnt goodbye - not really . No, this is the beginning of something extraordinary.

Adora watches Catra go with an anvil in place of her heart, and she is standing in the same place when she opens the package. It's the proof copy of Catra's novel. She opens the first page and sees that there are some words scrawled in pencil for her.

Hey , Adora.

Everything that happened to me while I was writing this book, you are the part I most want to remember.

Thankyou,

C

When the first tear falls over Adora's face, she feels stupid for not having said everything she wanted to say, for lacking the courage to say that she *loves* Catra just a few moments ago. She may not be sure what will happen to them from now on, but she is certain about this love.

And because this is not a truth she wants to confess via text message, she types the next best thing: "Thank you for the book. I love it. And Ill miss you so much."

Force Captain is typing…

Adora feels the eyes of strangers around her as she holds her cell phone and waits for Catra's response. Her cheeks are wet with tears that continue to flow.

“ill miss you too.”

03AM(T -MS 0A Y, 0-HS A SMNE)

Chapter End Notes

- I almost cut the first scene (Lonnie and Mermista interacting) off the chapter, but ultimately I decided not to even though the chapter was already a monster. Consider it like the "small intro before opening titles".

- "To be able to do that is such a wonderful thing" is an actual line from Notting Hill. What can I say? I'm a sucker for rom-coms.

- @dragonotakuroxy was the one who originally defined Sea Hawk as a "chaotic entertainer" and I thought it was so fitting I had to use it. Thank you!

- I would like to imagine all Catradora fanfic writers were there with Catra in that panel! In your mind, who was also there?

- Feel free to imagine your favorite Bon Jovi tune as Sea Hawk's serenade to Mermista. Honestly, they all fit the scene.

- Sir Dinadin the cat will be perfectly fine! That scene was no foreshadowing, just a shoutout to a real cat :)

- I've been sitting on the title "Curiosity Killed the Catfish" FOR MONTHS and I'm happy it's finally out there.

- Marina Siren Fisher isn't a callout, just a bunch of sea references and lame puns into a single name.

Thank you for reading! <3 I will love to read what you have to say about it :)

Inbox

Chapter Summary

Catra and Adora are apart again, but this time we get a shift of perspective.

Chapter Notes

Hello :) We are back to our regular time zone difference, and it hurts.
There's not a lot happening on this chapter, but as we will be following the story from Catra's perspective from now on, I supposed I needed a little time to organize her side before moving forward.

That being said, I don't know how many chapters we will have left, but we are nearing the end of this story. It's been so fun writing it!I'm glad there are people enjoying it too.

Keeping my promise to keep this story as light as possible, I hope you like your dose of fluff. Oh, there's some mild spicy content along the way.

Enjoy the chapter!Kudos and comments are always appreciated :)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

2:17 AM

The music blasts through Catra’s headphones, blocking out any other sound - a tactic to avoid getting into meaningless conversation with her neighbors in the elevator. It almost prevents her from noticing the doorman waving at her to let her know that a package has arrived for her, just as she was about to leave the building.

That’s weird. Catra hasn't placed any orders recently, let alone anything to justify a box this size. "Thanks, Grizz," she says with a puzzled smile as she feels the weight of the box in her hands, trying to guess its contents. It’s a bit bigger than a shoebox, but not heavy, she reckons, turning the package over to look for the shipping label.

Her plan for this afternoon was to go to a cafe, relax, change the scenery a bit to stimulate her creativity and start working on something new. But when she sees the sender's name on the cardboard box, she changes her mind and goes back to the elevator.

It's been nearly two months since her return from Bright Moon, Etheria, and Adora continues to amaze her daily.

Catra feared Adora's interest in her would fade once they both returned to reality. And if she's being brutally honest, this isn't just what she feared: it's what she expected. Yes, she was *sure* that when the initial excitement wore off, Adora’s feelings for her would disappear into her absence, blend into all the little things that Catra can't witness, get lost in the places Catra can't be, in the hugs and kisses Catra can't offer. Catra feels the itch of her insecurities prickling her skin every time her girlfriend says she's going out somewhere. The side of her that fears being dumped because something better has come along - or not exactly better, just more convenient - sometimes makes her doubt that they have any chance of making it work.

But that didn't happen. Not yet, at least. They have found ways to keep their flame alive across the distance, and Catra's self-destructive side goes silent when she feels that Adora's affection for her is real.

And, most importantly, that the reciprocal is also true.

Every day, something new tells her that the feelings she has for Adora are greater than her fears, that their relationship is worth the gamble. Today, it is this box. Tomorrow who knows? Catra isn't sure

of many things, but she is certain that she wants to be here to find that out.

Her fingers are burning to pick up the phone on the elevator ride, but she has to wait until she gets to her apartment so her hands are free to actually send a message. Before typing, she quickly checks the time. It's seven twenty in the morning in Bright Moon now, and if Catra knows her well, she's already awake.

"Just got a mysterious delivery now," Catra snaps a photo of the package after placing it on the living room table. "I wonder who's behind it"…

She goes to the office to find something to cut the duct tape from the package and, on her return, she catches the cat on top of it, sniffing the box curiously, claws ready to rip the cardboard, their tail pointed at the ceiling. "Paws off, Melog," she hisses, brushing them off as she opens the box. "That's mine."

There's a barely audible note of tenderness in Catra's voice when she says that word.

Mine.

Melog is startled by the movement of the cell phone vibrating against the thick glass table, which makes a loud buzzing sound, like a bee's hum.

Catra smiles. Most likely a message from the person she wished had come into the box.

"Yesssss finally! It's been over two weeks!" It's ridiculous how even nearly a year of conversation later, a text from Adora leaves Catra like a serotonin-laden idiot. She grins as she wonders the torture it probably was for her counterpart to keep that surprise hidden for so long. "*I was beginning to think it got lost in the mail or something!*"

“ah, so the culprit appears,” she types, keeping Melog from the box as she starts to go through it. “i suspected as much.”

“Well well well it looks like we have a Mer-tective in the building! 😅” Catra chuckles, amused with the fact that a month ago Adora didn't even know what Mer-Mysteries was, and though she has yet to read any of the books in the series, she promptly became acquainted with the memes. *“Did you like the surprise?”*

If she was asked this same question three months ago, Catra would have said she's not the kind of girl who would care about that sort of thing. And maybe if it had come from anyone else in the world, she probably wouldn't have.

However ...

“of course i like it, dummy ,” because when it comes to Adora, really , how could she not? Every hint of her affection seems to fill something inside Catra that she didn't know was empty. She’s kind of grateful to be behind a screen so no one but Melog can see how pathetic her smile must be. “but you really shouldn't have to, u know.”

“I know I didn't HAVE to. I wanted to 😘” Fuck, this adorable dumbass, it’s. Seriously , she makes it virtually impossible for Catra not to love her. For the fifth or sixth time this week, Catra curses the laws of physics for keeping them apart. *“I'm just glad it arrived before your birthday, I was worried it would get there after the actual date!”*

“thank you,” she types as she goes back to unboxing. “you really are a princess.”

“😊 *hope you like it!”*

After going through cardboard, duct tape, and bubble wrap, the first thing Catra takes out of the box is a metal pin. More specifically, it’s a Horde Force Captain badge, a detailed replica of what her character in *Escape to Despondos* wears - a relatively inexpensive item for

someone living in Etheria, but too expensive for Catra to order from Half-Moon due to fucking currency conversion, dumb taxes, and stupid shipping costs. A black T-shirt with the Horde symbol painted in red accompanies the gift.

The fact that she couldn't buy most of the merchandising she wanted was the subject of one of their earlier conversations, and she remembers specifically showing that shirt and pin to Adora as examples of things she couldn't afford.

"cant believe u remembered that," she adds a photo of the *Despondos* gifts to the message.

"Gotta memorize every detail I can about my enemies 😉" Catra scoffs softly. *"It's the secret to win!"*

"yeah i think i won this one though," she smirks to herself. "thanks again."

The next thing she takes out of the box is a book: a guide on how to care for desert flowers. With a mischievous grin, Catra looks at the Serenias Adora gave her while she was at Bright Moon. The plant is struggling with the recent environmental change, but it is still blooming, giving the apartment a beautiful coloring. Catra likes to think of the flower as a metaphor for her relationship - finding ways to thrive, despite everything against it.

"btw i dont know what you are trying to imply here, but just so you know the desert flower u gave me is perfectly fine," she smiles and sends a photo of the plant as evidence.

"They look beautiful! And I wasnt implying anything, just offering you an extra hand 😉"

While they may tease, Catra knows the book has nothing to do with her gardening skills - and nothing wins a fiction writer's heart like a good shot of symbolism.

I wouldnt say no to your hand," Catra laughs before moving on to the other items in the pack.

They include a red ebonite fountain pen, very elegant and beautifully crafted; a fancy notebook *"for when inspiration strikes"*; and two *Mara, the Dragon Tamer* action figures - one of Mara herself, the other of her unicorn dragon.

Every item in the box is a powerful representative of the different aspects of their relationship. Catra sighs like a fool, suddenly overwhelmed with emotion. It's not about the number of items in the box or their material value, she doesn't really care about that. Her heart is beating faster not because of the package, but because the size of her love and its ability to keep growing never ceases to stupefy her.

fuck, this is all fucking incredible, adora. you really shouldnt have gone through all that trouble."

She looks at the objects scattered across the table, and the sum of them all would not account for how she feels.

"Well, honestly, it doesnt even come close to everything I would have liked to send you. And it makes me sad that I cant deliver it in person."

Catra glances at Melog, still the only witness to her foolish grin, and is obliged to agree. She might not like to feel exposed, but it would be an irrelevant price to pay in exchange for having Adora with her.

I know . well get there, princess," she writes to Adora, but mostly to herself.

"Oh! Bow was Bow who made the Mara dolls," Adora says, almost as if predicting what Catra's next message would be. *"Or as he says, the 'war table battle figures'* 💀"

"holy shit. seriously?" Catra inspects the figurines' details, marveling at the designer's talent. Adora always says Bow was good at what he does, but Catra didn't know the extent of his abilities. "that's legit impressive. i have to think of a way to repay him."

"no, not at all, he insisted on making them! said it's his gift to you for introducing us to such awesome vintage 💪"

Catra scoffs defensively. "vintage my ass," she retorts with a quirky frown.

"I dont think your ass is vintage," the reply makes Catra snort loudly. She pictures the goofy smile that must be showing on her girlfriend's face. *"If it is then I am very into vintage 😉"*

"seriously?"

Ugh. Apparently, Catra is super into idiots.

The last item Catra takes out from the box is a plaid flannel shirt. Catra recognizes it as one of Adora's own clothes. She smiles nostalgically. When she landed in Dovale, she noticed that she had left one of her tank tops in Adora's apartment. Since then, they have been bantering about her having an excuse to come back - Catra saying that Adora stole the shirt, Adora saying she forgot it on purpose.

"this is not the shirt i left behind :)" She snaps a picture of the shirt, leaving the empty box for Melog to play with.

"Damn, and here I thought you wouldnt notice! 😳 Well. Sorry. Guess I still want you to come get yours. I thought this would be a fair trade."

Long-sleeved, red, white and a little worn out on the elbows, it's like a piece of Adora came through the mail, and the garment quickly turns into Catra's favorite item.

She brings the shirt up to her nose, a reaction so instinctive that when Catra realizes it she feels somewhat ridiculous. But it is worth it: although faint, Adora's perfume is definitely there, sweet like lavender and spicy like cinnamon, and it makes Catra's lips curl up and her eyes water all at once. The reaction is chemical, physical and psychological, but above all emotional. For a split second it feels like they're together and living that perfect week all over again.

But while the scent is able to fool time and distance, bringing up all those sweet memories, memories of kissing and laughing and fucking and waking up together, it also reminds her of what she cant have.

Fuck, Catra misses her. She misses her scent, her skin, her body, her taste. Her rosy lips and how soft they feel against Catra's mouth. The way her laughter fills the room. Her blue eyes sparkling alive when she smiles. Her weird good mood really early in the morning.

She misses having the whole package, but this is all they can have for now: a few days of intense bliss interspersed with months of this *unbearable* feeling of absence. Missing Adora hurts a lot more than Catra could have predicted and nothing she can send through the mail could make up for it.

But if she wants it to work, she has to learn to be patient.

All relationships have their quirks, right? As far as Catra is concerned, this remains the healthiest attempt at dating she's ever had, and definitely the most attached she's ever been to anyone. Online interactions, care packages, and phone sex may not be ideal, but Catra knows it's worth it. Adora is worth it. The kind of intimacy they have is worth it.

Besides, it won't be like this forever. They will figure something out.

They have to.

With a bittersweet sigh, Catra strips naked and dons Adora's shirt - a pathetic attempt to feel her warmth around her again. Granted, it's a little big for Catra's petite build. But at the same time, it feels like it was tailor-made. Catra rolls her eyes, wondering when exactly she's become so tacky, even though she already knows the answer.

Catra buttons the shirt from the bottom up, Melog watching her from inside the box. Huh. Funny, it is missing a few buttons.

Oh. Her mind takes her back to their last night in Bright Moon, to the image of Adora wearing that shirt, blonde hair falling over red and white stripes, Catra gripping the fabric to pull it open, a bit too violently, perhaps. So much desire that night, so much passion that, it seems, she let herself get carried away.

Her lips are slowly pulled into a mischievous smirk. An idea crosses her mind.

"Oops," she types, her message accompanied by a photo showing the seam where the buttons were torn off.

Because Catra is who she is, she takes the opportunity to choose the most strategic angle for the picture, making sure her bare breasts are on display under the half-open shirt. The smile on her face makes clear the intention of getting a reaction from her counterpart.

"Can't imagine what happened here, but it looks like the shirt came without a few buttons, princess."

Seer is typing…

Oh, yeah. That's the stuff. Catra especially loves those seconds before Adora's next message arrives, when she knows something is coming and she wonders how flustered Adora must look, how eager she is, how she would be staring at Catra right now if they were face to face.

This is one of the few comforts distance has to offer.

The comfort of fantasy.

"Owow," says her first message, and her loss for words is enough to satisfy Catra's ego. "Wow. I cant get over how gorgeous you are, Catra. You have no idea what this photo is doing to me right now. Thankyou. It will haunt my dreams for weeks, Im sure."

Ah. Now it's Catra's turn to blush. Adora's raw sincerity has always been one of her most adorable traits in Catra's eyes, but when it comes to this particular subject, it's actually kind of sexy.

A spark of arousal flows through Catra's blood while she tries to picture what Adora means by those words, and it intensifies as her mind drifts away.

Damn. Catra can almost feel it: Adora's silky touch on her stomach, those strong hands taking off the shirt, her mouth on Catra's breasts as she wraps her arms around Catra's waist, grabbing her by the ass to carry her to the bed...

Mmmm. The slight twinge of desire between Catra's legs turns to an urgent throb.

"how long before u have to go to work?" Catra makes her way to the bedroom, sliding the tip of her finger over the cardboard box, the loose shirt caressing each side of her hips. "i think a good princess like u deserves a proper thank you."

"I can definitely spare a few more minutes 😉😉" Catra scoffs at her girlfriend's disposition.

"a few minutes is not enough for everything i have in mind," she smirks, remembering how easily her fingers slid against her girlfriend's sensitive spots when she could afford to take her time. "but i guess it will do."

*

The edges of Catra's lips twitch. "You are close, aren't you?" She hums as she hears Adora's breathing getting more and more labored on the other end of the line. "I can tell."

"Y-yes," Adora sighs, clearly struggling to speak. "*Almost –,*" her voice breaks into a stifled moan.

With her eyes closed, Catra likes to pretend she's blindfolded. She pretends that Adora is with her and the suppression of senses is part of their foreplay, or perhaps that they are trying a new game, touching themselves so the other can see. There are so many options at the disposal of her imagination: she can imagine Adora squirming under her tongue, grinding desperately against her hand, or riding her strap while lying with her face down on the bed. They can be in Adora's bedroom, on the kitchen floor, on a plane, or in a public bathroom stall. In moments like this one, she has the luxury of not having to choose. Fragments of real memories and flashes of everything she hopes to experience with Adora one day; past and possible futures, the best of both worlds brought together in fantasy.

"Fuck, Adora, I can *hear* how wet you are," Catra increases the pace of her fingers on herself, getting even more turned on by the exquisite sounds Adora's giving her. "It's so fucking hot to hear you like that, did you know that? So needy ... And I bet you *taste* even better than you sound."

Adora grunts and pants. The noise makes Catra's skin vibrate and her nipples harden. "*Catra –,*" she gasps. "*Are you?..*"

Oh, yes. Catra's close, too. It takes a whole lot of brainpower to keep the conversation going when she's almost there herself, but the idea of coming together even though they're so far apart is too delicious to discard.

"Would you like that, princess? Mm? To have my mouth on you right now?" From the sudden change in the rhythm of Adora's breathing, Catra knows her answer is *yes*. Eyes still closed, her nails dig into the pillow, then she runs her free hand over her hair, down her collarbone and upper body, rubbing and squeezing the sensitive spots along the way. "My tongue on you, my lips." She chuckles darkly. "Fuck, I remember you begging me to fill you with my fingers while I was eating you out on our last night. I think I could come just by hearing that again."

A loud whimper comes from the other end of the line. Catra is reminded of how beautiful she looks when she stops back.

"Oh, fuck, Catra, I —" Adora calls out again, and this time Catra succumbs, getting lost in the sound of her name being chanted with such passion.

No other words come out of their mouths. Just an uncoordinated series of moans, sighs, and grunts, their throaty noises mingling with the wet sounds they are making. The tuneless melody lingers for a while until they climax, and then everything falls silent.

Only their ragged breathing remains, connecting them like an invisible thread. Catra feels somewhat lulled by the sound. They can't touch each other, but it's like they could.

They stay like that for a moment. A few relieved sighs and surprised chuckles break the silence. They've been doing this regularly since Catra came back, but each time is completely different and new. It's like they are kids again, discovering the potency their bodies have, no matter how far away they are.

"Heey - it's... I just noticed it's already midnight over there," Adora says in a slurred and goofy voice, sounding almost like she's high. Maybe that's an accurate description because Catra feels the same way. *"I guess that means happy birthday! I hope you have a fun and cake-filled day,"* she giggles. *"And no sharks! Hopefully."*

Catra opens her eyes, her skin still tingling, her body still buzzing. "Thanks," she chuckles when noticing how hoarse and weak her own voice is. "There'll be no actual cake, but cupcakes will definitely be on the menu." Her friend Entrapta has a thing for tiny food and she's the one in charge of the snacks for the evening.

"Then enjoy your cupcakes, Force Captain. And know that you are one of the best gifts I could have received in the last year."

"You sap," she says shyly. "And when am I getting my present?"

"Uh - I thought I just gave you one," Adora sasses. Swifty's bark echoes through the call. *"Oh, hey, Swifty wants to say happy birthday too!"*

"Thanks, Swifty," Catra smiles as her brain gradually gets back to full function. "Wait. Was the dog there the entire time?"

"Uhh, haha, I just opened the bedroom door." Catra stretches out on the bed, working up the courage to do the same, knowing the cat must be wanting to get in. *"Okay, so about your present, I have news. You said Remember's should be published in January, right? So I was thinking about taking the Christmas and New Year's break, and then we would spend it together and come back here for the book tour. What do you say?"*

Now that's a fucking birthday present. It's a lot less waiting than Catra imagined. It means that in less than two months they will be together again.

"That sounds like a good plan," Catra tries not to sound so eager. "Won't your family mind, though?" She asks suspiciously, knowing that Adora has a very close relationship with her family and that the holiday season matters a lot to them.

"Oh, they sure will," the blonde scoffs. *"But, you know, Adam's wedding is coming up. Ill be staying in Fernia with them for a while... I think they can handle Christmas without me. Besides I,*

uh..I really..gu h. Ka y , the truth is, I cant want to wait to see you anymore."

Catra smiles. "W ell, since you're that desperate... Yeah, sure, I *guess* I can bear the cross of having you over," she says sardonically. "It will be a heavy burden, but what is life without sacrifice"…

Adora clicks her tongue. *"Ar-ha, arent you a cute dumbass?"*

Her annoyed voice is the most adorable thing, Catra cant resist teasing her.

"Y oure just too easy to mess with, princess. Y ou know Im kidding, right? I'm looking forward to having you here."

She is, you know. She's more excited than when she got her first book published, and that's saying something. She is just terrible at expressing it in actual words.

It's weird. Catra has no problem taking the lead in a long and hot phone sex session, but ask her to admit how she *really* feels and she is useless. She's used to putting that part of herself in her fictional characters and her books. Speaking out loud and in the first person is still something she needs to work on.

"Ka y. Th en I guess it' s happening! Im gonna buy the tick et right now!"

"That's great." Catra smiles, allowing relief to course through her chest and deciding to give raw sincerity a chance. "W ell – yeah, uh… Yeah, actually it's more than just great. It's the best fucking news I could get today."

"Re ally?" Adora asks for extra reassurance, and Catra can almost see that hopeful light in her eyes.

"Of course, dummy . Trust me, I'll be marking the days on the goddamn calendar."

Adora sighs happily. *"Good birthday present, then?"* She giggles.

There's a pang of anxiety tugging at Catra's chest, as the unexpected news brings a new deadline to their relationship. Catra knows that after *Remember* gets published and the book tour is over, it will only get harder for them to see each other, especially if she doesn't land a new project with Wind Chime Publishings. But she's not about to spoil a happy occasion by worrying about what happens next. Today is not a day to fear the future.

She smiles softly. "*Best* birthday present."

She will have tomorrow for worrying.

*

8:14AM - 11:14AM

The smell of coffee fills the air. Closely followed by a lazy Melog, Catra goes to the kitchen. As she stocks up on her first sips of coffee of the day, she leans against the counter to go through her unread messages and e-mails.

The first one is from her mother. Apparently there's a copywriter position available in her office. *Ha-ha* . No, thanks. Not in a million fucking years. Catra deletes it without even reading the whole thing. Next is a spam mail from Flix Portal, something about a new series based on a videogame franchise or whatever. Delete. The third unread message in her inbox comes from Entrapta, inviting Catra to write the institutional texts for her sex toy company's website. If she accepts, it could become a permanent gig, as she can be in charge of the branded content department.

Mmm. Cool, but that's not really what she's good at, is it? Besides, Catra hates writing on commission and she doesn't think it's a good

idea to mix friendship with work - she can't stand taking orders from anyone, imagine how messy it would be to work for one of her closest friends. No. No, shell reply later , referring Entrapta to someone else.

Yeah, that sounds good.

Moving on...

Oh, finally. Netossa's response about the proposal she submitted a few days ago. Catra's heart skips a beat and her eyes go bright as she skims through the email. It might be too early to propose something new when her current project wasn't even published yet, but Catra has to think a few steps ahead. Plus, she is excited to hear what Netossa thinks about her new idea.

Her excitement turns to disappointment when she sees how many notes her editor has left in the document. "Promising, but not quite there yet." The feedback isn't exactly negative, but it points to a number of issues that Catra needs to address before actually starting to write. "Where is the conflict here?" She is basically telling Catra to start over. "What is this character's purpose?"

Shit.

Catra can't even be angry at Netossa. She knows it was a stretch, probably not her most original idea.

Inspiration hasn't been her closest friend lately. Her notebooks, including the one Adora sent her, have nothing more than scribbles and incoherent notes. Her most recent nightmares involve an enormous blank page on her laptop screen. Of course, none of this is unfamiliar. Every time she's about to start a new project, it kind of feels like being back to square fucking one, like she's lost in the middle of the ocean having to paddle to shore all over again.

But the uncertainty of being between projects bothers her even more now that she has Adora. She has to come up with *something* if she

wants to renew her contract with the Etheria-based publisher.

It's at moments like this that her mother's voice sounds louder than her own. Catra questions her ability and her disposition to make it in this brutal career, afraid of having peaked too soon. When one chooses a career that relies almost exclusively on creativity, negative criticism is never easy to read.

Catra could easily fall into this spiral, but the notification sound of a message from Adora brings her back to Earth. She tries to breathe the frustration away before checking her cell phone.

“Woke up from a really good dream just now and you were in it.”

Oh, only Adora could get a smile out of her now, even if it's a sad one.

“It felt so real... For a moment I thought you were here with me.”

Tears fill Catra’s eyes. “that’ s because i was there, princess,”she types lovingly, “wanna tell me more about that dream?”

“I dont remember much. Just that we were in a car traveling somewhere."

Catra grins, her mind already indulging in the metaphor. “like a road trip? were we going somewhere fun?”

“I have no idea 😅 But u know i dont thnk it mattered. We were together. Making stops along the way , getting to know each other more, discovering new places, talking, among other things 😊 And I knew that no matter where we ended up, we were going to be fine.”

Catra's face unclenches and her expression softens with a long sigh. The prospect of the two going in the same direction is refreshing and, well, inspiring. Adora’s dream reminds Catra of something more important than her momentary career setback.

It reminds her of her greater purpose.

"that sounds nice, yeah." She types, her mind bubbling with new ideas. "hey , well make that trip one day ."

"one is allowed to dream 😌"

In more ways than one, they are already traveling together.

Catra's cell phone vibrates again.

"and your hair was short. It looked so pretty!" Catra instinctively takes her hand to a wavy lock that falls over her shoulder. *"also I thinking princess was playing in the car!"*

"obviously i was the one in charge of the music then," she chuckles, moving from her place in the kitchen to put food in Melog's bowl. The cat appreciates it.

"Probably , yeah! It's all a little hazy , I wish I remembered more. But it was so so good. I just wanted to tell you."

Catra glances at the time, noticing that it's nearly two in the morning on Bright Moon.

"thank you for that. now go back to sleep, dummy ," she types, wishing her next words could come true when she hits send: "i'll be there with you."

"Promise?" Catra scoffs softly.

"of course i promise," her lips crack into a timid smile. "i wanna know how the dream ends."

"Ok 😊 Good morning to you 😘 "

"sweet dreams, princess."

After the message is sent and read, Catra refills her coffee mug, does the most urgent household chores, and goes to her bedroom to find her laptop. Without thinking much about it, she responds to Entrapta's email accepting her offer, as some things are more important than her pride. She then opens Netossa's notes and starts to go through each one of them.

If she wants to know how that dream ends, she has a long way to go. And a lot of work to do.

Chapter End Notes

Once again I left a reference to one of my other fics there somewhere - though it could also work as a reference to @xSinshine's "Her" (go read that fic!).

Hopefully, I'll be more inspired next time around :)

Offline

Chapter Summary

Adora goes to Eternia for Adam's wedding, Catra and Entrapta reach a mutually beneficial agreement.

Catra realizes how strong her feelings for Adora are.

Chapter Notes

Hello again! I wish you had a very chill holiday (or as chill as possible), filled with good food and great fanfic to read.

Things were busy on my end - work-busy, I mean - so I couldn't really write for a while, hence why it took so long for me to post this update. But here I am! With another chapter of this long-distance relationship story.

OK, so this chapter has a CW , but at the same time I don't want you to be spoiled, so I'll leave it in the end notes. If you must, scroll down to read it before reading the chapter, ok? Incidentally, I swear I am still committed to this being a fluffy fic, so trust me.

I really hope you enjoy this chapter! W riting it gave me great joy , and I wish I can share some of it with you.

Comments are always appreciated! Y ou have no idea how much I love reading your thoughts.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

4:48 AM - 5:19 AM

Something furry pricks Catra's nose, waking her up. She opens her eyes to realize her head is not on her pillow, and that the first rays of

sunlight are already coming through the crack in the curtain. When she looks up, her first reaction is outrage. Then, after a few tired yawns and grunts, her arm reaches for her cell phone on the bedside table to take a picture.

There are some unread messages from Adora, mostly pictures, videos, and audios from Adam's wedding party, but Catra sends the photo before going back to take a proper look at them.

"this little shit stole my pillow ," she sends, glancing at Melog who sleeps peacefully where her head should be.

Now she takes the time to look at the photos and videos Adora sent her, and smiles.

She is wearing a white suit and shirt, with a gold cummerbund and bow tie. Her blond hair is pulled back into a bun that leaves a few strands falling over her face, her steel-blue eyes are gleaming with joy . Adora looks so radiant, *so* unreservedly happy - hugging her parents, doing a dumb choreography for Deee-Lite's *Groove is In The Heart* with her brother, holding back laughter while sipping from a glass of champagne or stuffing her face with wedding cake. The spontaneity of it all makes her even more stunning, if possible.

While not an early riser, Catra realizes she doesn't mind waking up to that image.

Her chest feels suddenly tight. She wanted to be there. She wishes things could be different. Then again, if things were different, maybe they wouldn't have gotten this far. And Catra finds solace in the fact that they are only sixteen days away from meeting again.

Sixteen days that don't seem to go by fast enough, but still sixteen days.

"seems like ur having a blast, princess," Catra sighs, regretting not being able to attend Adam's wedding in person, but glad to be a part

of this special time in any way she can. "happiness looks good on you."

Sera is typing…

And just like that, Catra's sleep is nowhere to be found. She looks at the clock and recalculates the time difference between them, changed by four hours during the days Adora is in Grayskull City, Eternia, with her family.

"heeeeyy you're up! ♡♡"Adora says. *"Is it selfish that Im kind of happy you got kicked off your pillow???* If it is, sorry!"

"mmm i guess i can forgive u,"Catra wriggles up the bed to sit against the headboard and type more comfortably. "but only if u promise to bring that suit with you when you come here."

"MY suit?! Why?"

Catra's smile turns suddenly evil. "because i cant wait to take it of f."

"😳"Catra grins, knowing her words had the intended ef fect. Teasing Adora still feels wonderful as it did the first day they started interacting. "*Well* now you're making me blush in front of my entire family 😳"

The message has Catra snorting.

"mission accomplished then,"she gloats while stroking Melog's ear , which earns her a soft nibble. "so are u having a good time there so far?"

Catra has a reason to be checking in. Adora always refers to her brother and her parents in a very affectionate way, and from the pictures she looks undoubtedly cheerful. But no matter how loving, family is always a tricky thing to navigate, as there is always so much baggage involved. Besides, Catra knows how far Adora is willing to ignore her own needs just to make her parents happy - and

the emotional toll this has on her. They never spoke directly about it, but Catra suspects that this was one of the reasons Adora moved from Eternia to Etheria for college, and why she decided to stay there after she graduated: to breathe.

“I thinkmy stomach is aching with excitement 😂” Alright. If that's the reason, everything seems to be fine. *“I mean Adam is on cloud nine and I've never seen my parents this happy. Music is good, the food is AMAZING and everyone's dancing and having fun.”* Catra smiles, letting the warmth of Adora's words fill her chest. *“There's just so much love in the room, you know?”*

Oh, yes. As a matter of fact, Catra knows a thing or two about that. Thousands of miles away, she can feel there’s love in the room.

“I'm really happy to read that,” she replies with sincerity. “I know how anxious and overworked you've been lately, so it's a well-deserved break.”

“Yeah!”

Melog approaches and rubs their head against Catra’s shoulder, asking for attention. Catra begins to stroke them under their chin, and they are purring when her phone buzzes again.

“Too bad nothing is perfect, right?”

With a long exhale, Catra’s smile turns nostalgic. “Sixteen days, princess.”

“Yesss! 16 dayssss 🥳🥳🥳”

She adds a gif with a little girl doing a happy dance to her message.

“Now go enjoy the party, dummy,” Catra regains her place on the pillow after she successfully lures Melog to her lap. “I dont mean to keep u.”

“Alright alright! Well talk later . Hope you are able to sleep again!”
She starts to settle down to sleep again, but the phone vibrates once more. *“And Ill make sure to bring the suit 😉”*

Catra starts to cackle, then her mouth is taken into a yawn. “you fucking better.”

She goes back to sleep effortlessly;Melog curls into a ball beside her stomach.

6AM 30M

The charts on the RuneSlides presentation read like gibberish, but Entrapta looks *really* excited about them - and that’s all Catra needs to know.

“So according to the data, over the past month, more specifically since we started posting *your* stories on our blog, our bounce rate has dropped by 24 percent and the average session length has increased to *7minutes* ,”she screeches and claps her hands cheerfully. And even *more* importantly, we had a 5 point 3 percent growth in purchases, which is *way* above our monthly target. *Ah!* I hereby conclude our experiment was a resounding success!”

“Uh,”Catra glances at the screen and smirks, lazily tracing the edges of her cell phone with a fingertip. “Guess one should never underestimate people’s thirst for horny content.”

“That is correct!”Entrapta exclaims with a wide a proud smile. At this point, her assistant offers Catra a champagne glass and tiny scones. “I’d like to propose a toast to celebrate this *fascinating* discovery,” she raises her glass of grape soda before taking a sip.

“Yeah, well,”with a light scoff, Catra raises an eyebrow before taking the champagne glass to her lips. “Hear , hear or whatever.”She puts her feet on the table, amused with the fact that her friend is going through all that formality even though it's just the two of them in the conference room. “Anyway , glad I could help some people to get off.”

Catra is surprised at how much she means that.

Taking commissions from Pulse, Entrapta's sex tech startup, has been a low-pressure and fun experience.

For starters, it paid well - not a lot, but enough for her to start saving money again, which was her reason to take the job in the first place. Secondly, contrary to what Catra feared, her new assignment didn't interfere with their friendship or with her career - in some ways, it was even helpful. In a month overloaded with interviews with literary critics and queer culture bloggers, producing erotic fiction to help sell vibrators was an entertaining way to catch her breath and reconnect with her inner muse.

Finally, Catra discovered that writing porn as branded content for Entrapta's company comes with some *very interesting* perks. She has had the opportunity to try out new toys - for strict research purposes, obviously. A girl must attest to the quality of the products she's writing about, right?

Needless to say, Adora also loved this part of the deal. Especially Darla, the toy with some *very inspiring* long-distance features that made physical absence between them much more bearable during their intimate conversations.

Catra grins wickedly when she notices from the Entrapta's chart that "Quality time with Darla" was her most popular story.

"I'd be happy to help again in the future," she adds. "If it remains a no-strings-attached deal, I mean."

"Great!" Entrapta cheers then turns her attention to the computer in front of her. "I'm glad you mentioned that! Yes, I think we can *both* agree that the commission arrangement was mutually beneficial," she says while frantically making calculations and economic projections in an electronic spreadsheet. "Let's see: if you continue to give me two - no, *three* short stories a month, and sales increase accordingly, I will be able to expand the engineering team and

release a new product line in less than a year!" As she speaks and types, the graphics on the screen change at a speed only Entrapta herself is able to keep up with. "And another bright side is that you can write from anywhere in the world, even from Etheria! You know, once you move there."

Wait, what?

Catra grips her cell phone defensively. It crosses her mind that Entrapta may have tracked the purchase she made for Adora and she feels her privacy somewhat invaded.

"Whoa, whoa, hold on, *move* to?" She scoffs in unconvincing denial. "I'm not moving to – Wait, what makes you think I am planning to do that?"

Entrapta glances at her, then back at the computer. "Well, I am only basing myself on the data," she rolls her office chair closer to Catra and starts counting on her fingers as she speaks. "You *did* search for an Etherian-based publishing house to get your first international novel published. You are fluent in English. You've already established important work connections there. The publishing market there is much healthier and more promising than ours, especially for a queer author. If you want a more permanent contract with Wind Chime, moving there would make it a lot more practical. It just seems like the most logical next step."

"Oh," Catra says as if she had forgotten that her career was moving towards Etheria long before Adora was a part of her life. "Right. That's what you are talking about, *heh*," she clears her throat.

"Of course! What else would I be talking about?" Entrapta says casually as she goes back to typing furiously on her computer. "You have several good motives to move to Etheria and considering all the variables that are under your control I think it would be a more successful decision for your life than the alternative of staying here in Salfmoon."

"Yeah. I guess you're right," Catra mumbles vaguely, a twinge of fear causing her to shiver.

And then the phone vibrates in Catra's hand, and her lips curve easily into a smile, and fear gets mixed with a good dose of tenderness.

Speaking of good reasons to move to Etheria…

"Oof, the line at the hardware store was like… finished all my errands and am back to my parent's house, finally 😢 Would be down to cuddle whenever you have a chance!"

Catra feels her limbs turn liquid for a second or two. Oh, she's so soft for this girl.

"I'm wrapping things up with entrapta and can voice chat in half an hour or so," she types quickly. "How u feeling better?" She asks, knowing that Adora was feeling slightly hung over from Adam's wedding earlier today.

Seer is typing…

Catra taps her fingers on her cell phone, then leaves it on the table.

What if she *did* move?

What are the chances that things will really work out in her career? And with Adora? Wouldn't it be too soon? Would moving put unnecessary pressure on both?

While Adora's answer doesn't come, she resumes her conversation with Entrapta.

"But you dont think it's crazy?" She asks casually. "I mean, to risk everything I have here to move somewhere else?"

Her friend's eyes flick to her, then back to the computer.

"Risk? *Ah!*" Entrapta yells and opens her arms enthusiastically. "Every new experiment starts needs risk, because a scientist never has control over all the variables. I wouldn't have a company if I hadn't risked a good part of my equity in it. And a lot of people said I was crazy, that Pulse wouldn't last for six months. If I had listened to them, I wouldn't be here with you right now, celebrating," she grins widely. "Sure, it didn't happen immediately, there were casualties along the way, and the circumstances were against me on many occasions. But progress would never happen if people spent their lives wondering if their ideas are crazy," she speaks firmly, eyes closed and finger raised as if she were taking an oath.

"Uh," Catra says thoughtfully. "That makes... That makes a lot of sense."

It's easier said than done, of course, but Entrapta has a solid point.

Why is Catra postponing this decision anyway? This is what she wants, she should just go get it. What is she afraid of?

A new message from Adora pops up on her cell phone screen.

"Uh, not really." Catra frowns with worry. *"I mean, I'm mostly fine, I guess, but I am still kind of queasy and my stomach hurts* 😟"

Mmm. Okay, Catra doesn't like the sound of that.

"hey i know it's none of my business, but" She chooses her next words carefully. "maybe u shouldn't be running errands for your family all day if u r not feeling well, princess."

Entrapta asks her assistant to bring another batch of tiny scones; Adora's next text flashes after no more than a minute.

"Oh no no, it's all good! I'm fine! 😂 *Besides, since I'm not gonna be here for Christmas, I'm lending them an extra hand on a few things around the house."*

Ugh.

Guilt. The infallible engine of messed-up family dynamics.

"yeah but does it always have to be your hand though?" She types on protective impulse, not really caring if she is coming across a bit rude. "I mean, u should be taking care of yourself."

"I know 😊😊" Catra scoffs and rolls her eyes at the message before a goofy smile shows up on her face again.

Oh, yes, she is soft for this girl. And if possible, with each interaction they have she seems to get softer.

"just looking out for you, dumbass."

Scout is typing…

Many different thoughts are rushing through Catra's mind, confusing emotions are bubbling in her veins: her concern for Adora, the impossibility of being with her physically, the prospect of building a future elsewhere, away from Halfmoon, out of her comfort zone.

Of course, she's always considered moving to Etheria, it's been her career plan all along, but the idea of going ahead with it is suddenly scary. It makes her feel so vulnerable. Like her safety net has been ripped off.

She glances at Entrapta and finds her friend is fully engaged in something on her computer screen. She's not the first person Catra would go to for emotional advice - if she would go to anyone at all - but perhaps her unique and objective way of looking at things is exactly what she needs right now.

"Entrapta. What if I move and ruin everything?" She tries to sound casual, disguising the frailness in her tone with a sip of champagne. "I mean, what if everything goes to shit and I fail and have to come up with a new plan or whatever?"

It's hard to think about that possibility when this is the only plan she’s ever had.

Entrapta stops what she's doing and crosses her arms on the table. She looks deeply at Catra, as if considering every word she's about to say.

"If it goes to shit, it goes to shit,” she says quite bluntly before taking a bite of a tiny scone. "But at least you will know . And knowing is always better than *not* knowing in my book.” She adds, making a clear effort to sound more empathetic. "Besides, Catra, you've already succeeded at the most difficult part of the equation! You are about to publish a book *there*, while still living *here*. The data shows that you've already got this. Moving there would just be a way of making it more official and. You know, less expensive for all the interested parties,” she says while doodling smiley faces on a post-it note. "And if it fails, there's no reason to get testy or anything. Scientific progress is built on failure! It's a vital part of any experiment. If you had nothing to lose, it wouldn't be so exciting!"

"That is true,” Catra says, finishing off her glass and waving to Entrapta's assistant for a refill.

"And if by any chance the desired outcome doesn't come, you can always go back a few steps and adjust your hypothesis."

That is comforting. Knowing she has somewhere to go back to. With that thought, Catra feels a surge of relief about the idea of moving.

"That was. Surprisingly helpful,” she says light-heartedly . "Thanks, Entrapta.”

"No problem!" Entrapta changes the screen projection to another presentation, with models and schematics. "Now , can I introduce you to the new EBS line?"

While she prepares, Catra's cell phone vibrates again.

“Thankyou for worrying. I really appreciate it. And you. I’m gonna take it easy for the rest of the day , alright?! I promise I’m going to get there in one piece 😉”

“two weeks, huh?” She sighs in anticipation, noting that for nearly a year of their long-distance dating they've always been counting down to something. “get some rest :)”

“15 days!”

Who knows. Maybe soon they won't have to count down anymore.

2021 10AM

The Bright Moon Chronicler, MachaBubbleBlog, The Plumerian Times, The Twelfth Moon, The Grayskull Inquirer , Scholar’s Daily, Draconian Reviews, Queer's Gabby , the Please Read Project - a few of the most relevant newspapers, websites, and podcasts in the Eternian Realms, and they all seem to agree: *Remember* is a book worth reading.

Since the reviews started to come out this morning, Catra has already received very satisfied messages from Netossa and Spinerella. The public's search for the pre-sale book was immediate, and the publisher is very happy with the numbers so far. With that, Catra feels she is one step closer to a permanent contract with Wind Chime.

She checks her messages. Her best friend Scorpia has already sent her an enthusiastic "hooray!" Entrapta has once again encouraged her to pack her bags and leave Halfmoon for good, and even her mother had to acknowledge that she is on the right path.

She smirks with pride as she rereads the words of Labelle Petty, one of Etheria's most acclaimed literary critic: “With a provocative and innovative style, Remember takes us on a journey through time and memory.” The edge of Catra’s lips quiver as she savors this inexplicable sensation, the taste of having her work recognized. “K

Lynx’s writing is witty, evocative, and spicy in the right measure. Definitely, an author to remember.”

Ah, this is priceless. Better than any drug Catra has ever tried, legal or otherwise. Few things can compare to this buzz she’s feeling right now.

And there’s only one person in the world she wants to share this achievement with.

She forwards the link to Adora with a grin. Euphoria gets mixed with a dash of concern when she realizes her girlfriend still hasnt responded to any of the messages she’s sent so far.

This is unusual, sure, but Catra wouldn't really be worried if Adora hadn't mentioned she still wasnt feeling well when they hung up the phone last night. She complained about having abdominal cramps, then swore everything was perfectly fine when Catra suggested that maybe it would be better to go see a doctor. *“Dnt worry , Force Captain, I just tooka painkiller 💊💊 If I still feel bad when I go backto Bght Mon, I will make an appointment,"* was her last message before they said goodbye. *“But Im sure it’ s nothing!”*

Ugh, so stubborn. She does this thing where she tries to be stronger than human.

Still, it's not that late in the morning in Eternia. Maybe she's still sleeping.

‘I hope you’re getting some rest for a change. send me a word whenever you can.”

Something heavy tugs at Catra's chest, like a warning bell ringing somewhere inside. But she repeats to herself it's too soon to be worried.

Everything must be fine.

8:15 PM

Everything is *not* fucking fine. She checks her cell phone again, getting a bit more concerned when seeing that the last message she sent to Adora didnt even reach her girlfriend's device and that her cell phone is now turned off.

Adora is offline.

On any other day, she wouldn't mind. They've gone longer than that without contact before. But today, Catra knows. She just knows that something is *off*.

She was perfectly happy no more than a few hours ago, and now she can't stop thinking about the worst. She completely understands now what Adora told her about nearly having a heart attack when Catra surprised her in Bright Moon, and she wishes karma didnt have to come to bite her in the ass.

And she especially hates feeling so useless, so powerless.

So disconnected.

That's the worst part of the distance - not the longing, not the yearning, but the imminent and very *real* possibility of sudden disconnection. Without phone service or the internet, without technology, what keeps them together? When every means of communication fails, what do they have?

She is digging through Glimmer and Bow's social media profiles, trying to find some way to contact them when her phone rings.

About fucking time.

Catra takes a deep breath and lets out a long exhale, feeling stupidly relieved just to be reading Adora' s name on the screen.

"Hey," she says a little cautiously as if still waiting for the bad news. "Decided to get even after all this time?"

"*Hello, uh - you're Catra, right?*" An unfamiliar , deep voice asks, and Catra knows immediately that her worst suspicions were right: something *is* wrong. *"We dont know each other . I'm Adam. I'm - Adora's brother."*

Chills go down Catra's spine as she sits on her office chair. If there's something capable of breaking down her cool facade, something capable of making her understand what fear truly is, that something is this telephone call.

"Adam? What is going on?" Her hands curl into fists, squeezing so hard her nails dig into his skin. "Is – fuck, is Adora alright?"

"Yeah, yeah, yeah, no, dont worry , she is okay - I-I mean, she is okay now! Everything is fine," he reassures, and Catra feels her lungs deflating softly. *"Look, she woke up in the middle of the night with a fever , feeling a lot of abdominal pain, and I, uh. W -we rushed her to the hospital. Turns out it was her appendix"*

Ouch. Catra can only imagine the pain she felt. Scorpia had to take her appendix out and she has mentioned how unbearable the pain is.

"Oh, fuck," Catra replies, her hands go numb and her mouth goes dry as she briefly realizes what could have happened if Adora hadn't made it to the hospital in time. "You're kidding me."

"I wish," Adam chuckles awkwardly, and Catra captures the residual panic in his voice because it resembles her own. *"Yeah, but she's out of surgery now and the doctors told me everything went smoothly."*

"That's a fucking relief," she confesses.

"And s-sorry it took so long to let you know ," he continues. *"She kept asking me to text you or call you, but in the confusion, we didnt bring her phone. I got a hold of it just now, then I had to find a charger*

and... uh. Well, uh, sorry again. You understand, right? It's been a long day," he vents. *"I'm just glad it's finally over."*

Poor guy sounds like a wreck.

Catra closes her eyes and scratches the back of her neck. "Yeah, tell me about it."It's better news than she was bracing herself for, yet all the muscles in her body are completely stiff. "Can I talk to her?"

"Uh, let me – hold on a second." Catra waits for a few agonizing seconds. *"Hmm, she is still sleeping. The anesthesia is pretty strong, I thinkshe's going to be out of it for a while."*

She tries to smile. "Well, if it knocked Adora out, they must have given her the really good drugs."

"Ooh, yeah, they certainly did," Adam scoffs surreptitiously. *"But hey, Catra, listen. Mysister was worried that she wouldn't be able to travel to see you because of the surgery. Like, she literally didn't settle down until the doctor reassured her that this is a simple procedure, in terms of recovery and all, so a trip in two weeks'time won't be a problem. She made me promise that I'd call you to tell you that this doesn't change your Christmas plans."*

That sounds like Adora, alright.

"I don't fucking care about that so long as she's okay,"Catra blurts out, letting her words wash away the panic she is still clinging to. "You know she spent the day neglecting the pain so she wouldn't let you guys down, right?"

A short pause.

"Did she... I - no, I did not know that. Uh. That is.Well, that is classic Adora, actually," Adam says, and his tone almost makes Catra laugh.

"Yeah. For some reason, she thinks she needs to be the one who's always on top of everything. Maybe if she didn't feel that way, this wouldn't have to be classic Adora," Catra chides through gritted teeth, not caring if she sounds salty.

Adam sighs. *"You are absolutely right,"* he repeats. After another short and awkward pause, he takes a tangent. *"Well, I guess I can see why my sister, uh,"* he clears his throat, swallows an "L." *"why she cares about you so much."*

Hearing those words, the adrenaline finally starts to fade, and serotonin kicks in. Adora told her family about Catra, and the feeling is as rewarding as reading good reviews of her work in the newspapers.

Well, probably more.

Catra thinks back to when she and Adora started talking two years ago. The dispute between virtual strangers slowly turned into a friendship. A platonic attraction that grew into this nameless thing, this feeling that fills Catra's chest with warmth in the good times and hurts like a punch in the stomach when something goes wrong.

It's a crazy emotional rollercoaster.

And with the tension and relief and subsequent urge to look for a plane ticket to Grayskull City right fucking now, there's no doubt about what it is. It is love. Love is the thing that keeps them together when every means of communication goes offline.

Terribly tacky, but nevertheless true. Catra loves Adora. Fuck, she loves Adora more than anyone she's ever loved in her whole damn life. She loves her enough to make road trip plans and to get excited about visiting dumb castle ruins;enough to tolerate watching reality trash on TV, go to volleyball games, and even to admit her secret passion for old romantic comedy movies.

Enough to want a future where she's not alone.

The thing is, before Adora, Catra had always imagined herself single, and that was actually okay. Alone is fine, really. She enjoys her own company. Being alone is easier. People are complicated and usually not worth her trust. But now, when she contemplates the future, she really can't imagine it without that cocky blond veterinarian with a dorky sense of humor - or, well, she *can*, but she prefers not to.

And the idea of not being able to see Adora, of not being able to be there with her right now, hurts Catra more than she could even begin to explain. She decides she doesn't want to feel this impotent again, and that she will do whatever it takes to never have to.

"Yeah, uh – I... I care about her very much, too," she stutters in response, finding it difficult to articulate those words, especially to a semi-stranger. "Hey, Adam, thank you for calling me or whatever.

"Oh, I'm sure she'd kick me if I hadn't," he laughs.

"Keep an eye on her for me, alright?"

"Of course. According to the doctor, she should be released in a day or two."

"Can you please let me know when she wakes up? I'd really like to talk to her," Catra pleads, knowing that her mind won't rest before she listens to Adora's dumb voice again.

"Don't worry," he says rather kindly.

Disconnected once again, Catra's nerves are still on edge. Adora's fine. She knows it was just a scare. But she dreads this feeling of impotence. Staying here, sitting around, doing nothing.

She wanders around her office, puts food for Melog, calls Scorpia, turns on some music, tries to read a book, watches Mara and tries that new animated show with the sapphic couple that everyone is talking about.

When nothing seems to put her mind at ease, she decides to take action, or at least the only action that is in her power. She opens her laptop and stares at the blank screen for a few seconds.

And then the words that were failing her finally start to flow - incoherent, a bit chaotic, but words, nonetheless. Maybe the beginning of a new project, maybe a story she never finishes. But as she lets her thoughts and feelings fill the screen, she remembers why she started writing in the first place, why she fell in love with it. The company and comfort of words, a part of her that she can reach even in moments like this, have always helped her process her emotions, no matter how confusing they may be.

Hours pass. She has over two thousand words by the time the phone rings again, and although she is feeling much better than when she started, it is Adora's voice that finally brings her peace.

"Catra?" She sounds so sweet, and her voice is so slurred, perhaps still groggy from the drugs.

It's adorable.

"Hey, Adora," Catra sighs with a smile and trembling hands. "Welcome back. How are you feeling?"

"Mmm, just peachy," she says, dragging out each syllable and snorting.

"That's good to hear, princess," she grins tenderly, wishing to look into her eyes now. "You scared me, you know. I was so worried."

But it's okay. Scared is not that bad, really, and Catra understands that now. Scared means she has something to lose. And as Entrapta told her, life wouldn't be exciting if she had nothing to lose.

"Catra, I'm so sorry! I told Adam to call you like a million times but then the phone was stupid and then there was a scan and then the doctors - heeey, Glimmer is here! Hi, Glimmer!"

"No, no, don't be sorry , dummy, you have nothing to feel sorry for," Catra makes negative gestures with her hand and head as if Adora could see her. "Just.T. ake care of yourself, alright? Focus on getting better."

"Yes, Force Captain Catra," she giggles. "*D- Ad you!Y ou, though: you have to promise me one thing. One very important thing."*

Catra raises a curious eyebrow and scoffs. "Y eah, sure. What is it?"

"Y ou have to promise me, Catra. Promise me that you will hydrate."

She chuckles softly. "Okay . I'll make a note of that."

After hanging up with Adora, Catra feels the high of waking up from a nightmare and realizing it wasn't real - the downside of being connected to someone, she reckons. Still, she now knows that she prefers this over the alternative. The really good part can only come when you take a risk.

Two weeks later, the really good part comes. And when the airport gate opens and Catra finally gets to see Adora again, when she gets to the kisses and the warmth of Adora's body and to her irresistible smile, when she sees the small scar from the surgery on the right side of her abdomen, she decides what she wants to do next.

But each thing at its time. For now, she will just take Adora home with her.

29M29M29M

Chapter End Notes

CW: health scare (but just the scare, I swear)

Yes, there are Arcane references and fandom references scattered around this chapter, as well as She-Ra references.

I also would like to add that the idea of Adora and Adam doing a twin-choreography of Groove is In The Heart lives in my mind rent-free now that I unlocked the MOtU box. Also I would like to give AceAutie huge thanks for figuring out where Etheria and Eternia would be in the real map (thus solving the time difference between them).

Oh, by the way, sorry for the quick scare, but you see, I'm so committed to the fluff that I didn't leave you in a cliffhanger! Christmas came!Christmas came with the best of presents! They are together again!Y aaaaay!

Tethering

Chapter Summary

With Catra as her host, Adora spends 20 days in Halfmoon.

Chapter Notes

I am here again :) And I am so, so happy this chapter is finally finished. Not much to say, just that I hope you enjoy it!It's been so amazing writing this story, and I am sorry it's getting closer to its end (maybe that's why I'm writing soooo slower), but I am also so proud of it.

I really really hope you enjoy what you're about to read.

And I'd love to hear your thoughts about it :)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

61 1M

Cringer is attempting to climb the kitchen cupboard to sniff at the wooden board while Adam happily slices a carrot, singing along to one of his favorite romantic ballads from the 90s. Today is a good day, right at the end of a really good year. This is going to be a more than special holiday season: the first with his new marital status, and that calls for a particularly amazing celebration. Armed with his new fancy chef's knife, it is in the kitchen that his fabulous secret powers are revealed.

W. ell, heh, or so he likes to believe.

He's checking on the lamb in the oven when his text message alert goes off.

“Adora, dearie! This is auntie Razz. Listen dearie, I dont want to disturb you on your trip but I am afraid I really need your help . Please give me a call when you can.” Adam chuckles, as this is not the first time his aunt mixes up her contacts. While Adora is at Honeymoon, Razz is tending to Swifty and the plants in her apartment in Bright Moon. She can bake a fantastic pecan pie and is one of the wisest people Adam knows. Technology, however, is not her forte.

“love, aunt Razz 💖 ”

“Hey auntie! You texted the wrong twin again LOLOL 😂 This is Adam, not Adora!” He considers adding that she doesn't have to sign every message, but then decides it's not worth it.

“Oh I’m so sorry dearie, have a nice day ! ” Another message comes almost immediately. “*Tell Teela I said hi !*”

“OK. Love u!” Adam is about to peel the pile of potatoes in front of him, but he remembers something Catra said about Adora always being the one who takes care of everyone in the family. He also remembers Adora, drunk on anesthesia, rambling about how much she loves this girl. Sigh. After everything that happened, his sister more than deserves an undisturbed vacation, he reckons. “Wait but did something bad happen? Maybe I can help!”

Razz is typing…

Still staring at the screen, Adam leans back against the kitchen counter as he waits for an answer.

“I cant find any more mara on adora’s tv!” It takes a few good seconds for Adam to understand his aunt is referring to an ancient TV show his sister became obsessed with over this past year . *“how will I know what happened to hope ??”*

Adam laughs, wondering how he will be able to give a happy ending to this great tragedy.

10:01

Pleasure builds as Catra's tongue finds a steady rhythm between Adora's legs, her hands gripping each of Adora's thighs, her nails digging into the bare skin as her lips deftly take care of her throbbing apex. Adora's white suit jacket is draped over the foot of the bed, the cummerbund is tied tightly behind her head, covering her eyes, the golden fabric blending with her blond hair.

Deprived of sight, Adora feels her body's every response with greater intensity, Catra's touches across her skin take on a flavor of surprise, and she shivers at each of them. It was Catra who brought up this idea, after having recounted in exquisite and titillating detail what was going through her mind while the two teased each other over the phone, over the months they had been apart. The suggestion turned into foreplay, and Adora was eager to give the experiment a try.

In addition to the heightened sensations, the experience is also an exercise of trust, of putting herself so vulnerable and at her lover’s mercy, and it is proving itself to be incredibly arousing for both of them. As if that wasn't enough, the mere thought of being able to give Catra the same kind of pleasure a few minutes later makes her toes curl in anticipation as she allows herself to surrender to the darkness even further.

With every lick, every lap, every wet kiss Catra is giving her, Adora feels the signs - her rapid breathing, her bobbling knees, her whole body telling her that she’s about to reach that zone where all control is lost, where any attempt of self-governance will fail - and oh, she wants to get there so badly. Catra must feel it coming too: Adora can sense it by the smile Catra’s lips are drawing against her most sensitive spot, by the way her nails dig deeper into her thighs, and by the self-satisfied, throaty chuckle she is letting out against Adora's skin.

In one quick motion, Catra’s hands spread Adora’s legs wider. Adora feels a ghostly fingertip running up her stomach, all the way to her chest, and although the touch is light and gentle, it has her shaking in its wake. The hand teasingly outskirts her right breast, shooting

small electrical discharges through Adora's body. When her nipple is caught between two of Catra's fingers, she moans uncontrollably, already dancing on the edge of her climax, feeling the hot pressure build in her temples, ready to surrender completely.

When Catra pushes a finger inside her while continuing to lick her center vigorously, Adora finds release. She allows the ecstasy to wash over her. Adora laughs, moans, squirms, holds on to the linen sheets, all the while trusting Catra to guide her through the aftershocks as the peak of her pleasure begins to subside.

"Wow," she exhales breathlessly after it fades, taking off the blindfold. "This was... Wow."

"Yeah." Then Adora opens her eyes and sees her own pleasure glistening on Catra's smirking face, a proud and worshipful expression in her eyes.

A refreshed wave of arousal hits her. Adora measures Catra up and down, her eyes lingering on her small breasts, which are rising and falling with her ragged breathing. Adora's throat dries up, she grips the blindfold tightly and bites her lower lip.

Time to switch positions.

The first weekend of the 20 days Adora is spending in Half-Moon was simply that: two bodies stubbornly trying to subvert the laws of physics and occupy the same space, one trying to fill the other, trying to make up for the time they've been apart. To be clear, in choosing the word "simply," I don't mean to sound dismissive or demeaning. No, because sometimes "simple" is everything one needs. Wrapped in the sheets of Catra's bed, the pleasure they are discovering together is also the embodiment of their connection, of an intimacy that has not been lost or eroded over time.

While still shrouded in a sense of carnal urgency due to the ticking clock that insists on tormenting them, sex with Catra feels more…

tender, now. Adora is realizing how zealous and gentle her girlfriend can be in bed, how caring.

Perhaps it's because Adora just had surgery , perhaps it's because emotions can run especially high during the holidays, or perhaps it's because her girlfriend is taking the nickname "princess" at face value, but Catra has been mindful of Adora's every need, trying to anticipate them. Though some words have yet to be spoken, Adora would dare to say that they are not fucking or having sex - they are making love.

Ew , the snort Catra would let out if she heard Adora say that aloud. Adora smiles just by imagining it.

But the simple truth is that thousands of miles from the place she calls home, in Catra's arms Adora has found the concept has nothing to do with geography. She may not know what the future has reserved for them, but she's sure she's ready to take the plunge and face any risk to fight for their relationship.

The days that followed that glorious first weekend also involved getting out of the apartment. Catra has shown Adora through her favorite spots in town: restaurants, bars, tourist attractions, clubs, museums, outdoor fairs, and parties. At the beach, Adora was amused by the warnings to watch out for sharks scattered along the boardwalk - but of course, she didn't dare to set foot in the sea in these areas, however tempting the view might have been.

Speaking of the view, the city is beautiful. Some of the most spectacular landscapes Adora has ever seen. It's also a town full of interesting contrasts, where tradition and modernity, nature and urbanism coexist. Some of those contrasts are sad, as they are the effect and legacy of a long history of social inequalities. Adora's heart was unsettled to witness the injustice and abandonment on some streets. She saw the spark of hurt in Catra's eyes as they passed through certain areas of Dovale and caught the hint of nostalgia in her tone when she explained how alive those places used to be when she was a child.

But none of that is able to erase the inherent richness of a region that was blessed by nature, nor the friendly grin on the face of just about everyone Adora meets. Everyone is helpful and nice. She may not yet understand their language, but Adora understands human warmth - and in that sense, she feels thoroughly welcomed.

From a practical point of view, the city is well equipped, with lots to see, lots to do, lots of cultural activities. It is undeniably a fantastic place to visit - and, well, who knows.

Yeah. Adora can see herself living here.

Though it's just the two of them most of the time, Adora has had the pleasure of meeting Catra's childhood friend Scorpia, a flatwater canoeist and one of Halfmoon's most successful Olympians, whose intimidating figure belies her outgoing and kind personality.

Scorpia's also quite protective of Catra. "Oh, yeah, and... Adora? Look, you seem *super* nice and all, and I'm like, *really* excited for you both! But just so you know, I've never seen Catra talk about a girl the way she talks about you - scratch that, I've never seen her talk about a girl at all, and that's saying something. So as her super pal, I feel like it's my duty to tell you that if by any chance you break my little Wildcat's heart... I'm gonna hunt you, find you, and *kill* you." Her athletic muscles and her bulky size can make the woman seem really scary, but instead of fearing for her life, Adora was happy to find that there are people close to Catra willing to take care of her. "Oh, wow, did I... Did I say that right? Gosh, sorry, my English is a bit rusty, *hehehe*, but yeah, just so we're absolutely clear, the bottom line here is: if you hurt her, I don't care how far away you live. I'll take you down."

Uh... Well, perhaps there was also a slight twinge of fear.

Knowing Adora's love of food, Catra has been keen to introduce her to the local cuisine, and the new flavors and spices have been an experience in itself. She's admittedly intrigued by the local habit of consuming hot dishes on the beach, under the hot sun, but the food

is so good she doesn't question it. And while we're on the subject of the sun, Catra *definitely* wasn't exaggerating when she warned Adora about the heat during the summer. Unaccustomed to such high temperatures, the Etherian young woman can't grasp how people manage to go to work and be productive without ripping off all their clothes.

"Well, feel free to walk around naked if you want," Catra teased when Adora had shared her impressions on an especially hot day. "You won't see me complaining about that."

Now they're on the bed, Catra lying on her back, Adora about to blindfold her, and the heat emanating from their glistening bodies doesn't bother her in the slightest. If anything, she wants the temperature to rise. Drawing circles over Catra's nipples with her tongue, kissing them, biting them, feeling Catra's body melt and writhe beneath hers, Adora feels honored and empowered by the trust her girlfriend is placing in her.

Of all the places Adora has visited in the city, Catra's apartment remains her favorite. The cat, the plants, the shelf filled with books in three (or maybe four) different languages, the bicycle leaning against the wall, the chaise lounge chair, the vinyl records, the guitar that immediately made Adora *beg* to hear a song - a kindness that has yet to be attended. The posters on the walls. Her coffee mug collection. The corner where she usually writes, so full of her scent and her personality.

And, of course, this bed. The bed in which they share their most intimate moments. The bed they had just experimented on with each other.

When Adora is done taking care of her girlfriend's needs, she gently kisses Catra's knuckles before removing her makeshift blindfold. Then she stares into those gorgeous heterochromatic eyes, and happiness fills her chest.

“Hey. Everything okay there?” Adora checks in, noting how heavily Catra's breathing still is even a few minutes after her peak. Because of Catra's suspicious nature, Adora knows that it's harder for her to put herself in a vulnerable position, even if the idea originally came from her.

“Yeah. Just. Fuck. Still recovering, I guess.” She places a chaste kiss on Adora’s forehead, then tucks a strand of her hair behind her ear. “That was very hot.”

Honestly, it was way more than hot. Exchanging that kind of trust is such a powerful and intense experience that she understands why Catra is still dumbfounded.

“*You* were hot,” Adora interjects, her fingertip aimlessly encircling the edge of Catra's breast. “You *are* hot.”

“Mmmm. So are you, princess,” she turns to kiss Adora’s lips, the scent of her wetness still strong on Catra’s mouth. “Thank you,” she says thoughtfully - and then, remembering herself: “N-not for the compliment or whatever, but, you know, for being here. And for agreeing to this.” Adora’s smile grows silly with love, and she's certain that the way she's looking at Catra now is making her feelings transparent.

“Thank you for having me.”

For a short moment, it looks like Catra’s about to say something else, but whatever it was, she chooses not to say it. Instead, she buries her head on Adora’s chest, kisses her collarbone, and closes her eyes.

2PM

With the help of Catra's fingers, the moisturizing lotion spreads over Adora's bare, newly sunburned skin. Leaning against the headboard of the bed with Adora nestled between her legs, Catra is trying to keep her touches gentle, but Adora still lets out a few groans and

hisses of pain when her girlfriend reaches some of the most sensitive spots.

Catra had warned her, alright, but she was so entertained playing volleyball with Scorpia on the beach that morning that she chose not to listen. And by doing so, she underestimated the damage a summer morning by the sea in Dovale would do to her skin.

A mistake for which she is paying the price now.

"Ow ," Adora flinches and tries to mask her discomfort with a low giggle, feeling stupid for being a victim by the *sun*, of all things. "So. Scorpia tells me she has these videos of you playing the guitar. I said I'd rather wait for my personal performance, but since I don't know *how long* that will take, I might take her up on that offer," she adds a purposeful hint of snark to her tone. "She also told me you are an awesome singer."

Having heard Catra's voice in multiple contexts by now , Adora doesn't doubt it to be true.

"Shit, she told you that? Ugh, fuck, I knew leaving you two together would be a terrible idea," Catra grumbles while massaging Adora's shoulder. "Anyway , don't get too excited about that, alright?" She chuckles modestly. "Scorpia is just... I don't know , annoyingly enthusiastic and supportive about everything."

"Kind of reminds me of Bow ," Adora turns to her with a smile, thinking how nice it would be if their friends could get to know each other and hang out. "They would get along well, I think."

"Yeah." Catra seems to consider it for a minute, a lazy smile creeping over her face. "Yeah, I think they would."

"She can stay at my place when she travels to Mystacor for one of those championships she mentioned," Adora offers, referring to a canoe sprint competition that takes place every year in a small city

near Bright Moon. "And I can take her to the plant shop where I bought your Serenias since she liked them so much."

"Y ou *really* dont know what youre of fering there," Catra scof fs while her hands slide over the areas in Adora's body that have been most affected by the sun - shoulders, arms, and shoulder blades. "Scorpia has some serious boundary issues. Besides, the next world championship isnt until August. By then, hopefully , Ill have already , uh "—

Catra stutters and doesn't finish the sentence, briefly interrupting her cares on Adora's back.

"What?" Adora gives her a puzzled look from over her shoulder . "What will happen by August?"

"Uh"…

Melog interrupts Adora's train of thought by bumping their head on her foot and then proceeding to lick her big toe. The sudden tickle has her laughing. "Melog! *aha* , cut it out! Ow ," she hisses at the sharp sting provoked by the small commotion.

"Hey , dumbass, do you mind standing still?" Catra cuts of f, squeezing more lotion into her palm. "I don't want to hurt you there," she threatens in a good-natured way, going back to Adora's shoulders.

"W ell, it's a little too late for that, *heh*," Adora responds awkwardly , wiggling her foot to push Melog away and forgetting the question she had just asked. "But I promise I'll do my best to stay put, Force Captain."

Despite the pain, Catra's touch is soothing and pleasant. Adora doesn't take long to relax again under her hands.

"Such a good girl," Catra purrs, her voice low and sultry as she pulls Adora to her by the belt loops on her denim shorts. And with that,

Adora feels another kind of sting piercing her lower abdomen — not a pang of discomfort, but of desire.

How to stand still when all she wants to do is to melt into Catra's arms?

Luckily, Catra changes the subject.

"You know, for someone who has done *all that research* and believes *so much* in advance preparation or whatever," Catra teases with a hint of sarcasm in her voice. "I have to be honest here, I expected you to be a little more thorough in choosing the right kind of sunscreen for your precious princess skin."

Adora snorts. "Yeah, you weren't joking when you said Halfmoon has an extra sun for each citizen," she says, ever so slightly turning her chin to steal a kiss from Catra's lips. "I'll admit that I didn't take you that much seriously."

"And just look where that got you," Catra regretfully clicks her tongue as she continues to rub Adora's shoulders. "I hope this tragic experience teaches your stubborn ass a valuable lesson."

"It's definitely teaching me something, *heh*, although I'm not sure if it's quite what you had in mind," she adds with a sly smile, absently caressing Catra's inner thigh. "I mean, if this is supposed to be a punishment… You can punish me anytime you like."

"Yeah?" Catra laughs and cocks an eyebrow, her skin shivering with Adora's delicate touch. "Well, I hope you know there are less painful ways to get a massage from me," she discreetly runs a fingertip down Adora's torso, carefully caressing her surgical scar before moving to the waistband of her shorts. "Unless you're into pain… Because in that case, I'd *love* to lend you a hand," she whispers, pressing a sharp nail against Adora's hipbone.

Holy mother of the First Ones.

If Adora still felt any discomfort, it was quickly being overpowered by *need*.

"Uh," She babbles as she feels her insides turn liquid, coherent thoughts starting to slip away.

"That does it for you, huh?" Catra chuckles wickedly, brushing Adora's hair off her shoulders to kiss her neck. "Good to know."

Adora's hand closes around her thigh, and she presses herself against Catra's chest. "I'm starting to wonder if there's anything about you that *won't* do it for me," she confesses, casting a knowing look at Catra from over her shoulder, biting back a smile; her back brushes Catra's breasts through her t-shirt.

"Mmmmm," Catra hums softly before nibbling on Adora's earlobe, her left hand climbing up her girlfriend's bra, her right hand slipping inside her shorts. "I hope we never find out," she whispers.

5:37 PM

Except for the occasional familiar word that she picks up every three sentences, Adora doesn't know what Catra was talking about on the phone with her mother, but she does know her girlfriend isn't happy. She also doesn't need anyone to tell her that the first thing Catra mumbled just after hanging up was a curse word. Adora was going to show the photo her Aunt Razz just sent her - Swifty wearing a unicorn tiara - but she decides to wait for a more propitious moment.

Catra enters the bedroom and looks at Adora, anger and frustration shining bright in her gaze. Upon seeing Adora's expression, she realizes that she has been overheard.

"Sorry about that," she shrugs, leaving her cell phone on the desk. "Dont know why I even care anymore."

"You dont have to apologize for anything, much less for caring." Moved by a strong urge to comfort her, Adora tries for a reassuring

smile, rising from the bed to put her arms around Catra. "Do you want to talk about it?"

"No. It's. It's not even worth it." Catra breaks off from Adora's embrace by taking a step back. "Ugh. Sorry, I, uh." Avoiding eye contact, Catra grabs her own arm. "Look, you don't want to be around me right now, alright? That bitch has ruined the mood."

"Trust me, I don't think that's even possible," she grins. "And I will be here to listen to anything you want to say, when you are ready to say it." While Adora's apprehensive about not being able to make things better, she chooses to give Catra more space and sits on the bed again. "Would you prefer to be alone?" She suggests with a hesitant sigh. "I can clear out, start getting ready for Scorpia's."

They have plans to spend Christmas dinner at Catra's best friend's house, apparently a tradition that has been going on for years, ever since Scorpia's mothers returned to their homeland in the countryside and Scorpia stayed in town to continue with her training. As Entrapta's parents have passed away and as Catra has a complicated relationship with her mother, the trio had promised that they would try to always get together at Christmas.

Adora thought the whole arrangement was very sweet, and she is proud to have been invited into her girlfriend's chosen family.

"Catra?" Adora asks again, speaking softly as if to show that Catra has a safe space to communicate her needs, a technique she's learned from Bow. "Do you want me to leave?"

"No," Catra looks up at Adora and holds her gaze while stepping towards the bed to sit by her side. With a sharp exhale, she covers Adora's hand with her own, resting her head on Adora's shoulder. "Stay with me. Please. Just. Let's talk about something else."

"Sure." Adora smiles as she combs two fingers through Catra's hair. She feels her girlfriend slowly relaxing under her touch. "But I'll be here if you want to open up. No pressure."

"Thank you. Really ."

"There' s no need to thank me."Adora giggles. Melog joins them, taking their place on Adora's lap to knead her thighs. Catra glances at them and her lips part in a discreet smile, and she unclenches a little further in Adora's arms. Silently, Adora strokes Catra's hair for a few moments. She smiles when an idea occurs to her. "But I do have something very important to ask you. I mean, this is something absolutely crucial."

With a worried frown, she turns to look at Adora. "What is it?"

"Will you teach me how to swear in Portuguese?"She says it very seriously, before cracking a silly smile.

Catra bursts out laughing;tension leaves her expression entirely , the sound of her laughter assuaging Adora's anxiety. "Idiot."

Adora makes a funny face. "I'm pretty sure that' s still English."

A long list of swear words and expressions later, Catra is in a fresh mood and even willing to open up a little. She doesn't give Adora much detail, but comments that her mother insists on controlling her and souring her plans, even when she's not around - she's out of town on a business trip, and shouldnt be back before Catra leaves for her book tour in Bright Moon. What should have been a quick Merry Christmas call turned into a discussion about what Catra wants to do with her life from now on as if the success of her book had been a casual "stroke of luck."

More than ever, Adora would like to have a face-off with Catra's mother. I mean, cant she see that Catra is doing an amazing job at running her own life?That her daughter's choices are not for her to control?That bitter lady' s lucky she's out of town because Adora would *love* the opportunity to give her a piece of her mind.

Fortunately, they dont let that inconvenience spoil the rest of their night.

Christmas dinner at Scorpia's is hearty and pleasant, and everything runs smoothly. The food is fantastic, and Catra's friends are very loving people that remind Adora of Glimmer and Bow. She calls them, then her parents and her brother and Razz and Swifty, to wish them all a Merry Christmas. She misses them like *crazy*, but at the same time she wouldn't want to be anywhere else in the world but by Catra's side.

Also, Adora doesn't quite understand why, but Entrapta is genuinely *fascinated* when she discovers that Adora is from Etheria, as if she had found the last piece of a very complicated puzzle. Whatever the reason was, Adora doesn't have a chance to find out, because Catra chooses that moment to distract her with shots of a local and very popular spirit drink. It's strong and warm like tequila and subtly sweet, like rum. The moment it rolls down her throat, her limbs go floppy and her mind gets fuzzy, and she is too giggly to care what they were talking about in the first place.

When they return to the apartment, Catra announces that she is going to give Adora her Christmas present. "You sit right down on that couch, princess, and I'll be right back." She disappears into the dark hall that leads to her bedroom. "Don't move."

"*Hehe*, you don't have to worry about me moving at all, because after that shot of... What's it called? Cache. Cashhhhasss." Adora's voice is slurred, and she realizes that she probably wouldn't be able to pronounce the word even if she wasn't tipsy. "Well, see? I think it's best if I stay right here," she laughs.

As she waits, Adora absently scans the now-familiar room and picks up a book from the coffee table. She lies on the sofa and skims through the pages, cuddled with a sleeping Melog, smiling when she realizes that she can already recognize some of the words, although she doesn't understand full sentences.

"Okay." Catra says when she comes back, after no more than a minute. "But you have to *promise* me you're not gonna laugh."

“Laugh about what?” Looking away from the book, Adora glances in Catra’s direction and her eyes go wide with surprise.

Instead of a package, Catra has the guitar in her hands. The rush of serotonin and adrenaline causes any trace of alcohol to evaporate from Adora's blood in that instant, and she sits up, feeling incredibly honored. “Oh. Oh, *of* course I wont laugh! How can you even think that I would –” she begins to protest, but Catra cuts her off.

“Yeah, yeah, I hear you, dummy, now just… Shut up before I change my mind, will ya?” Guitar in hand, Catra sits in the armchair in front of the sofa, gazing at the floor with an awkward smile. “Alright. Here it goes.”

The melody is unfamiliar to Adora's ears, but it's bittersweet and mellow and a little romantic, unlike most songs Catra had ever shown her. The lyrics, however, have everything to do with her. They talk about the uncertainties of the future and the downfalls of the present, but also about a special person who makes it all worthwhile.



Adora's chest is overloaded with emotion as she hears Catra's husky voice hit the notes accompanied by the beautiful chords she's strumming on the guitar. *"And even though I meet trouble each and every corner with nothing but disaster... I set my chin a little higher , I hope a little longer, build a little stronger castle in the air... And thinking youll be there, I walka little faster ."*

The song ends, and Adora has to make an effort not to cry, taken by a wave of urgent tenderness. Catra is staring at her fondly, a soft blush covering her freckled cheeks, and Adora feels like all the freaking stars standing up above them are her witnesses, that anyone with a working pair of eyes is able to see it written in her

smile, in her eyes, in her face. She's known this for some time, but each new realization hits her like lightning all over again.

She'd never been more in love in her whole damn life.

And she would give anything to live this love to the fullest.

*

8:45 AM

The blue screen of death flashes on the monitor. Perfect. Great timing for Netossa's computer to crash, right when she was in the middle of a manuscript reading. Now she's going to have to take her notes all over again. While waiting for the useless piece of junk to restart, she pulls out her cell phone to complain to Spinny about how she warned her that the IT repair company they hired was half-assed. She is frustrated, but maybe telling her wife a good old-fashioned "I told you so" will lift her mood.

When taking a look at the cell phone screen, however, she comes across an unexpected message.

"Hey, hot stuff. How is my favorite person in the publishing business doing these days? ;)"

Netossa scoffs indignantly. The last time they spoke, this sleazy opportunist used Wind Chime's contacts as a bargaining chip to snatch a position in a big company in the entertainment business. Why would they be looking for her after so many years?

With a smirk, she realizes there can only be one reason: Netossa must have something they need.

"I'm doing fantastic." Which is in no way thanks to them. "And to what do I owe this not so pleasant —" Netossa thinks it over, decides to play nice. "And to what do I owe this surprise?"

While her cell phone doesn't beep again, Netossa texts Spinny, not to complain about the broken computer, but to send her a screenshot of the conversation accompanied by a "look what the cat dragged in." When she's done sending the message, her cell phone buzzes.

"Always straight to the point, aren't we? But love that about you ;) Anyway, I was wondering if you could give me the scoop on that intriguing halfmoonian new writer of yours. See, a little birdie told me her novel is going to be on the next Interian Chronicler bestseller list, and the big boss is very interested. So tell me, love: is she a fun player? Any skeletons in that sapphic closet I should know about? Spare no detail!"

Well well. It looks like the tables have turned, didn't they? Luckily for them, Netossa doesn't hold a grudge when it comes to business opportunities - and being aware of where they work, she knows that message could spell a *hell* of a deal for both Wind Chime and perhaps especially for Catra.

She stretches her fingers and places both feet on the desk. "I guess I could tell you, but that depends on what exactly you want with her."

Thisrose is typing…

Netossa rolls her eyes, noting how appropriate her two-faced interlocutor's nickname is, and then their next message arrives.

"No need to be suspicious, darling, I promise you it's good. We really liked her material and we think it can work for us. You know how much we love a good sci-fi niched romance. I sent you a draft proposal by email. Scrutinize it as much as you like. My way of making amends for our past disagreements ;)"

More and more interesting. Once the computer restarts, Netossa takes a look at the document in question. She can ask the legal department to check for loopholes, but the proposal is solid and is certainly an amazing deal for Catra. "Looks good at first glance. I can set up a meeting between you when she's here for the book tour."

“Terrific. And while we are at it, do you have any tips? Surely my content-starved competitors will go crazy after this one, and I can't have another Mr. -mysteries fiasco in my hands, so I'd love to have some kind of leverage. I'd owe you a big favor.”

The owner of Wind Chime Publishings smiles, knowing that this is a situation that can greatly benefit everyone involved. She remembers the most recent messages she'd exchanged with Catra, in which the novelist made clear her interest in moving to Etheria as soon as a concrete opportunity came along – not just for career purposes, but certainly to be able to be with that sweet girlfriend of hers.

She fondly remembers the loving look in their eyes when they were having lunch, all those months ago. In many ways, they remind her of when she and Spinerella met and began to fall in love, such different personalities finding partnership in each other. The editor’s soft-hearted side can't resist giving the couple a gentle nudge.

Besides, in the entertainment business, it's always nice to have someone owe you a favor.

“Well. There is one thing that I think would make the proposal more attractive.”

00 AM

Amidst the cheering crowd and the roar of fireworks, the music rises again, but Catra hardly registers it. Raindrops begin to fall on her shoulders, people around them are dancing and jumping excitedly enough to cause a few accidental bumps, and none of that bothers her. The pressure of Adora's hands on her hips, the taste of Adora's lips and tongue against her own, and the softness of Adora’s chin under her fingers make up for any inconvenience.

Everything about this moment is worth savoring, every stimulus, every sensation vibrating through Catra’s skin. The sounds, the beat that compels her to dance, the cold rainwater on her warm skin, the breeze, the heat of Adora's body, the ever-so-magnetic attraction

between them, the combined rhythm of limbs and mouths so passionate, so hungry for each other.

And that fire in her lower abdomen, that raw desire willing to consume and destroy everything in its path just so she and Adora can keep touching, is burning wilder than ever.

While a part of her feels like she'll never be satisfied if she's not inside Adora, another part is perfectly content. The world could end here and now, existence could be obliterated, and Catra would be fine with it. Dramatic as it sounds, she realizes that she doesnt need much more in her life than this: this sense of presence, this feeling of being connected to everything and nothing at the same time, this thing that makes her existence seem important.

Well, damn.

I guess that's the thing that romantic idiots talk about so much. A kind of silly happiness that makes everything seem less important. Never in her wildest dreams had Catra imagined she would become one of those fools, but *fuck* - she gets it now. She really gets it. For a long time, she thought that giving in to that kind of feeling would be a sign of weakness, but for the past few days, she's been feeling the exact opposite of weak. It's not about *depending* on someone, as she discovers, but about feeling part of something bigger, greater than herself.

She's still somewhat afraid to surrender completely. Afraid of making a mistake and walking out of this romantic comedy trope with nothing but a broken heart. Can't really blame her - with the mother she has, Catra grew up suspicious of any good things that came her way. Maybe that's why she still hasn't told Adora about her plans to move to Etheria, or why she still hasn't been able to say that she loves her. Every instinct in her body tells her she can trust Adora blindfolded - and she happens to know this quite literally - but a part of her doesn't fully believe that she deserves a happy ending.

But over the past month, she'd begun to allow herself to enjoy that sensation, to get comfortable with it, to seek it out instead of pushing it away. It's been a remarkable and wonderful experience, in the sense that for the first time, it feels right. Love feels right.

"Happy new year," Adora says with her eyes still shut, her voice especially sweet.

Catra clenches a fist into Adora's hair, her knuckles pressing lightly against her scalp as she leans forward to kiss the raindrops from the other woman's eyelids. The height difference between the two of them forces her to stand on her tiptoes, and her lips crack into an awkward grin.

"Happy new year, dummy," she responds.

Blue eyes open to meet her gaze, colored flashes of fireworks sparkling inside them. Adora looks up, a dopey wide smile playing on her lips as she admires the light spectacle above them; the old lighthouse behind her illuminates the sparse raindrops that quietly fall on the beach and on the sea ahead.

A strong, ridiculous urge to say *I love you* pounds in Catra's gut, scratching her throat, itching to break free.

Though the actual words won't come out, she makes a point of kissing Adora again, hoping her body can express what verbal language still can not.

"Oh!" Adora says when their mouths part, and she looks as if she had been just reminded of something. "I guess it's time for those waves!" She says with an overexcited gleam in her eyes, pulling Catra by the hand like a child.

Catra rolls her eyes, biting back a grin. Thanks to Scorpia and an extensive research session, Adora has spent the day entertaining herself with all of Halfmoon's nonsensical New Year's traditions, and jumping through seven waves when the clock strikes midnight will be

her last. While superstitious bullshit is not exactly Catra's idea of fun, the smile on her girlfriend's face when she’s having a good time is more than enough reason to accompany her on all of those silly missions.

As far as Catra’s imagination goes, she cant think of a better way to start another year.

9:56 AM

Time is a very strange thing. The last twenty days passed in a wonderful blur, but every minute spent in that short period was better spent than anything Catra has ever done in her life. Having Adora keep her company while she worked, seeing Melog cuddling with her, watching television, eating meals together, dancing, going to the beach, introducing her to her friends. Like the week she had spent on Etheria, this vacation was a taste of what their lives could be if their geographic circumstances were different. Now that they're packing up to head out to Bright Moon together, Catra's heart feels small because she knows that once the book tour is over, they'll have to part ways again, even if momentarily.

She is sorting out her warm clothes while Adora stuffs her favorite local foods into her suitcase. Catra takes a moment to stare at her fondly. Her hair is messy, her eyes are tired, her shoulders are peeling from the excessive sun, and Catra realizes that she finds her even more beautiful in those moments in which she looks like a real person.

Catra’s eyes dart to Adora's suitcase. "Not that I'm shaming you or anything, but is that all for you?" She smirks at the amount of cake Adora is bringing back home.

"What? No, of course not," the blonde frowns and gestures dismissively. "See, there’s one for Bow and Glimmer, one is for my aunt Razz," she explains, pointing to the treats already inside the suitcase. "And *heh*, well, the other ones are for me. For us, I mean, you can have a slice too, if you want."

"Always so generous." Catra scoffs ironically, being rewarded with a playful elbow to the waist while going back to folding her black leather jacket. "Though I'm afraid they'll arrest you at customs. Transporting that amount of food's gotta be illegal."

With a glance at Catra's luggage, Adora counters. "Oh, yeah? Then you're going down with me because I don't think they will approve of animal smuggling either."

Looking back at her suitcase on the coffee table, Catra notices that Melog has crept inside and is and is carelessly lying on top of her already organized clothes.

"Perfect. Like I don't already have enough cat hair on my clothes or whatever."

"Maybe they want to go along with us," Adora giggles, making her way to the bathroom in search of her toothbrush.

For a brief moment, Catra is alone in the living room, and she looks at the apartment as if saying goodbye.

Her things, her furniture, her plants. Her copy of *Ember*, the product of her efforts solidified into paper and hardcover. She picks it up and thinks of all the times she's received a rejection letter, all the times she had to start over, all the times her mother hinted that she would never be able to build a life for herself without her so-called help. "Don't come running to me when this adventure of yours goes wrong," her mother had said to her on Christmas.

The thought of needing to ask her mother for anything makes Catra shudder, so she's doing her best to never have to.

She has done the math for how much she would need to permanently move to Etheria, and despite being a lot of money, the prospects are good. Her book is getting rave reviews and sold very well in the first week; her words are flowing and she is in advanced negotiations with Netossa to seal another deal with Wind Chime -

perhaps for more than one book. Although that won't necessarily give her everything she needs to apply for a migrant visa, she feels that she's *so fucking close* to finally getting where she wants to be.

Where she truly belongs.

Then Adora laughs, that delicious laugh that always catches Catra's attention, and she puts her arms around Catra to kiss her neck. "Admiring your own masterpiece?" She asks with a playful smile.

"Yeah, I'm... I guess I'm still getting used to it." When Catra looks back at her girlfriend, she sees the one person who has been by her side - virtually or physically - during some of the best and worst moments of her life these past few years. The person who makes her heart go warm and sets her soul at ease, the person who makes her feel soft and powerful, all at once. Her strength, her weakness; her tether, and her lighthouse.

And with that, Catra realizes that she desperately needs to say what she's been harboring all this time.

"Hey, Adora." She starts somewhat hesitantly, rubbing the back of the neck and taking another look at her living room, then placing the book back where it was. "I know we're still going to spend like a week together in Bright Moon, but I've been meaning to talk to you, about... What happens from now on. With us."

"You have?" Adora looks at her, carefully studying her expression. From the way she's fidgeting her fingers, Catra knows she's made her anxious, so she covers Adora's hand with her own.

"Yeah." Feeling a little bit braver, Catra looks over her shoulder to stare at her eyes. "I've been thinking a lot about how we can come up with a solution that works for both of us. A more permanent solution."

"Oh." Adora's face lights up. She takes a step back and starts pacing the room. "You know, it's funny you should mention that, because…

Uh, I think I may have an idea."

Somewhat surprised, Catra frowns and sits on the couch. "You do?"

"Yeah, I've been thinking a lot the last few days, about how much I loved coming here, and seeing the city you live in, and feeling like I lived here for a while, and... Well, I thought..." She holds her hair in a ponytail and tugs it sharply before releasing it. Closing her eyes, she lets out a very long breath. "Catra, you are very, *very* special to me. And it's really hard to think that we're going to have to say goodbye again."

"Couldn't agree more," Catra replies with a reserved smile. "Goodbye sounds fucking impossible to me, to be completely honest," she confesses, and Adora grins warmly.

"So this may sound a little crazy, but I thought I could..." Adora goes back to wandering the room, not looking directly at Catra. "I-I could take a break from the Pet Zone and come here to spend more time than just a vacation. Like, much more time. Like for a few months maybe, or -or until my tourist visa expires. And by then... Well, by then, if everything continued to work out between us, if we were still together... M-maybe I could look for something more permanent," Adora stops and stands in front of Catra. "Here."

Transfixed by what she's just heard, Catra sinks further into the sofa.

"You mean you would... Would you really do that for me?" She mutters, trying to process what Adora's just offered.

Adora smiles radiantly. "Yeah, I would."

Catra's mind is spinning in denial. "Shit, Adora, you can't be serious."

"Uh... I am," Adora says with a foolish grin, sounding a little more hesitant now. "Wait, are you freaking out because you're surprised or

because you didn't like the idea? I.. kind of cant read your tone right now, *heh*."

"Oh, Adora." Catra shakes her head in utter disbelief, then buries her head in her hands, chuckling softly. "You really are unreal, did you know that?"

"I did say it was crazy," she scoffs defensively.

"It's not only insane, Adora, it's... Well, it's just like you, isn't it? Sacrificing everything that's yours for someone else, no matter the consequences. But I won't let you do that, because... Well, because your idea is very stupid." Catra blurts out without thinking too much, then she sees the disappointment in those steel-blue eyes. "Sorry, you know me well enough to know I didn't mean it as an insult."

"Oh?" Adora interjects, crossing her arms under her breasts, doubt rising in her gaze. "And how *do* you mean it, then?"

Catra takes a few breaths to gather her thoughts. Here she was, unsure about a decision that she knows could *give* her everything she's ever wanted for her life, while Adora is willing to *lose* everything she has for her.

She feels foolish - so, so foolish - for being afraid.

On the other hand, the significance of Adora's offer also makes Catra feel incredibly appreciated. Safe. Safe enough to take the final plunge, without looking back.

"Look, it's *amazing* that you're even suggesting this, don't get me wrong." Catra does her best to keep her tone steady, but as her hands begin to shake, her voice unravels. "But you can't really mean that you would give up a job that you *love*, a career you excel at, give up being close to your family and your friends, risk bringing your dog with a heart condition on an international trip - or worse, fucking leaving him behind... to live in a country where you don't know the language, where your license is not recognized and where probably

your best short-term chance would be teaching English to teenagers."

Silence hangs in the room for a few instants, Adora stares at the floor. "Yeah, when you put it *that* way, I understand why it sounds dumb, but"…

Catra rises from the sofa and takes her hands, searching for her eyes.

"It's the sweetest thing anyone has ever offered me, Adora. But I would *never* let you throw everything away like that," Catra says in a low voice, almost whispering, stroking Adora's cheek while firmly holding her gaze. "See… I love you too fucking much for that, dummy."

The words slide out of Catra's mouth, and it feels as if a weight had been lifted from her shoulders, as if the natural order of things had been restored. She watches Adora's eyes fluttering, the small gasp she swallows, her mouth open in surprise, and she is instantly glad she was able to say those words while they were standing face to face.

She studies Adora's expression as she processes the new information, and falls in love with her all over again when a smile breaks out on her face.

"Love is the reason why I even came up with this lame plan in the first place," she declares with teary eyes. "I love you, too."

With those words, they eliminate the distance between their mouths. As the kiss lingers, Catra's skin is set on fire - not with desire, but with the certainty of having done the right thing. She pulls Adora closer in a tender embrace.

"It *was* a lame idea, but thank you for having it." Catra smiles against Adora's lips, acknowledging in silence that the offer was the final nudge she needed to come clean about her own feelings. "We both

know that the option that makes the most sense is for *me* to be the one who moves. I can do my job from anywhere in the world, my publisher is there, I wouldn't need to learn a whole language from scratch."

"Rationally , I think I know that. But it's also such a huge change. I could never ask this of you, so"…

"Well, but see, this is what I wanted to tell you to begin with." Catra takes a delicate finger to Adora's lips, caressing her mouth gently. "You don't have to ask me anything. I've been planning to move to Etheria for a few months now. I just didn't have anything concrete to tell you yet, and I was…Scared of making it real and creating expectations and screwing everything up or whatever."

Adora laughs in Catra's arms, muttering something about the two of them being lesbian disasters. "And *Im* the paranoid one who always thinks of the worst-case scenario."

"You totally are," Catra teases. "But you're not afraid to take the leap anyway," she smiles softly . "And for that, I love you even more."

With a smug expression, Adora smiles. "Soooo, does that mean you're in love with a *princess*? How's that for your brand?"

"Yeah, I don't really care about that," as if her mouth was moving of its own volition, she pulls Adora in for another kiss, allowing it to become steamier.

What follows happens very quickly . Before Catra realizes it, she is pressed against the living room wall, Adora is eagerly kissing her neck, her mouth;her hands are firm on Catra' s hips, one knee between Catra's legs. The strong emotions the two shared that afternoon shift to desire, and then to bliss.

After a few orgasms and another "I love you" later , the two go back to preparing for the impending trip, and Catra explains her plans, which should become clearer once she reunites with Netossa in

Bright Moon. Now that everything is out in the open, Adora is incredibly excited, and so is Catra.

On their way to the airport, Catra receives a message from Netossa, wishing her a safe flight, and signing with an enigmatic postscript. *“Make sure you keep your schedule flexible while you’re here, I have someone to introduce you to. I can’t say much, but this could be the opportunity you’ve been looking for ;)”*

Catra will have to wait a few long hours to find out what the meeting is about, but in her heart, there is no room for fear anymore.

Chapter End Notes

I'd like to thank everyone who's helped me and supported me while writing this!

Also check out the Amazing fan art commissioned to EmileeDoodles by machabubblecat!Thank you so much!It looks gorgeous!

References:

The song Catra sings to Adora: Fiona Apple - I walk A Little Faster
The drink Adora has shots is cachaça - yes, I'm a ridiculous Brazilian who is obviously basing Dovale in my own hometown.

Thank you for reading!

Home

Chapter Summary

The final chapter is here :)

Chapter Notes

Hello :) I know it's been a while.

I personally don't like taking long between updates, but multiple factors have contributed to this delay - life has been seriously kicking my ass lately. Nevertheless, I am proud to deliver the final chapter of this story, and I have to admit I'm having a hard time saying goodbye to it.

I will be back as soon as possible :)

I really hope you enjoy this last chapter - it took me a very long while to feel satisfied with it. I'm very moved by the positive feedback this story has received, and I'm glad it touched you in some way. Hopefully, you'll leave your thoughts when you're done reading :)

Enjoy the chapter!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

9:14 AM

It is with a frustrated sob that Adora admits there is no way out of the mess she's made for herself. A clusterfuck, alright, but far worse than she could ever have imagined. It's so sad. After she's fought so hard and sacrificed so much... I mean, of course she knew the stakes were high, but she didn't expect to lose almost *everything* she's worked for.

"I can't believe you did this"—she starts typing but ends up erasing the whole message. What's done is done, there's no point in crying about it.

Really, though, how did she not see this coming? How could she be so stupid, so naive? For a moment there, she actually believed she could. Oh, you know what, forget it. She only has herself to blame for allowing herself to be so easily manipulated.

And now, what's even left for her to do? Grumbling nervously , Adora gets up from the chair and starts walking in small circles to try to get a different perspective. Her eyes wander aimlessly around her bedroom walls as she tries to decide her next course of action.

But in her heart, she knows she's only delaying the inevitable.

"oh, adora"... The notification sound of a new message draws her attention back to the computer screen. *"how long will you drag this out?"*

Inconsolable, Adora sits down again, exhaling sharply, as her defeat seems imminent. She hates surrendering, hates giving up, but at the moment it seems like the only viable option. If anything, it would be a way to cut her losses.

She is about to press the key that will decree her tragic failure when something on the screen catches her eye.

An idea occurs. Adora's fingers freeze in midair, hovering over the keyboard as she studies the options before her. There is a possibility there, yes. It's a long shot at best - and if it backfires again, the damage will be irreparable. But if it works, it might turn the tables in her favor, once and for all.

Hell, screw it. She-Ra isn't one to surrender! With a quick flick of the keyboard, Adora commands the remaining rebel troops into the heart of the Horde empire, attacking with whatever is left of her arsenal.

“this is getting pathetic, princess,” a new message pops up. “*you cant seriously believe this desperate stunt will work. not after i made u sacrifice your queen.”*

Adora smirks. If Catra is going to the trouble of trying to dissuade her from continuing the match, it's because she knows there's still a chance for her to win.

"If that's the case, it will be over in a minute. No reason for you to worry, right?" She replies while waiting for her opponent's next move. "Or...is...there? 😉😉"

“oh please. just dont want to see you embarrass yourself anymore than you already have.” The message may have no sound, but Adora can practically hear Catra's snarky tone. She smiles lovingly, but then remembers that they are in the middle of a life-and-death dispute. *“trust me, surrendering is a favor you'd be doing to ur reputation...assuming u have one ;)”*

Adora snorts, competitiveness filling her with renewed energy. She tugs at her own ponytail to get her blood flowing, then goes back to the keyboard.

"Reputation or not, I refuse to go down without a fight," she types confidently. "Hit me with your best shot, ForceCaptain! I'll show you what I'm made of!"

“haha, i wish i was there to see the ridiculous heroine face u must be making.” The game begins to update, but it would take a few moments for Catra's latest move to be concluded. *"ok, shera. you asked for it."*

Barely blinking, Adora nervously nibbles her thumbnail while waiting for the screen to refresh. The tension hangs in the air until the end of her opponent's turn, a few minutes later.

When it’s over, Adora sighs in relief. "Sorry , Catra," she mutters to herself, seeing that her girlfriend has taken her bait. "But all is fair in

love and war."

As Adora hoped, her surprise attack forces all Horde armies to retreat from their positions to protect their main stronghold, the Velvet Glove. They retaliate in full force, likely believing this to be the rebellion's last hurrah - which is exactly what Adora counted on. While Catra's troops are busy in the battle, Adora teleports one of her princesses into the fortress's server room, where she activates a failsafe mechanism that neutralizes their defenses and releases all rebel prisoners in their custody.

"fuck" By the time the Horde officer realizes Adora's strategy, it's too late to stop it: the rebellion's army has more than tripled in size. *"this is bullshit."*

"Not so pathetic now , am I?" A cheeky expression covers Adora's face as if she's had the match under her full control at all times. "It was fun distracting you though! 😉"

After a few more rounds, the princess alliance flag is raised on the Velvet Glove's walls, indicating that She-Ra has won this match. With this victory, Adora reached the same amount of points as Catra in the dispute for first place in the yearly *Escape to Despondos* championship.

"Whoooo, oh yeah!" Adora cries out, throwing her arms up, unable to contain her pride. "Another win for the rebellion, *heh*," she cheers to herself. Her heart is still pounding with excitement when Catra's next message arrives.

"...unfuckingbelievable."

Adora giggles, shaking her hips in the chair in a happy dance. "Come on, even you have to admit that was absolutely STELLAR! And you were awesome, of course," after all, she was very close to winning the match and securing the championship lead. "But it takes more than awesome to beat this princess 😘"

“whatever .” Another text appears immediately afterward. *“this game is fucking rigged .”*

“Oh it’ s not rigged,” Adora smugly cracks her knuckles. “I’m just too damn good at it 😉,” she types, winking and shooting finger guns at the computer after sending the message as if Catra could see her through the screen.

Force Captain is typing…

Basked in virtual glory, Adora is glaring at the screen when her girlfriend's real voice snaps her back to reality.

“You know.” She turns to find Catra, wearing nothing but the plaid flannel shirt that used to be Adora’s, nonchalantly leaning against the bedroom door, one leg crossed over the other. “If I had any idea of just how *dumb* you look whenever you beat me, I think I would let you win more often,” she concludes with a lopsided grin, crossing her arms in front of her chest. “I am not a fan of getting my ass kicked, but I have to say that this cocky, overconfident version of you is… honestly , it’s kind of a turn-on.”

Heat rushes to Adora's cheeks; her heart pounds in her chest.

It’s interesting. Adora has grown so used to the distance between them that she still gets fascinated by Catra's physical presence, as if she had forgotten for a second that Catra was really there with her, and marvels at it all over again. No matter how many times they meet, being together in the same room still feels like the first time they exchanged pictures, sounds, writings, fragments of their materiality, back when Adora would get so excited to confirm that Catra was a real person. Part of Adora still finds it all too extraordinary to believe, still finds Catra too extraordinary for her world.

In a way, she hopes this feeling never passes.

"Oh really? I shall make a note of that," she grins, turning the chair towards Catra.

"Well. Yeah." Rolling her eyes like the stubborn brat she is, the other woman draws aimless patterns on the door, running a finger up and down the wooden surface. "In a *very* annoying way, that is," she smirks.

"Sooo." Adora's expression becomes smug again. "Does that mean I get my prize?" She raises an inviting eyebrow.

At the question, Catra hoots with laughter. "First I'd like to reiterate my protest and state to the record that this shitty game is obviously rigged. But of course, I *am* a woman of my word."

With a tight-lipped smile, Catra makes her way to Adora, hips swaying, the partially unbuttoned flannel shirt dancing gracefully across her skin. As she watches, Adora holds her breath as if the air has been taken hostage by that powerful stare. Desire tugs at her stomach at every occasional flash of Catra's breasts, abs and thighs, and she purses her lips as she imagines herself licking each of those delicious parts.

Her thoughts must be showing because Catra is now cackling and putting a finger in the middle of her forehead, her knees just inches from the seat of the chair.

"Oh Adora, the way you are looking at me now." Catra's finger slides down to cup the seated woman's chin. She slightly lifts Adora's head. "Like I could do whatever I wanted to you and you would enjoy it." One of Catra's knees sneaks up onto the chair and settles between Adora's thighs. "Makes me wonder who's the *real* winner here."

There's no need to protest, no need to argue. Adora just laughs, as she knows her girlfriend's remark is true. She may have been reluctant to surrender to Catra during the game, but she won't offer any resistance to it now.

"I'd say we both are," she replies, bringing her hands to Catra's thighs, holding them tightly as she holds her gaze. "I love you, Catra," she smiles fondly , still not used to the freedom of being able to say those words. "So, so much."

"Love you too," leaning in, Catra closes the distance between their mouths. "Dummy ."

(POV - POV)

When Adora met Catra, as contenders in that same video game, she could never have dreamed that one day they would be playing against each other not from distant countries or incompatible timezones, but from different rooms in the same apartment. She also would have laughed if someone had told her that one day the winner would be celebrating her victory with a long, hot kiss from the loser.

And yet, here they are.

This isn't the first time they've had this opportunity, of course, you probably remember that they had already played Despondos together during their previous visits to each other's cities. But there's something special about this particular triumph: it seals the end of a chapter in their relationship, and the beginning of a new one.

You see, as amazing as those past encounters were, they also led to their imminent and inevitable geographic separation. For Adora, meeting Catra also meant preparing to say goodbye to her, preparing to go months without seeing her. That awful countdown would always be ticking in the back of her head, reminding her that their joy was temporary and soon it would be time for one of them to leave.

This time, however, there's no countdown. No deadline, no return ticket, no expiration date.

Catra is in Etheria to stay.

Indefinitely.

The credit for this great achievement belongs entirely to the novelist. As it turns out, Catra has as much talent for strategy as for fiction, and it's no wonder she's such a great Despondos player. While Adora considered sacrificing her career to move to a different country without really thinking it through - and if it all came down to it, she would have done it in a heartbeat - Catra was putting her skills to good use and bringing a more sustainable plan to life. Unbeknownst to Adora, she had spent months leading up to *Ember's* book tour working to diversify her source of income, raise extra cash, submit new manuscripts, and strengthen her professional network in Etheria.

Then when January came, her efforts began to pay off.

Our lesbian lovebirds had barely gotten off the plane in Bright Moon when Catra received a call from Netossa, telling her that *Ember* had made it to the Etherian Chronicler best-seller list. It was a huge deal, of course. Getting on that list is the goal of any fiction author aiming for international success, and the quickest way for a newcomer to get on the press's radar. It was Catra's dream, and she had just fulfilled it.

While Catra talked to her editor, Adora watched her girlfriend's expression and body language change. She saw her hands shaking as she tried to keep her voice steady, saw her different colored eyes filling up with tears of joy, and the adorable grin that lit up her freckled face. Adora still remembers the peace and relief she felt when she saw that smile, and she remembers thinking that she would do anything to never have to spend a day without it.

People at AirWorthy International Airport weren't ready for Adora's reaction when Catra told her the news - and frankly, neither was Catra.

The writer was caught off guard when Adora dipped her for a lingering kiss;and she would have lost her balance if not for the

blonde's arm, strong around her waist. Much later they would learn that the iconic moment had been filmed and gone viral on HW e. The trend has since inspired countless other qeer couples to dip kiss in public places. Good for them.

"So tell me, *best-sellerrrr*," Adora rolled her tongue, purposely dragging out the syllables to force a snobbish accent. "What' s it like to be on top?"

"As if I didn't already know ," Catra snickered wryly , getting to her feet without breaking from Adora's embrace. "But it's really fucking awesome, Ill tell you that."

That day would go down in Adora's memory as one of the best of her life. It was the day they both felt that anything was possible, the day they were sure that, somehow, they were going to win in the end. The celebration was filled with champagne, music, great food, and lots, *lots* of passionate lovemaking.

But even better news awaited them.

That same week, at the book launch cocktail party, Catra got an e-mail from the Triple MaJOr , one of the most coveted awards in qeer literature, informing her that she would be nominated for three categories: Outstanding New Author, Most Shippable Ship, and Best Sci-Fi Novel. Other important awards - such as the Scholars' Honor and the Creative Flex - had yet to announce their nominees, but Spinerella and Netossa were confident that *Remember* would make those shortlists as well.

Needless to say, the honor was unprecedented. Never had Adora seen her girlfriend so ecstatic, so elated. Catra usually has a more reserved and cool demeanor, but that night she let her excitement show clearly, freely, so beautifully that Adora fell in love with her all over again each time their eyes met, each time she saw the corner of Catra's lip curl up in pride.

That was also the night Adora realized that the line of fangirls trying to get Catra's attention no longer made her feel anxious, afraid, or insecure. She knew where they stood, knew where they were headed, and there was no doubt in her mind that whatever future they were going to have, they would be paving it together.

The flirtatious looks from Catra's admirers now caused an entirely different reaction on Adora's more competitive side: her ego swelled with pride at being the person Catra was actually with. "This is my girlfriend, Adora," Catra would say , and the young veterinarian would beam smugly, her chest puffed out as if she were sporting a medal.

"Yep, *heh,* that's *me*. Hey there," she would snigger with her chin held high, waving a hand casually before bringing it to her hip. "Are you enjoying the festivities?"

On the dance floor that night, Catra teased. "Feeling good about yourself, aren't you, princess?"

"Well, can you blame me?" Adora replied, hooking her fingers into Catra's belt loops to pull her closer, their hips aligned and moving together to the beat of the music. "I'm so proud of you, Catra. And to be able to be here, sharing this great thing with you. It's like I have won an award of my own."

At the confession, Catra's gaze softened. "I'm lucky to have you, dummy," she replied somewhat modestly , tucking her chin into Adora's shoulder, bringing their bodies closer together. "Hold on, isn't that Swifty's walker or like...Sitter or whatever?"

Adora glanced behind her and confirmed that Kyle was indeed there, along with his boyfriend Rogelio. They were talking to a girl who Adora recognized as the book tour's event planner. "Oh yeah, you're right!" The three of them seemed intimate and affectionate. "Huh. Small world!"

After that night, the rest of Catra's stay in Bright Moon passed in a rapturous whirlwind.

Press interest in her work opened up new opportunities, and she was able to masterfully capitalize on the momentum. Among her accomplishments, she landed a contract for two more books with Wind Chime and signed deals to have her novels available in other languages and countries.

None of these achievements were unexpected - not for Adora, at least. Knowing Catra's talent, drive, and determination, Adora had never doubted that she would thrive in the right setting and circumstances. In her not at all impartial opinion, the recognition Catra was receiving was overdue, considering all the time and energy she invested in her career.

But even so, the offer that would determine her girlfriend's permanent change of address came as a genuine surprise.

It was the day before Catra's trip back to Halfmoon. She'd been out for brunch with a bigshot producer who goes by "D.T.," one of the several meetings that Netossa had arranged for her during the book tour. Catra didn't go into much detail, but from the excited gleam in her eyes, Adora could tell there was something special about that meeting.

Adora was waiting for her next patient at the Pet Zone when she heard her computer's notification sound.

"so"... The first text said, and it wasn't long before the next one arrived. "*crystal castle wants to acquire the rights to adapt remember into a fucking miniseries."*

Ah. Sure, *heh*, okay. Whoa, I mean, what?! The vet had to read the sentence several times to make sure she got it right.

And then she had to make a huge effort not to scream.

"WHAT?!" was her first reflexive reply. "CATRA OMFFFFFFFG are you serious?!" She asked next, followed by "

 ,"which was the way she found to accurately describe her state of mind at that moment.

"i know , right? :)" Catra answered a few seconds later. *"i cant believe this is seriously happening."*

Oh, but it was seriously happening, alright.

In fact, it was *so seriously* happening that by the end of that same day, Catra would still be courted by two other streaming companies with similar proposals - Prime Vision and Flix Portal. But it was Crystal Castle who made Catra the one offer she couldn't refuse: a role as executive producer, which in turn would require her to reside in Bright Moon for the duration of the show's production. As Crystal Castle is the only one of the three companies that also has offices in Halfmoon, Catra's hiring and the subsequent intra-company transfer would make her eligible to apply for a permanent visa in Etheria.

It was the easiest decision Catra has ever made in her life and, by extension, the best news Adora could have received.

When they said goodbye to each other the next day, the pain of separation was overshadowed by the concrete prospect of a future without all that distance. Catra would be back in Etheria soon - and when she returned, it would be for good. The farewell was tearful, but also sweet, for they knew it would be their last.

"See ya, princess," Catra vowed with a wink before walking through the boarding gate.

"Soon," Adora grinned lovingly , blowing a kiss her way.

Having companies fighting over the rights to adapt her work further reiterated Catra's confidence in building a life away from her hometown. After all, it's not every day that you can afford to turn down bids like the ones she had received.

"I think I'll ask Bow to make me a t-shirt that says something like 'My girlfriend is so powerful she snubbed an offer from Prime Vision' 😎😎"Adora gloated after Catra gave her final response, already back in Halfmoon.

"and dont u forget it." Catra boasted, and Adora giggled on her side of the screen. *"good thing i dont have to take money from that scumbag,"* she remarked, referring to Prime's CEO, one of those billionaire tycoons known for making their fortune by avoiding taxes and exploiting their workers. *"i should send my editor a thankyou gift for that*," she added in conclusion, as she knew Netossa had played an active role in the negotiations with D.T., supplying them with the smoking gun that would seal their deal and helping them through all the bureaucracy.

"Oh I've already made it my life mission to find the perfect gift for her 🎁 "On a not-so-relevant side note, Adora was so committed to this cause that she even considered letting Netossa and Spinerella win game night the next time she and Catra were invited - but as grateful as she is, losing a game on purpose is a line she would never dare to cross. She *has* her principles, after all. "Netossa's into sports, right? Do you think she would like a pair of tickets to the kingdoms league finals? Or maybe dinner reservations at yoursfemmely… 😉"

"yeah, i guess. though i was thinking more like a shibari rope kit or something."

While the controversy surrounding Netossa's gift has yet to be resolved, Catra's contract with Crystal Castle was signed on May 15th. The company has since applied for her work visa in Etheria and the series' pre-production phase was set to begin on July 7, while Catra's ticket was purchased for mid-June. During her adaptation period in the city, they would provide Catra with an apartment in Thaymor, the artists' district, about ten blocks from Adora's place. The streaming service would also be paying for her

living expenses until she receives her first paycheck in Etherian currency.

Once the paperwork was fully taken care of, all that remained was to wait. Not that waiting is an easy task, especially for an anxious soul like Adora, but having something tangible to look forward to made the process much more bearable.

And now that she no longer had to worry about working extra shifts and saving money for periodic international travel, Adora found room for a new, more personal plan. She spent those months preparing and sending applications for doctoral programs with an emphasis on wildlife health. A career shift, she knows, but her experience with unconventional pets like Lizzie, the Chinese water dragon, led her to discover a passion for exotic animals as well as endangered species.

“very cool,” Catra commented after Adora sent her a series of links to graduate programs at nearby institutions. *“though if i had to guess, id say youd choose to specialize in horses.”*

Chuckling, Adora took a brief glance at her horse-patterned pajamas. "That was the original plan lol. I promise my love for horses remains intact 🐎 But the thought of treating wildlife is soooo exciting! I feel I can really make a dif ference there."

“well princess, you know i fully support anything that turns you on.”

“♡🔥♡🔥♡🔥”The corner of Adora's lip twitched; anticipation for Catra's definitive arrival pounding hard in her chest. "And since we're on the subject of things that turn me on… 😉 have I told you how much I can't wait for June?"

“not for the last 5minutes or so)” Adora could practically hear Catra's sarcastic laugh. *“hang in there, dummy. june will come. and then so will you. over and over again.”*

Before they knew it, June came, bringing Catra along with it.

It had crossed Adora's mind to suggest that Catra spend the adaptation period in her apartment, but she preferred to roll with what she had been given, as Glimmer once advised, trusting that things would happen when they were both ready. It had always been that way between them, after all: from affinity to friendship, from attraction to mutual declarations of love, their relationship had changed and progressed exactly when it should. There's no need to rush it now.

Besides, after so much time dating from separate continents, Adora figures a ten-block distance is just *perfect*.

And considering they have been spending every night together since Catra arrived, their friends are highly skeptical that this two-apartment situation will last. Scorpia asks Catra about it daily, Bow and Glimmer have already placed their bets, and Entrapta has devised a predictive algorithm to determine when they will officially move in together - on that note, her latest calculations indicate a time frame of 1 month, 9 days, 10 hours and 42 minutes.

Now it's really up to you to decide how seriously you will take this estimate, but experience has taught me *never* to doubt Entrapta's skills.

Not that it matters, anyway. Their friends can speculate all they want, Adora isnt really worried about how long it takes. For the first time in an excruciatingly *long* while, she isn't the least concerned about the future of their relationship. She's not making plans, nor is she thinking about what will become of the two of them from now on. She reckons they both deserve to just enjoy the simplicity of their present situation.

Catra lives in Bright Moon now, and Adora's heart can finally rest after such a lengthy journey.

She gets to be *here* - and here exclusively. In her bedroom, kissing her girlfriend to celebrate a trivial video game win, tugging at the

collar of her flannel shirt, so caught up in the moment she doesn't realize how hard she is pulling until Catra falls into her lap.

"Oops, *heh*, sorry about that," the blonde cocks a mischievous eyebrow, as she doesn't *really* regret having Catra sitting on top of her. "Got carried away, I guess."

"Yeah, don't worry, dummy, I didn't fall in love with you because of your finesse," Catra smiles, adjusting herself to sit properly on Adora's lap, one leg slung over either side of the chair, her arms over Adora's shoulders. "Besides, this turned out fine, don't you think?" Leaning forward, she nibbles the tip of Adora's ear then slides her tongue along the blonde's jawline. "I know I'm not complaining," she whispers softly.

Eyes ajar, Adora is moaning without even realizing it, already succumbing to the sensation of Catra's husky voice against her skin, the scorching tongue tracing a line across her throat, the long fingers gripping her hair and tugging at her scalp. "Mhmmm, yeah, I-uh"… The seated woman mumbles pathetically, closing her eyes and sinking further into the chair. "I-I can't complain about it either."

"Didn't think you would," Catra hums happily, leaving a soft peck on her lips and then sitting up straight. "So what's the plan? What are you in the mood for?" Her fingertips trace Adora's neck, collarbone, chest, and arm. "How would you like to celebrate such a sweeping and *astounding* victory, now that we're here?"

Something about the question makes Adora look up, and her heart staggers when she meets Catra's gaze. The repeated realization that they are *here*, that *Catra* is here – and that this time she is not leaving – strikes her as a miracle for the second time tonight. With an accomplished sigh, her gaze travels over her girlfriend's body, admiring her exquisite figure as both hands roam over her hips and find their way under her flannel shirt.

"I don't know," she scoffs, giddy from the sudden surge of serotonin, and her blue eyes would be watering with joy if they weren't so filled

with desire. Her thumbs curl into the waistband of Catra's sheer black panties. "We could stay in and, you know. Do something. Like, watch that gay pirate rom-com that Bow's been obsessed about lately," she suggests with mock casualness, all the while digging her hands into Catra's hip bone to pull her closer, sliding her onto her lap. "Or perhaps we could order some takeout at Meff's and watch an episode of Mara," she slips one hand between Catra's legs and over her panties; the other hand tugs harder on Catra's hips, rocking them back and forth against her skin.

"*Uhh*—" The unexpected contact has Catra gasping for a split second, but she's quick to appreciate the surprise. Readjusting herself, she smiles and then continues to rub against Adora's hand and thighs, silently accepting the implied invitation. "Well, yeah, sure... Those sound like two very solid options," she says, leaning on Adora's shoulders and snuggling deeper into her lap. "For one thing, you know how I feel about rom coms." Catra starts putting more force into the swings of her pelvis, finding a pleasant rhythm. "But then again, an episode of Mara is almost too irresistible to turn down," her voice almost breaks into another short gasp.

Adora is ready to melt right here, in the warmth of Catra's ass wiggling and squirming in her lap, in the wet stain growing on the thin fabric of her panties, in the soft brush of thighs and the pressure of her own hand, in the sound of Catra's heart pounding hard against her chest. "Mhm, yeah, uh—" She swallows sharply, feeling her cheeks get flushed as the pulse between her legs begins to throb with need. "I agree, yeah. *Absolutely* irresistible," she eyes Catra up and down, slightly tilting her hips to match her movements.

Her girlfriend flashes her a knowing grin. "Either way… *hmpf*, food will definitely be a priority soon," she cocks an eyebrow, a hand pressed against Adora's chest to help her maintain balance. "I know I'm getting hungry. Aren't you?"

The blonde snickers in response, her free hand roaming Catra's body, from her thigh to the back of her neck. "Starving, actually," she replies as she chases Catra's lips with her own.

They kiss, not at all gently - a confusion of tongues and hands and limbs trying to claim every bit of skin, every bit of flesh they can find. Adora can hear the chair scrape against the floor as they continue to rock vigorously against each other, she can feel her own arousal seeping through her boyshorts, and the warm beads of sweat pooling on her white tank top. Not pulling away, her hands blindly hold Catra's collar before moving down to undo the remaining buttons of her shirt.

When they part for air and Adora opens her eyes again, she's greeted by a stunning sight. Catra's cheeks are glistening with sweat, and some of her long brown curls cling to her shoulders. Her eyes have grown heavy and bright with lust, rolling up whenever the thrusts of her hips find that perfect spot in the middle of her thighs. Partially hidden beneath the plaid fabric, her breasts are bouncing slightly, her abdominal muscles twitching and relaxing, as if dancing to the muffled sounds of the pleasure they are producing.

Yes, starving is accurate.

"Wow," a wide-eyed Adora utters reflexively because she will be *damned* if this isn't the hottest, most gorgeous thing she's ever seen in her life. The image is taking her mind to countless possibilities - Catra riding her strap, the two of them cuddling in bed, Catra's lips between her legs, soft moans turning into screams. And maybe this unbelievably hot lap dance will lead them to one of these scenarios at some point, but Adora wouldn't dare rush it. She has no interest in skipping to the end.

Instead, she fixes her wide blue eyes on the tempting curves revealed before her. "I mean… *wow*," she licks her lips greedily .

At the spontaneous compliment, a spark of tenderness flickers in Catra's eyes just before they turn lecherous again. With a smirk, she leans back and shrugs her shoulders so that gravity takes care of her shirt. As the worn piece of clothing falls to the floor, Adora's hands are trembling with want.

Now in just her underwear , Catra slows down her movements before letting her torso fall further back to lay across the blonde's thighs. Propped up on her elbows, she stretches, putting her body completely at the disposal of Adora's worshipful gaze.

Exhaling sharply, Adora stares. Her chest is heaving and her mouth is dry as she runs her hand over Catra's covered sex, the taut abdomen, the gorgeous breasts, an arm around her back to make sure she's steady. "Fuck, you're handsome," she murmurs humbly , as reverently as her palm is caressing Catra's swollen nipple. "You're so beautiful that honestly... Sometimes I can't even believe you're real," she admits with a grin, lifting her girlfriend up again.

"How come?" Catra asks teasingly , readjusting herself on Adora's lap. "Don't tell me you're still afraid I'll turn into a pumpkin."

"No," Adora shakes her head slowly before placing a kiss on Catra's throat, one thumb stroking the skin beneath the waistband of her panties. "I'm not afraid."

But anymore.

"What then?" Catra runs her fingers over her flushed cheek, then tucks a strand of blonde hair behind her ear.

Half-naked, disheveled, and incredibly aroused, Adora lacks the competence to process her emotions into full sentences. For now, she hopes her eyes can express the happiness she finds in Catra's embrace, and that her hands can convey the relief she feels at the prospect of no longer needing to say goodbye.

"I think I'll just show you," Adora grins, her nails digging into her lover's bare back as she leans down to cup a breast between her lips, and she's certain that the conjunction of their bodies will give a more satisfying response than her words ever could.

*

10AM 10M

The door swings open and a bell rings as Catra and Scorpia walk through it. From her place behind the counter, a tall, broad-shouldered blonde flashes them a welcoming grin. A single look is enough for Catra to decide that she can't stand the woman, but luckily her opinion is irrelevant to their purposes. Refraining from taking another step forward, she shoves her hands into the pockets of her leather jacket.

Her best friend, however, is already running around the store, drooling over every plant on display. There's an excited expression on her face as she mumbles things like "oh wow" and "oh yeah, this is rare stuff."

"Good afternoon and welcome to the Heart Blossom!" The woman at the counter says, coming closer to Scorpia. "My name's Perfuma. How can I assist you today?"

"There you go," Catra pats Scorpia on the shoulder and finds a wall to lean on, as her friend is the only one interested in checking out this particular store. "Knock yourself out."

Scorpia grins. "Hey there! I've heard so many great things about your store!" She waves to Perfuma, who giggles bashfully in response. "Yeah, so, here's the thing, I'm looking for a plant" – and realizing the obviousness of what she just said, the professional rower bursts out laughing. "*Aha*, *duh*, I surely am - oh man, just look at this goofy lamb, standing in a freaking plant shop of all places, yeah. No, what I mean is I'm looking for a *specific* kind of plant..."

The two engage in conversation, which fades into the background when Catra feels her cell phone buzz inside her pocket.

"Hey!" An affectionate smile crosses Catra's face when a picture of Adora and her brother appears on the screen: the twins are grinning

like morons and pointing at the entrance sign at Eternia's main train station. *“Im getting on the train now and Adam wanted to say hi!”*

As her own mother did not offer her a good experience in this regard, Catra always felt that she was not a family person. Upon settling in Bright Moon, she understood that it wasn't *family* she didn't like, but rather a specific version of the concept, in which so-called gestures of love are indiscernible from possessiveness and control.

With Adora, she discovered that love can be something else entirely. And to her surprise, that also includes her family: Catra gets along well with Adora's brother, sister-in-law, and aunt - and, to a lesser extent, her parents.

“yeah, tell that idiot i said hi,” Catra types, almost regretting that she couldn't visit him that weekend, as the dates coincided with Scorpia's coming to Etheria for a canoe sprint championship. “so what time do u want me to pick you up?”

The novelist begins scrolling through their conversation history in search for a screenshot of the train ticket, but Adora's next message arrives before she finds it. *“I should be there in two hours or so. Try not to miss me too much until then 😚”*

Yeah, right. That ship has sailed since Adora left last Friday.

Catra sighs. “i dont know about me, but melog will be pleased to have you back ;)” She teases out of habit. “and scorpia, of course. we're at that plant shop you mentioned and she's been driving me fucking crazy asking about you.”

Seer is typing…

Since she mentioned Scorpia, Catra quickly scours the store looking for her best friend. She spots her in one of the aisles, a flower arrangement in her shopping cart, another in her hand. She's laughing at something the shopkeeper said, and from what Catra can tell, they're not talking about plants anymore.

Though vaguely intrigued by the interaction, she turns her attention to her cell phone when it vibrates again. *“Tell my beach volleyball buddy I’m coming! And Bummer and Bow invited us all for a picnic at the Fernian castle ruins later today . How does that sound?”*

Catra isn't particularly fond of picnics, but her chest fills with warmth at the rare possibility of having almost everyone she gives a fuck about in the same place and at the same time. “sounds like a plan, princess.”

The next message from Adora is a gif of a shiny horse, which is dork code to express great appreciation, the equivalent to some exaggerated adjective like *splendid* or *majestic* or whatever. *“It’s a date! I’ll save some battery now , but my train will arrive at platform 5 in 1 hour. Love you!”*

“I’ll be there,” Catra assures her , grateful for the fact that now they only need to be away from each other in occasional situations like this. “have a safe trip.”

And after grunting and rolling her eyes at her own cheesiness, she adds: “love you too.”

In the checkout line, Scorpia can't stop talking about how her moms are going to love the flower arrangement she's bringing them, how beautiful their apartment is going to look, and how Perfuma was kind enough to give her her number just in case she had any questions. About plants, of course. I mean, what else would it be?

Then she updates Catra with the latest news from Dovale - the bar that closed, the new park they built around the river, and the plays they are showing in the theater. The writer smiles nostalgically, listening to her friend talking about things and places that only months ago were part of her daily life, but which already feel like fragments of a past life.

Scorpia must have caught on to what she’s thinking, because when they're on their way to the train station, she asks if Catra misses

home.

The immediate answer that goes through Catra's mind is that she absolutely doesn't, but the truth is not that simple. After some pondering, she tries to explain. "I miss some things. The food. The weather, as incredible as it may sound," she chuckles and takes a deep breath before continuing. "You and Entrapta. To be able to visit you whenever I want. That coffee house around the corner from my place. The coffee here is a joke, by the way," she says as she looks for a spot to park near the entrance to Moonstone station. "But I don't know. I guess I don't think of it as *home* anymore," she turns off the engine.

Catra slams the car door and heads toward platform 511. Quickening her pace, Scorpia follows suit. They walk side by side, through the crowd, then up the escalator. "Oh yeah, definitely, I totally get what you're saying, Wildcat, and especially after I started competing abroad, I kind of feel the same way. Man, do I miss it sometimes, and *gosh*, I wish I could be closer to moms. But at the same time... I feel like my life is not really *there* anymore. Or like it's *there*, but not completely. You know?"

The two arrive at the platform's exit, where they stand to wait. The place is mostly empty and silent, just the soft howl of the wind blowing from the train tunnel. "Yeah," Catra looks at the big clock on top of the sign and checks that they are exactly on time. "I know."

The sound of the train approaching the station makes Catra's heart beat faster. The corner of her lip curls up.

*

Catra arrives first. She came straight from the cast meeting at Crystal Castle, while Adora had to stop by the apartment after class to give Swifty his heart medicine. It's okay. She doesn't mind waiting. Surrounded by stairs, bookshelves, small tables, ottomans, and benches, Catra looks for a comfortable place to sit, deciding on the soft red cushion under one of the huge trees around which the old

library was built. Once she's settled, she kicks off her shoes and takes her notebook out of her backpack in case inspiration strikes. Putting on her earbuds, she chooses a song.

She's focused on writing something when an additional cushion drops at her feet. She smiles before looking to her left, knowing she'll find Adora there. The blonde then sits next to her and leans against the tree trunk. "Sorry I'm late," she gives Catra a gentle kiss on the cheek.

Catra finishes the sentence she was writing and slides across the floor to snuggle into her girlfriend's chest. "I kept busy ," she shrugs, taking off her headphones. Meanwhile, Adora spreads her legs to better accommodate her, her arms wrapping around her waist;Catra turns to kiss her before letting her body relax over hers.

The Great Library of the Whispering Woods has become one of Catra's favorite spots in Etheria for quite predictable reasons. For one thing, she loves the smell of books mixed with fresh wood and the occasional aroma of hot coffee, and getting lost in the words of her favorite authors is always an efficient way to recharge after a long day. Also, in her first few months living in Bright Moon, this was one of the few public places where she felt completely at ease, where she could spend the whole afternoon undisturbed, without feeling like a foreigner. Once she shared her feelings about the place with Adora, the library gradually turned into one of their regular hangouts. Even now, more than a year later, coming here remains a tradition.

On cold days like this, Adora orders a hot chocolate and a cinnamon roll, while Catra asks for an espresso - if only to complain about how shitty the Etherian coffee is. Then they talk about their days, Adora shares something she learned in her graduate class, and Catra gives her an update on the development of the miniseries inspired by her book. They usually sit like this, Catra nestled against Adora's chest, but sometimes they reverse their positions so Catra can stroke Adora's hair or massage her back as she goes through her class notes or one of her patient records. They can spend hours having in-

depth discussions about lame reality shows or just sitting in silence, Catra flipping through books and occasionally reading some of her favorite passages aloud.

Today it was Adora who brought a book, and by the dumb look on her face, she's clearly feeling smart about her decision. "I don't know if you know this author, but she's just *excellent*," she announces with a silly tone. "Plus, I hear she has a kickass proofreader."

Catra chortles when she sees that Adora is talking about her own novel, only recently made available at the library. "Dumbass," she shakes her head and elbows her girlfriend's stomach. She might be laughing, but it actually means a lot to Catra to have something she wrote in a place she's grown to love, a place where she feels like she belongs, and to be able to read it with the person she belongs. Safe in Adora's arms, Catra is suddenly filled with a strong sense of accomplishment and gratitude for her journey—a journey that, in many ways, she shared with the woman who embraces her. "I hadn't even seen it," she says, taking the book in her hands. "Thanks."

"Well?" Adora asks smugly, her dorky grin getting dorkier by the second. "Aren't you going to read it to me, Force Captain? Or should I say, miss Kl ynx?"

It may sound ridiculous, but this simple suggestion moves Catra far more than she would have expected. She considers coming up with a clever retort, but on the sudden verge of tears, she just leans back and opens the book. Her cheeks are slightly tingling as she starts looking through the pages she's written, the pages that turned out to be the catalyst for one of the biggest changes in her life. When she chooses a paragraph she is particularly proud of, she clears her throat playfully and the forced sound turns into a laugh. Chuckling along with her, Adora hugs her tighter, and then rests her chin over her shoulder so she can also follow the lines. The first word that Catra says comes out choked and hoarse, but her voice regains its strength before she finishes that same sentence.

The sun begins to set as Catra continues. At the end of the page, she lies on the floor of the library to rest her head on Adora's lap. Their orders come in. Conversation shifts and flows as they eat and drink coffee and grumble about the cold outside. Between reading, bantering, and making plans to spend their next vacation in Half-Moon, they linger until night falls. If there are unread messages or emails waiting on their cell phones, they don't know. Neither of them bothered to look.


Remember

Art by the amazing Piritos (thousands of thanks to Ramenfever for commissioning it!)

Chapter End Notes

This story is my way of expressing how grateful I am for the fantastic people I've met in this fandom, no matter how far away they live.

For this last chapter, I'd like to give a special thank you to Machabubblecat, who unknowingly gave me the idea for the final scene.

To everyone who reads and writes spop fanfic, to everyone obsessed with a catgirl and her sword lesbian girlfriend, you have all my love.

End Notes

It's good to be back!I hope you enjoyed it :) If you did, give it some love!

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!